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Goings On

Theresa Hak Kyung Cha’s Linguistic Art

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***By** Hilton Als, Brian Seibert, Marina Harss, Dan Stahl, Rhoda Feng, Richard Brody, Sheldon Pearce, **and** Taran Dugal*

November 6, 2026

You’re reading the Goings On newsletter, a guide to what we’re watching, listening to, and doing this week. ***Sign up to receive it in your inbox.***

It’s taken me some days to write about Theresa Hak Kyung Cha’s show at Artists Space, because I didn’t want to face the fact that she’s no longer around to keep growing as an artist, a thinker, and a woman. Cha explored her deep interest in language among distinct cultures—including that of her native South Korea, where she grew up, and of the United States, where she moved, in 1962, when she was eleven—with video, performance, and multimedia installations. **“Theresa Hak Kyung Cha: Multiple Offerings”** (organized by the Berkeley Art Museum and Pacific Film Archive, and on through Nov. 21) is the first retrospective of Cha’s work in twenty-five years, and I can’t imagine a more beautiful curatorial vision. Everything about it—placement, context, sound, moving image—works to create a kind of holistic portrait of an artist who was as devoted to image as she was to language, and to show the ways in which each amplifies the other.



A slide from the multimedia installation "Other Things Seen, Other Things Heard," from 1978.Art work by Theresa Hak Kyung Cha / Courtesy Berkeley Art Museum and Pacific Film Archive

Indeed, her mysterious and uncategorizable book "Dictee," from 1982, features a number of women talking, ranging from Joan of Arc to the artist's mother, who lived through Japanese rule, when Korean could not be spoken in public. In "Dictee," and in her performances, many of which are featured in "Multiple Offerings," Cha's and other women's voices rise out of bodies that have lived through some form of oppression to come out on the other side as whole and true. One walks away from this historic show deeply moved by its singularity, and angry: in 1982, shortly before her first exhibition at Artists Space was scheduled to open, Cha, who was working on a series of photographs about her time employed at the Metropolitan Museum of Art, was murdered.—*Hilton Als*

About Town

Dance

The first part of "Adaku"—a dance-theatre trilogy by Okwui Okpokwasili and Peter Born that spools out a speculative vision rooted in a pre-colonial African village—ended with wailing, as a beloved daughter was caught up in the transatlantic slave trade. Part 2, **"She Shivers with It,"** which has its New York début at *BAM*, starts with that choral cry and fast-forwards into

an alternate present, tapping into embodied memory to trace the lineage of the lost daughter. Amid two hundred feet of snaking red coil, the ritualistic performance lingers in pain but also mines the humor in a magical hairdresser.—*Brian Seibert (BAM Fisher; Nov. 11-15.)*

Dance

Paul Taylor Dance Company has lately diversified its repertory considerably. This season includes new and recent pieces by the resident artists Robert Battle and Lauren Lovette; an example of mid-century psychedelia by Alwin Nikolais; and "Messengers, Maidens and the End of Something Else," by the jokey postmodernist Pam Tanowitz. A tongue-in-cheek exploration of the classical-music repertoire, the dance pairs the first and fourth movements of Schubert's "Death and the Maiden" quartet with a bright palette of movement and color. Those who come for Taylor will be rewarded with rare revivals of "Arabesque," from 1999, which is set to a Debussy composition that suggests prettiness but soon reveals something darker, and "Byzantium," from 1984, which probes the degenerate sides of society.—*Marina Harss (David H. Koch Theatre; through Nov. 22.)*

Broadway



From left, Crystal A. Dickinson, Hiram Delgado, and Bill Irwin in "The Imaginary Invalid."Photograph by Joan Marcus

Molière collapsed onstage while performing the lead role of his last play, **"The Imaginary Invalid,"** and died hours later. That it's a sendup of doctors and medicine is an irony worthy of its author. Brandon J. Dirden's revival, for Roundabout, features Bill Irwin (who also adapted the text from

Doug Skinner’s translation) as the lead: a perfectly healthy hypochondriac exploited by greedy, bullshitting physicians. Irwin’s performance is a marvel of physical and vocal comedy, complemented by Crystal A. Dickinson as his sweet-talking, gold-digging wife; Rachel Bloom as the sly servant who sees and fixes all; and a bloviating Brooks Ashmanskas, double-cast as two of the quacks. In its whirligig puncturing of pretense, this sumptuous production not only honors Molière’s spirit but makes it felt, offering us ninety minutes with him in comedy heaven.—*Dan Stahl (Haimes; through Nov. 22.)*

Off Broadway

In the new musical **“Midnight,”** Rail (Todrick Hall, who also wrote and directed), an enslaved Black man, falls in love with Richard (Jeremy Beloate), a white man he works for; in the second act, they swap social placements, so that Rail is the wealthy landowner and Richard the enslaved worker. (They remain in love.) Even if the songs go on twice as long as is necessary to the plot, the singing is a considerable pleasure, with Kennedy Caughell bringing a spirited assurance to her turn as Scarlet, an imperious Southern belle, while Charlotte Odusanya imbues Lily Rose—a young woman wooed by Rail’s “pretty eyes”—with a lambent sweetness. Hall’s ambitious show is concerned with racial legibility and manipulation, but he’s threading with a dull needle.—*Rhoda Feng (Daryl Roth; through Jan. 3.)*

Movies



Michelle Mao and Haley Lu Richardson in “Zi.”Photograph by Benjamin Loeb

Reappropriating the means of production after two elaborate movies, the director Kogonada filmed **“Zi”** in Hong Kong, shooting on the fly with a main cast of three and a scant crew to match. The results are as daring as the method; the title character, a Hong Kong-born violinist (Michelle Mao), is awaiting test results about a possible brain tumor. In a variation on Agnès Varda’s “Cléo from 5 to 7,” Zi has hallucinations—seeing flashes of her future self, as though mentally stuck in her own past—but a chance connection with an American wanderer (Haley Lu Richardson) and a Korean scientist (Jin Ha) offers hope: the trio’s lurching, passionate overnight ramble helps diagnose a metaphysical malady. The filmmaker’s ardently curious vision of the cityscape links inner lives to history, self-images to aesthetics.—*Richard Brody (Metrograph through Nov. 15, and in limited release.)*

Post-Punk

Since its inception, in 2019, the torrid band **Sweeping Promises** has been a project about the act of creating. Its partners, Lira Mondal and Caufield Schnug, started up on a whim when a jam sesh in an abandoned science lab conjured their first song, which became the title track for their 2020 début, “Hunger for a Way Out.” The band was imagined as a space beyond the duo’s other musical projects to “capture the exhilaration of writing songs in the moment,” as Mondal put it, and the music is governed primarily by impulses—it’s lo-fi and punk, possessing a free spirit and a resourceful nature. Their most recent album, “You Say I Romanticize,” reaffirms their core drive with songs more explicitly about committing to an artistic life.—*Sheldon Pearce (Baby’s All Right; Nov. 11.)*



Bar Tab

Taran Dugal excavates cocktails in Bushwick.



Illustration by Patricia Bolaños

Brooklyn night life is full of imposing figures: brutish bouncers, cool-kid carousers, the rare haughty bartender. But it wasn't until this summer's opening of **the Museum**, a low-lit cocktail lounge in Bushwick, that barflies had to contend with a T. rex—or, at least, a replica of one, whose skull is mounted on a table in the back room. On a recent weekend, three friends sat to the dino's right, trying their best to ignore his unmistakable glower. They'd begun their evening in the Gift Shop, a cozy parlor up front serving drinks and finger foods, before making their way through the establishment's Exhibition Hall, a narrow space lined with engraved skulls, Egyptian figurines, and a kaleidoscopic array of gemstones and crystals. In the back, the friends perused the menu, which consisted of cocktails inspired by different aspects of natural history. The most adventurous of the group ordered the Insectarium, an earthy honey-gin Negroni with a cricket-infused tincture, accompanied by a small piece of ant-ridden chocolate. The queasiest, looking away, opted for the Crystal Pass, a velvety Old-Fashioned incorporating oaky Scotch, bourbon, and mole sauce. The third friend, between sips of his Birds of the World (a tangy tequila-based concoction of elderflower, sunflower seeds, guava, and pineapple), began eavesdropping on a couple nearby, whose discussion had turned to mammalian politics. "Hyenas get a bad rep from 'The Lion King,' " a man said to his date, "but they're just kind of taking care of the leftovers, you know?" The eavesdropper, busy finishing a delectable pepper-chicken

skewer, couldn’t agree more. Eventually, the place emptied out, and the trio took their leave to the hazy groove of a Khruangbin track. After all, the sun had set, the T. rex was still glowering, and one can never be too careful in a museum at night.

P.S. Good stuff on the internet:

- *Seven generations of broom making*
- Tom Hiddleston says: close the toes
- *“Like a hug in a dish”*

An earlier version of this article misstated the venue where “Midnight” is playing.

Hilton Als, a staff writer at The New Yorker, won the 2017 Pulitzer Prize for criticism. He is the editor of “God Made My Face: A Collective Portrait of James Baldwin.”
Brian Seibert has been contributing to The New Yorker since 2002. He is the author of “What the Eye Hears: A History of Tap Dancing,” which won an Anisfield-Wolf Book Award. His writing appears in the New York Times and the New York Review of Books. A Guggenheim fellow, he teaches at Yale University.
Marina Harss has been contributing dance coverage to The New Yorker since 2004. She is the author of “The Boy from Kyiv: Alexei Ratmansky’s Life in Ballet.”
Dan Stahl is a member of The New Yorker’s editorial staff.
Rhoda Feng, who received the 2025 Nona Balakian Citation for Excellence in Reviewing, has also written about theatre and books for Artforum, the Boston Globe, and the Times Literary Supplement, among other publications.
Richard Brody, a film critic, began writing for The New Yorker in 1999. He is the author of “Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard.”
Sheldon Pearce is a music writer for The New Yorker’s Goings On newsletter.
Taran Dugal is a member of The New Yorker’s editorial staff.

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What We're Reading

The Best Mystery Novels of the Twenty-first Century

By ***Amy Davidson Sorkin***

October 28, 2026



Illustration by Greg Clarke

This is the What We're Reading newsletter, featuring book recommendations from our writers and editors. ***Sign up to receive it in your inbox.***

My usual beat for *The New Yorker* is political and legal commentary, and so I'll ask, in advance of listing my favorite recent mystery novels, for the forbearance of the genre's true specialists. I'm not the person who can say, for example, which of Louise Penny's twenty "Chief Inspector Gamache" novels is the best. ("*Still Life*," a friend tells me.) But there are overlaps in expertise: most of the best mysteries deal with the imperfect fit between the law and justice and with, as in politics, skewed balances of power, if only in the home, and the tension between public and private identities. I love the puzzles these kinds of books present. Here are four greats from the past twenty years, plus a bonus.

"*The Trespasser*," by Tana French

French has written ten novels (the “Dublin Murder Squad” sextet, the “Cal Hooper” trilogy, and one stand-alone), and the real debate is what order of greatness to put them in. Nine of them were chosen by readers for a recent *Times* list of the “Best Thrillers of the Century,” the most by any writer. “The Trespasser” is the only one that *didn’t* make that list. I stand by my pick. The book, about a young Irish woman murdered in her hard-won home, is the French novel that most often comes back to me unbidden. I’ve sometimes taken it off the shelf just to reread the final interrogation scene.

“*When Will There Be Good News?*” by Kate Atkinson

As with French, there is a lot of good Atkinson in the mystery (and non-mystery) department. “When Will There Be Good News?” is the third in her “Jackson Brodie” series, and an exemplar of her narrative control over chaos. Set mostly in Scotland, the book involves the disappearance of a woman and her baby in the long wake of a family murder. Reggie Chase, a babysitter who pulls Brodie into the case, returns as a detective herself in later Atkinson novels.

“*The Girl with the Dragon Tattoo*,” by Stieg Larsson

Its rich afterlife alone might earn this novel a place on the list: much imitated (and parodied); an accelerant in the rise of Nordic Noir; the template for a certain kind of hacker-detective; the basis for two sequels and two movies. And yet, upon first reading, I was ambivalent—put off in part because of all the hype but also, perhaps, because of what the book seemed to present as the available responses to sexual trauma. When I picked it up again this summer, though, I found it more nuanced, engaging, and multilayered than I had remembered.

“*Wild Dark Shore*,” by Charlotte McConaghy

This one is a bit of a wild card, a crossover into the climate-fiction genre. The setting is a scientific station on an Antarctic island that must be evacuated because of rapidly rising sea levels—a locked-seed-bank mystery, one might say. A shipwrecked woman confronts the enigma of a missing researcher, an unexplained grave, beached whales, and the question of what can or should be saved. It is, in many ways, a counterweight to

“The Girl with the Dragon Tattoo,” offering a very different vision of resilience.

And the bonus: **“*Women Crime Writers: Eight Suspense Novels of the 1940s & 50s*.”** The novels in this boxed set (including Vera Caspary’s “Laura,” Dorothy B. Hughes’s “In a Lonely Place,” and Patricia Highsmith’s “The Blunderer”) are outside this list’s time frame, but the grouping (edited, with notes, by Sarah Weinman) is new. Mid-century America could be an awfully unsettling place.



Our editors and critics choose the most captivating, notable, brilliant, surprising, absorbing, weird, thought-provoking, and talked-about books. **Find your next great read »**

On Our Radar

- “The Mosquito Bowl,” starring Nicholas Galitzine, Bill Skarsgård, Ray Nicholson, and Tom Francis, is in theatres this weekend. Based on *Buzz Bissinger’s book* of the same name, it’s about a football game that took place during the Second World War, between the 4th and the 29th Marine Regiments.
- Set in Ireland in the nineteen-eighties and tracing the complicated connection between a pair of teen-age friends, “*Stations*,” by Louise Kennedy, which comes out on November 3rd, has made its way onto many lists of anticipated works.
- Gary Shteyngart’s first collection of personal essays will be published on the 17th, and the title says it all: “*The Sensualist: Adventures in Pure Pleasure*.”

P.S. Min Jin Lee recommends “*Jane Eyre*,” by Charlotte Brontë, because, *she says*, “the capacity to know a character so intimately of this era is really unusual, and so beautiful.”

Amy Davidson Sorkin has been a staff writer at The New Yorker since 2014. She has been at the magazine since 1995, and, as a senior editor for many years, focussed on national security, international reporting, and features.

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The Talk of the Town

- **Breaking the Decade-Long Trump Fever**
  By David Remnick | The President's unique brand of lurid authoritarianism has finally lost appeal, and he has lost the plot.
- **John Cusack Goes Graphic**
  By Emma Allen | At the comic-book store Forbidden Planet, the "Say Anything" actor talks about his new graphic novel, in which the philosopher-artist Antonin Artaud is freed from an asylum by Jackie Gleason.
- **I'll Take Blue Florida for Five Hundred**
  By Charles Bethea | Not all bets are made with big money. On the night of the midterms, one small Kalshi wagerer puts his chump change—and his sanity—on the line.
- **Hilary Knight Is Rawther Beloved**
  By David Kamp | At the hundredth-birthday party of the illustrator of the "Eloise" books, testimonials poured in from such pals as Bernadette Peters, Anderson Cooper, and the reputed inspiration for Eloise herself, Liza Minnelli.
- **Josh Homme Likes to Satan**
  By Amanda Petrusich | On the heels of a new album from the rock band Queens of the Stone Age, the group's front man spends some quality time with Linda Blair's "Exorcist" character.

Comment

Breaking the Decade-Long Trump Fever

The President’s unique brand of lurid authoritarianism has finally lost appeal, and he has lost the plot.

By David Remnick

November 7, 2026

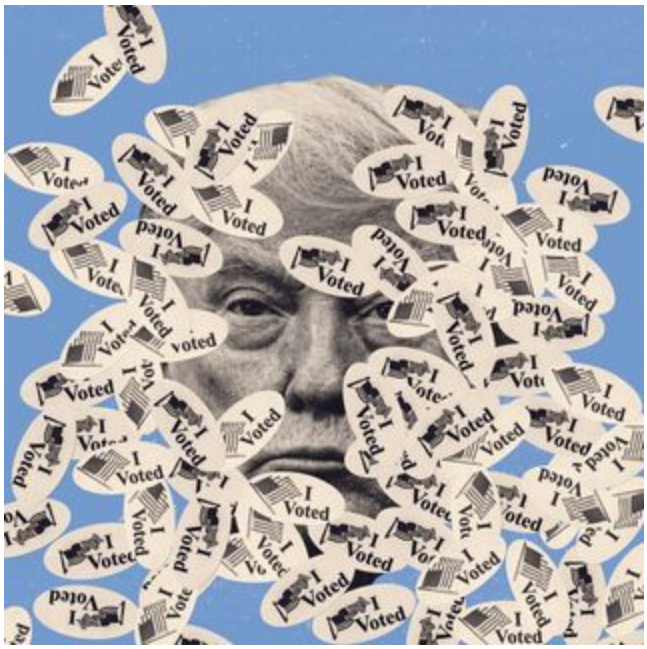


Photo illustration by Cristiana Couceiro; Source photographs from Getty

Two generations ago, in the fall of 1974, President Gerald Ford and the Republican Party approached the midterm elections with considerable dread. That August, Richard Nixon had learned that he could no longer outrun his crimes in the White House. One tape recording in particular, the so-called smoking gun, proved that he had conspired with his aide H. R. Haldeman to obstruct the investigation into the Watergate break-in. The Republican elders Barry Goldwater, John Rhodes, and Hugh Scott told Nixon that impeachment in the House of Representatives was now certain, and conviction in the Senate likely. Nixon resigned, handing over his office

to Vice-President Ford. A month later, Ford issued Proclamation 4311, pardoning Nixon for any crimes that he might have committed as President. Watergate, Ford said, had been “an American tragedy, in which we all have played a part. It could go on and on and on, or someone must write the end to it. I have concluded that only I can do that, and if I can, I must.”

Until then, despite a dreadful economy, Ford had enjoyed approval ratings as high as seventy per cent. But the Nixon pardon was political poison, for both Ford and the G.O.P. His popularity plummeted by more than twenty points. And, in the midterms, the Democrats gained forty-nine seats in the House and four seats in the Senate. The incoming class of rookie Democrats—among them Gary Hart, Paul Tsongas, John Glenn, and Patrick Leahy—became known as the “Watergate babies.”

This week, some commentators, having exhausted the usual marine metaphors for midterm blowouts (a “blue wave” quickly became a “blue tsunami”), scurried to find historical points of comparison for the astonishing nationwide triumph of the Democratic Party. More than a few settled on the post-pardon midterms of 1974.

In sheer magnitude, this week’s Democratic victory—a sweeping repudiation, above all, of Donald Trump and the low, dishonest decade he has defined—makes the post-Watergate humbling seem modest. Both houses of Congress flipped, giving Democrats a substantial majority in each. The new Senate Majority Leader needn’t worry if, say, John Fetterman strolls across party lines. Nine of the ten most populous states will have Democratic governors. For those already anticipating the Presidential race in 2028, it’s significant that all the traditional battleground states (which Trump won just two years ago) have elected Democratic governors. The Party scored in unlikely places, particularly in the Midwest and the South. Texas, the second most populous state in the Union and reliably red for a generation, will have a Democratic senator (James Talarico), governor (Gina Hinojosa), and state House. Kansas—seriously, *Kansas*—elected a Democrat to the Senate for the first time in ninety-four years. Democrats also chalked up amazing wins in both Carolinas. The geographic shift was as pronounced as the demographic one. After moving toward Trump in 2024, many Latinos swung Democratic; so did many

young white men. (Thanks for rethinking things, Joe Rogan!) And Black voters came out for Democratic candidates in huge numbers.

The diversity of “firsts” was heartening. The first Muslim in the Senate: Abdul El-Sayed, of Michigan. The first Black female governor: Keisha Lance Bottoms, in Georgia. The first Latino governors to be elected in Texas (Hinojosa) and California (Xavier Becerra). New Mexico will have the first female Native American governor (Deb Haaland), and Minnesota will send the first Native American woman ever to the Senate (Peggy Flanagan). Even the near-misses were stunners. In ruby-red Florida, a Black democratic socialist named Angie Nixon almost became a senator. (And maybe she would have won had she gotten more funding, or had she been three jots less far to the left—hard to know.) This all happened after years in which the President and the Vice-President have deployed racist epithets, jokes, and myths. (“In Springfield, they’re eating the dogs! . . . They’re eating the cats!”) Laura Loomer, a court bigot for the Administration, made the Trumpian ideology clear when she wrote on X, “America was always intended to be a majority White country. Not a cesspool for third world minorities. America was founded as a Christian country. Not a Muslim country.” The midterms dealt that foul idea its greatest blow since Barack Obama’s ascent to the Presidency, in 2008.

The scale of the victory left no room for Trump to contrive a conspiracy theory and challenge the outcome. On Election Night, he was, by his perverse standards, gracious. He blamed Fox News for the Republican losses, “by constantly and consistently putting on the Dumocrat opposition.” Separately, he claimed, “I wasn’t on the Ballot and if I was, we would have won IN A LANDSLIDE!” #Classic.

The results were driven by the most urgent economic concerns of the voters: the spike in fuel prices, which followed the misbegotten tariffs and the war in Iran; the high cost of groceries, housing, and health care; and, for some, anxiety about data centers, artificial intelligence, and what all this portends for employment. But what is so striking about Trump’s second term is that he entered office intent, it now seems, on flaunting his cynicism, his greed, and his scorn for the American people. It was as if he actually meant to squander his support as quickly as possible. How else to

explain the heedlessness of his behavior in office? On Day One, he gave pride of place at the Inauguration to a lineup of moguls who had agreed to bow to his power and his ego. They regularly traipsed to the White House, delivering gaudy house gifts and large donations to his pet projects. They smiled weakly as they were compelled to listen to his moronic rants and admire the latest *ungapatchka* embellishment of the gilded Oval Office. They spent tens of millions of dollars on his wife's documentary about how taxing it is to endure the attentions of the help and how lonely it is to shuttle from one place to the next in limousines and private planes. As in any tin-pot autocracy, this was the price of doing business. Trump's populism was always a fraud. Now he plainly didn't care who knew. At a "jungle-themed" Halloween party at Mar-a-Lago, costumed guests enjoyed seafood delicacies and a caviar bar. There was a caged zebra. Circus performers dangled from the ceiling. "Rich people, they spend nine hours getting ready," the President merrily remarked of his pals. He was dressed in his usual blue suit. "I had ten minutes, so I came as Donald Trump."

Trump has shown contempt for the law, as he hollowed out the Department of Justice and ordered federal agents to menace American cities from New York to Minneapolis to Los Angeles. He has shown contempt for culture and education, as he threatened and defunded one invaluable institution after another. He has shown contempt for competence, by stocking his Administration with preposterous, often odious, fourth-raters: Pete Hegseth, Kash Patel, Robert F. Kennedy, Jr., Kristi Noem, Stephen Miller (incredibly, the new chief of staff), the Son-in-Law, the Ubiquitous One with the portable printer.

Abroad, Trump's contempt for restraints on his power has been equally conspicuous. The United States' closest allies found themselves coping with his arbitrary tariffs, his threats to shatter alliances, and his periodic intimations of invasion. What was the world to make of an American President who, with immense self-satisfaction, slathered praise on dictators like Vladimir Putin, Viktor Orbán, and Xi Jinping, while seeking to humiliate heroic democrats like Volodymyr Zelensky? Trump ordered his government to invade Venezuela, imprison its President, elevate a more compliant one, and start extracting that nation's oil and gold. It was a

regression to an earlier era of U.S. imperialism, when military intervention in Latin America was a standard instrument of Presidential power.

The most consequential result of the midterms has been to break the fever of Trumpism and to diminish its threat to democratic institutions, to personal and civil liberties, and to decency itself. Trump's unique brand of lurid authoritarianism has finally lost appeal, and he has lost the plot. The election was also a vindication for those who had refused to submit. We are all too familiar by now with the many politicians, law partners, billionaires, C.E.O.s, university presidents, and others who cowered before Trump. Part of the reason we will survive the Trump era is that many more did their work honorably. Judges, civil-rights lawyers, academics, election officials, curators, artists, and countless ordinary citizens stood up. Their resistance to Trump's bullying, corruption, and heartlessness has gained new political force.

After the midterms, the White House issued a "PSA" on social media: "Trump is still your president." That is useful information. While he remains in office, his party is unlikely to rid itself of its cultlike obedience. J. D. Vance, his would-be successor, believes that he can win in two years simply by acknowledging the folly of going to war with Iran, while still aping the cruelty and dogma of his mentor. It is Vance's conviction, he has said, that "Donald Trump will ultimately decide who's going to be the Republican nominee."

This is a moment of enormous relief and celebration. Trump can still do damage, and, in defeat, may prove even more unhinged and vengeful. But restraints in Congress and beyond are now far stronger. This aging autocrat, repudiated by an electorate he once believed to be under his spell, has been significantly weakened.

The Watergate babies arrived in Washington in 1975 resolved to transform American politics; when Jimmy Carter, a moderate Democrat, won the Presidency, their prospects seemed to brighten even more. Yet, just six years after their great electoral triumph, Ronald Reagan, a right-wing ideologue, was elected President and the Republicans captured the Senate. The reformers of 1974 found themselves defending gains they had expected to build on. They had helped change Washington, but the country was

changing in ways they struggled to understand. The next Congress will succeed not through an obsession with retribution and punishment but by delivering on the myriad hopes and demands of the voters who elected its members. The Democrats of 2026 have won an extraordinary opportunity. What they make of it will determine what this election means. ♦

David Remnick has been the editor of The New Yorker since 1998 and a staff writer since 1992. He is the author of seven books; the most recent is "Holding the Note," a collection of his profiles of musicians.

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Permanent Rebellion

John Cusack Goes Graphic

At the comic-book store Forbidden Planet, the “Say Anything” actor talks about his new graphic novel, in which the philosopher-artist Antonin Artaud is freed from an asylum by Jackie Gleason.

By Emma Allen

November 9, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

*You’re reading **The Talk of the Town**: fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond.*

For the actor John Cusack to deliver an apathetic Cameo performance—Cameo being the service through which regular people hire famous people to make short videos wishing a friend happy birthday, or whatever—feels

like the most John Cusack-character thing that John Cusack could do. But “the internet” (meaning Threads) recently turned against him for phoning it in on Cameo. Cusack, however, at sixty years old, still gets plenty amped up about the things that actually interest him.

Things that currently interest John Cusack include politics, fringe philosopher-artists, and graphic novels, one of which he recently published. “Momo,” illustrated by Ignacio Noé, is Cusack’s noirish seventies road-trip romp about the philosopher-artist Antonin Artaud (per Cusack: “sovereign of the absurd, master of the irrational, lord of the permanent rebellion”), who spent years in French mental institutions. Cusack’s book imagines a scenario in which Artaud fakes his own death and is sprung from an asylum by Jackie Gleason, who then accompanies him and Richard Nixon to the Homestead Air Force Base to check out embalmed alien heads. After that, things get really weird.

The other day, at Forbidden Planet, a comic-book store near Union Square, Cusack, dressed in black (uniform, not disguise), moved easily among young punks in plaid and Doc Martens and clerks in ironic tees. He said that the artist Damien Hirst (whom he met in the nineties, with Joe Strummer) had turned him on to Noé’s work. “You can always go to Damien and get this Wonka world,” Cusack said, in his flat, gravelly voice, punctuated by a slow lemur blink. He recalled, “Last time I was at his place, he had bought a graveyard in Scotland. And he was building a house out of the headstones. I said, ‘It’s going to be haunted.’ And he said, ‘It will be when I’m fucking done with it.’ ”

Cusack perused the shelves. “I read ‘Dr. Strange,’ ” he said. “I love the old ‘Creepshow,’ ‘Daredevil.’ ” “Momo” takes place in 1972, when Cusack was six. “But I remember stuff,” he said. “Elvis was on TV, Watergate.” The book came pretty easy: “It was like writing a script, except I had to negotiate a lot less with anybody else. It was like a movie that only existed in my mind.”

He stood in front of boxed, beefy action figurines and opined on Artaud, who, notably, had freaked out even his Surrealist contemporaries. “He just went all the way,” Cusack said. “And what he wanted was always almost impossible—he wanted performance to be a magic spell. I always thought

he was this great avatar that represented success and failure—failure mostly. Like Sid Vicious but much more talented. I always thought that, in a way, he was a wizard."

What would an Artaud action figure look like? (He's known to have had a "magic" walking stick.) Cusack studied a Starman figurine and mused, "I think if we did monetize Artaud as an action figure, he would come out of the primordial abyss and stomp on me." He walked past a doormat that read "*GODZILLA WAS HERE*" and featured a big reptilian footprint.

Heading up Broadway—a former stomping ground, from his N.Y.U. days—Cusack pointed. "That used to be a theatre," he said. "There was a play where everybody was on wires. They used to come down and grab you."

He settled in at a table at Union Square Café, removing his cap and ruffling his hair. "Môm o," he explained, was a moniker that Artaud gave himself: "It was some alter ego or something." Cusack said that none of his friends call him by his name. "People called me Carl for a long time," he said. "Or Doctor, like, a self-proclaimed doctor of whatever." He ordered an "iced-tea lemonade." "Like an Arnold Palmer?" the waitress asked.

Cusack is a board member of the Freedom of the Press Foundation, which once had Edward Snowden as its board president. Cusack, with the author Arundhati Roy and the Pentagon Papers releaser Daniel Ellsberg, visited Snowden in Moscow in 2014. The surrealism of this cross-continental road trip was not lost on Cusack: "I'm an artist, a post-punk American weirdo! Ed and Dan are both like Oliver Stone—believers who defected."

Talk turned to politics in Hollywood. Cusack described a dispiriting lack of "uncomfortable truths, versus those that reassure you." His comfort watch: "Sovereign-citizen body-cam things—Joe Rogan guys who get pulled over by the cops and argue, 'I don't need a license. I don't need plates. I don't need stickers. This is my property. I'm not driving, I'm travelling, and you cannot enter this car.' " The cops tend to feel differently.

"It's my guilty pleasure," Cusack said. He added, "You don't even have to agree with something or be on board with it. You just appreciate the fact that it's not formatted and sanitized." ♦

Emma Allen is The New Yorker's cartoon editor and edits humor pieces on newyorker.com.

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Political Econ

I’ll Take Blue Florida for Five Hundred

Not all bets are made with big money. On the night of the midterms, one small Kalshi wagerer puts his chump change—and his sanity—on the line.

By **Charles Bethea**

November 7, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

*You’re reading **The Talk of the Town**: fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond.*

The midterm elections furnished prediction markets with nearly two billion dollars in bets, a tidy sum for a teetering democracy. A Los Angeles-based trader named David Bensoussan, whose day job is in real estate and whose politics are left of center, bet more than a million and a half dollars on upward of a dozen outcomes, including the Democrat James Talarico winning the Texas Senate race ($114,000) and Democrats controlling the House ($662,000).

Most bettors put less on the line. Andrew Schaefer, a forty-two-year-old father in Orlando, Florida, who helps people out of tax messes, also likes to wager on elections. He tends to vote Republican, but clarified that he is "not someone who thinks Q talks to him in his dreams." Of political betting, he said, "It's a hobby for many, a side business for some, and just a way to bet on red versus blue for the majority. Then, there are people like me, who are, like, 'There's money that's still chasing the shoo-in candidate but not pricing in the tail risk.' " Translation: most bettors were picking the favorites and undervaluing upsets. Schaefer continued, "There's lots of money on the sidelines from bettors who did well in the previous cycle, and now they're a little bit looser with it, so they're going to bet on the team they always bet on." In other words, they're partisan bettors. "That's when there are opportunities," he said. "It's a game of chess."

Schaefer wasn't going to bet only on his team; he'd won more than thirty thousand dollars in two of the past three Presidential elections, largely by putting his money on Donald Trump in 2016, when it made sense to do so, and by not betting on a Trump blowout in 2020, when it didn't. Early on Election Day, Schaefer posted on X that 2016 and 2020 "were 'leave the casino way up' moments for me." Of wagering this year, he said, "It's just one drink, for old time's sake." He decided to put money on the Florida gubernatorial race. He chose David Jolly, a former G.O.P. congressman turned Democrat who faced Byron Donalds, a Black *MAGA* congressman.

"I've got a thousand bucks to play around with," Schaefer said. His rationale for placing five hundred on the Florida race: "When I put the money down, a couple of hours ago, it was, like, a thirty-eight-per-cent chance that Jolly would win. I would say it's more like fifty per cent." Donalds's nomination felt to Schaefer "like an anointment, not a choice."

He went on, “Donalds hasn’t campaigned well, hasn’t debated, and isn’t particularly experienced.” Schaefer planned to hedge with some smaller plays: the Senate races in Kansas and Texas, he reckoned, would both go Republican. He put a hundred on each, believing that market pricing had been skewed by “blue-team money sloshing around.”

“I have absolutely no idea about the Kansas candidates for the Senate,” Schaefer admitted. “I feel like I’m the Area Man from *The Onion* who’s, like, ‘Well, actually, I’m a firefighter—but I do bet about twelve thousand a year on pro sports.’ ”

On Election Day, Schaefer had a lot going on at work and a very pregnant wife to tend to. She wasn’t interested in his bets. “Not looking good,” Schaefer said via text, appending a laughing-crying emoji, when he saw the early returns from Florida: Donalds was closing the gap on Jolly’s early lead. “But that’s the thing with playing the odds,” he went on. “If a bet is underpriced at 65% when it should be 50%, you’re still going to lose half the time.”

Donalds won; Schaefer lost. The good news: his two other bets—which would have been losers—were never filled. He texted, “The fun thing about prediction markets is that you can lose $500 yet manage to convince yourself that . . . you were actually smart for losing $500!” Still, he said, it was his worst political-betting performance ever. He wasn’t alone in drawing one conclusion from his bad night: “Trump has been quite the disappointment.” ♦

Charles Bethea, a staff writer focussing on the American South, has contributed to The New Yorker since 2008.

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Dept. of Milestones

Hilary Knight Is Rawther Beloved

At the hundredth-birthday party of the illustrator of the “Eloise” books, testimonials poured in from such pals as Bernadette Peters, Anderson Cooper, and the reputed inspiration for Eloise herself, Liza Minnelli.

By David Kamp

November 9, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

*You’re reading **The Talk of the Town**: fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond.*

It’s not often that you meet someone whose painting instructor was Reginald Marsh, the New York City social-realist artist of the Jazz Age who also happened to be one of this magazine’s first cartoonists. But Hilary

Knight, an illustrator most celebrated for his work on the “Eloise” books, was genially holding forth about Marsh from his wheelchair the other day, on the patio of a restaurant in Sierra Madre, California.“I learned so much from him,” Knight said. “He was drunk all the time but a great teacher.”

It was Knight’s hundredth birthday, and a small party had been organized by a niece, Lily Knight. Hilary, a diminutive man with no children of his own, moved in with Lily in 2018, when, because of age-related limitations, he became unable to maintain his homes in Manhattan and East Hampton.

Though Knight remains mentally and verbally sharp, his hearing isn’t what it used to be. At the restaurant, Lily distributed pink notepads and Sharpies, so that guests could pose questions and offer tributes. Knight responded either verbally or in writing.

Does he still draw?

“Not as much as I should,” he said. “My parents were both great artists. My mother was a naturalist and a real inspiration to me. She needed to draw to keep going. I should be doing the same thing.”

Had he heard that the Plaza, the hotel where Eloise resides in the books—and where tourists regularly visit Knight’s portrait of her, insouciantly posing in the lobby with her pug, Weenie, and her turtle, Skipperdee—will be closed for at least four years?

Knight’s eyes widened with alarm: “No! Why on earth would they do that?”

Renovations to the façade, mostly.

“God, I hope they find a safe place to keep my painting.” (In 1988, when Donald Trump bought the hotel, Eloise fans worried that she might be evicted.)

The party guests included Lily’s twin, Kitty; their brother, Chris; and a strapping young towhead named Alvin, who amused his great-great-great-uncle Hilary with his Eloise-like mischievousness. There were also some swells and characters from Knight’s old life who had flown in from New

York, among them the mustachioed pianist and historian Peter Mintun and the musician, artist, and downtown fixture Phoebe Legere, who, to Knight's delight, had dressed up in a sequinned minidress, fish-net tights, and a plumed fedora.

Knight himself has always been, as Eloise might say, *rawther* fond of visual whimsy and extravagance. He wore amber-tinted glasses, a bird-print shirt, and a baseball cap to which a spray of peacock feathers had been affixed. The feathers were a nod to Knight's love of India, a country he adores but has not—yet—had the opportunity to visit.

Legere led the crowd in "Happy Birthday" as a cake was carried out. There followed a reading of testimonials from absent friends: Bernadette Peters, Anderson Cooper, the British actress Sally Hawkins, and Liza Minnelli, whose godmother was the singer and actress Kay Thompson, the author of the Eloise books. Minnelli is believed to have been at least a partial inspiration for Eloise.

"In 1955, you and my beloved Kay Thompson introduced the world to a little girl named Eloise, and nothing has been quite the same since," Minnelli wrote. "Seventy-one years later, Eloise is still six years old, the Plaza is still her playground, and your drawings remain as enchanting as ever. What a magnificent legacy. What a magnificent life."

There is a new live-action "Eloise" movie in the works, directed and co-written by Amy Sherman-Palladino. Knight has mixed feelings about this. Hawkins, who became his friend after he admired her performance in Guillermo del Toro's "The Shape of Water," is in the film, which is a mark in its favor. "But I've seen images from the set, of Eloise as a real girl, which is kind of strange," Knight said. "Eloise isn't real! She's a fantasy, an invention. That's what I like about her."

As the party entered its third hour, the New Yorkers, jet-lagged, made their apologies and headed out. The birthday boy, however, showed no sign of fatigue. He commandeered one of the pink notepads and wrote the following:

WHO is ready
To go to INDIA
With me—
I will guarantee
Elephant rides
curry dinners ♦

David Kamp is the author of "Sunny Days: The Children's Television Revolution That Changed America."

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The Musical Life

Josh Homme Likes to Satan

On the heels of a new album from the rock band Queens of the Stone Age, the group's front man spends some quality time with Linda Blair's "Exorcist" character.

By Amanda Petrusich

November 9, 2026



Illustration by João Fazenda

*You're reading **The Talk of the Town**: fun, fizzy dispatches from the city and beyond.*

Josh Homme, a guitarist and vocalist in the art-rock band Queens of the Stone Age, paid a visit to Regan MacNeil, the demonically possessed adolescent girl at the center of the 1973 film "The Exorcist," the other day.

Actually, it was an animatronic-doll version of Regan, complete with head-whirling, and it was on display in a Plexiglas box at the Museum of the Moving Image, in Astoria. Somehow, the doll's bleached-out eyeballs seemed to follow a visitor around the room.

Homme, who is fifty-three years old, first saw "The Exorcist" when he was twelve. His parents weren't home. "My brother was supposed to watch me, and, of course, he didn't," he said. "I started it at around six-thirty. The sun went down, and I'm in my parents' waterbed, just gently jiggling. Sheets and blankets pulled up to my nose. And this movie just *happened* to me. I couldn't get up." He continued, " 'The Exorcist' deals with things that are sort of esoterically possible: possession, the Devil. I had a pretty sincere Christian upbringing, so it seemed like nonfiction. To me, this was a documentary."

In an adjacent gallery, an exhibition on Jim Henson's Muppets was visible. Homme looked up from Regan and locked eyes with Kermit the Frog. "Oh, shit!" he said. "Seeing all this horror stuff and then looking over at Kermit, it feels like Kermit's doing something dark."

Homme founded Queens of the Stone Age in 1996, shortly before he returned to his home town of Palm Desert, a sunbaked oasis in the Coachella Valley. "I grew up right where the desert starts," he said. "There are pine forests at the top of Mt. San Jacinto, in Palm Springs. It's snowy, and then the snow melts and it comes down, and that's right where the desert begins. I love transition, the braiding together of worlds. I think that's where the interesting stuff is."

His songwriting has always embraced heavy and devious themes: lust, death, menace. The day before Halloween, the band released its ninth album, "Perfecth." It's a record about making reluctant peace with love gone asunder—"Letting go of you is beautiful," Homme sings—and it was inspired, in part, by an acoustic show that the band played in the Paris catacombs, a subterranean ossuary containing the bones of about six million people, in 2024. "There's a lot of gravel on the floor, so you crunch your way through," Homme said. "It makes you feel really insignificant, which makes me feel comfortable." He went on, "I took a dark alleyway and got on my knees and said, 'I promise to try as hard as I can.' It was very special

to be alive there.” At the time, Homme was dealing with some health issues, and the band would soon cancel a tour. “The line between where they were at and where I was at—it felt paper thin,” he said, of the piled-up bones.

These days, Homme likes to watch horror movies with his twenty-year-old daughter, Camille. “She calls it Satan-ing,” he said. “She’s, like, ‘Do you want to Satan tonight?’ We just scratch each others’ arms and eat popcorn. I can tell it’s soothing to her, and it’s my chance to get unadulterated time—kid-straight-off-the-tap is hard to come by.” He finds the experience of being frightened cathartic, even calming: “You get on a roller coaster, and by the time you get off all anxiety is gone. It’s been replaced with adrenaline, endorphins. Jump scares flush the body of anxiety.”

At the museum, Homme paused to examine a vomit device that, on the set of “The Exorcist,” was attached to the actress Linda Blair, who played Regan. It resembled a single-jointed horse bit, with plastic tubing at the center; this was glued to Blair’s face and then concealed under prosthetics and makeup. Crew members fed bile-colored porridge into a hand-cranked pump hidden under her bed. Homme marvelled at the mechanics of the thing. “I think, nine times out of ten, the fascination with horror is that it lets us deal with death in a way that’s a little campier. It initiates a conversation,” he said. “Modern society kind of tells you not to look at the sky. *Don’t think about death*, especially in the United States. *Sweep it under the rug*. But sending someone off into the ether, into the great parent that made us, should be revered and ritualized.” ♦

Amanda Petrusich is a staff writer at The New Yorker and the author of “Do Not Sell at Any Price: The Wild, Obsessive Hunt for the World’s Rarest 78rpm Records.”

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- **An N.B.A. Player Got Hooked on Sports Betting. Soon, He Became the Bet**
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American Chronicles

Can American Socialism Survive Its Success?

The movement has often seen its ideas flourish as its organizations withered. Will today's resurgence follow the same course?

By Jill Lepore

November 9, 2026



In 1912, more than a thousand socialists held office in the United States. Their ambitions ranged from lowering trolley fares to abolishing the Senate.Photo illustration by Matt Dorfman; Source photographs from Library of Congress; Getty

It was American socialism's best year ever. In 1912, the Socialist Party of America tallied a hundred and twenty thousand members, and newsstands groaned under the weight of some three hundred socialist papers and magazines, including the Kansas-based *Appeal to Reason*, which had three-quarters of a million subscribers and was committed to the belief that "socialism is not just a theory—it is a destiny." Socialists were winning elections, carried to victory by voters furious at trusts and corporations and millionaires and oligarchs, whose monopoly on political power rested on a

two-party system indifferent to labor's demands and on a breathtakingly conservative Supreme Court. (In 1895, the Court declared a federal income tax to be unconstitutional; in 1905, it said the same of a law limiting the number of hours in a workday.) Year by year, socialists had gained strength. In 1910, the Milwaukee newspaperman Victor Berger, who had founded the Socialist Party with the Indiana railroad-union leader Eugene V. Debs, in 1901, became the first socialist elected to Congress: he vowed to abolish the Senate. In 1911, a socialist mayor was elected in Schenectady, New York. "We know that we cannot abolish the capitalist system in Schenectady," he said at his inauguration. But "we can and will demonstrate to all the spirit of socialism and the application of socialist principles insofar as possible with the handicap of laws framed to establish and sustain capitalism." (He pledged to lower trolley fares.) In 1912, Debs ran as the Socialist Party candidate for President and called for an end to "wage slavery." Across a great striving land of fields of wheat and corn, and factories of steel and automobiles, and mines of coal and copper and iron, more than a thousand socialists held office, including fifty-six mayors (of cities as different as Berkeley, California, and Flint, Michigan), a hundred and sixty city councilmen, and a hundred and forty-five aldermen. A machinist became the mayor of St. Marys, Ohio; a railroad brakeman the mayor of New Castle, Pennsylvania. "But, comrades, it is not merely our physical growth, it is not merely our large strength upon which we congratulate ourselves," the chairman of the Socialist Party Convention, held in Indianapolis that year, declared. "It is the fact that the Socialist Party has, at all times, remained true to its trust and carried the banner of international socialism aloft in this country." Socialism's moment, it seemed, had arrived.

At that convention, the Party adopted a platform that began by denouncing capitalism as a system that produced, among other evils, an "extortionate cost of living": "Under this system the working class is exposed to poisonous conditions, to frightful and needless perils to life and limb, is walled around with court decisions, injunctions and unjust laws, and is preyed upon incessantly for the benefit of the controlling oligarchy of wealth." The platform called for the collective ownership of everything from the railroads and the telegraph lines to mines, forests, oil wells, banks, and the currency system. It called for a shortened workday, a workweek no longer than five and a half days, a minimum wage, old-age pensions,

workers' insurance, unemployment insurance, and the abolition of child labor. It also called for a graduated federal income tax, female suffrage, and the abolition of the Senate, the Presidential veto, and the Electoral College—and, since each of the items on this last list would require amending the Constitution, for a constitutional convention.

"The socialist moment is here," Nathan J. Robinson, the editor of the socialist magazine *Current Affairs*, announced this past summer, pointing to the swelling membership of the Democratic Socialists of America and to socialists' newfound prominence: Zohran Mamdani on the cover of *Time*. Is it 1912 all over again?

This year, the banner of socialism is being carried by the D.S.A., whose hundred and thirty thousand members already include two U.S. representatives, Alexandria Ocasio-Cortez and Rashida Tlaib; there are hundreds of D.S.A.-backed state and local officeholders across the country. (Bernie Sanders is a longtime socialist, but he is not a member of the D.S.A.) The D.S.A. is not a political party, but it does have a platform. Sort of. In 2017, its National Political Committee decided to replace its "priorities resolution" with a platform. Promised for 2019, it was postponed to 2021, given the D.S.A.'s "ideological diversity." A new platform, which the D.S.A. prefers to call a "program," was released this summer. It has much in common with the Socialist Party platform of 1912.

"We are workers fighting to transform society: to win the battle for democracy, draft a new constitution, and create a democratic socialist republic," the program pledges, while inveighing against the existing parties: "Both are funded by the same criminal class of billionaires and war profiteers." The program proposes, among other things, the abolition of the Senate and the replacement of the Presidency and Supreme Court with an executive and judiciary chosen by and subordinate to Congress.

A number of prominent Democrats condemned the platform. On Fox News, the host Shannon Bream asked Megan Romer, a D.S.A. co-chair, to confirm some of its proposals:

> B*ream*: Abolish borders and give amnesty to anyone currently in the U.S. illegally.

R*omer*: As a long-term plan. Yep.

B*ream*: Defund the Pentagon.

R*omer*: Absolutely.

B*ream*: Abolish prisons, at least in large part.

R*omer*: Yeah, again, as part of a long-term program. Yeah.

B*ream*: O.K. So no prisons. Government or public ownership of most large corporations.

R*omer*: Yeah, absolutely.

Romer, who grinned and seemed almost to laugh at one point during this quiz, came across as glib and, at best, remarkably naïve. “These people are insane,” Ted Cruz tweeted.

Then came Election Day, an epic Democratic sweep that reinvigorated the Party and brought gains for socialists not seen since 1912. Six D.S.A. members—from California, Colorado, Michigan, New York, and Pennsylvania—won seats in Congress (and the two sitting D.S.A. members won reëlection). D.S.A. candidates won mayoral races in Los Angeles; Washington, D.C.; Ann Arbor, Michigan; and Providence, Rhode Island. Even socialism’s losses were triumphs. The little red scare of 2026 backfired. The D.S.A. member Angie Nixon lost her long-shot bid to unseat the Republican Ashley Moody, a U.S. senator from Florida, who had characterized the campaign as “freedom versus socialism,” but Moody’s margin of victory was just 2.9 per cent. Mamdani, speaking at the Election Night party of Kathy Hochul (no socialist she), announced the dawn of a new era: “We have begun the work of transforming our party and making it belong to working people once again.”

The United States has no meaningful socialist party, and socialism has never overtaken either of the country’s two major political parties. This distinguishes the U.S. from every other Western democracy and would have surprised early American socialists, who pointed to a tradition of

communalism stretching from the Shakers to the Owenites. In 1869, John Humphrey Noyes, the American preacher and utopian, proclaimed that “this country has been from the beginning, and especially for the last forty years, a laboratory in which Socialisms of all kinds have been experimenting.” It was as if socialism was in the soil, as American as the Revolution.

Nevertheless, socialism didn’t really come to the fore of American politics until the Panic of 1893, when, according to Oliver Wendell Holmes, Jr., “a vague terror went over the earth and the word socialism began to be heard.” After the railway magnate George Pullman cut workers’ wages by a quarter, Debs called for a strike, and in 1895 he was sent to prison for his role in organizing it; Victor Berger visited him, bringing a copy of “Das Kapital.” (Debs’s extraordinary life is the subject of a lively and admiring new biography, “American Socialist,” by Shawn Gude.) Debs, a Democrat, said that he had previously “heard but little of Socialism,” and he did not become a socialist until 1897, after a campaign funded by plutocrats elevated William McKinley to the White House, convincing Debs that the rich controlled politics. “Money constitutes no proper basis of civilization,” he concluded. He first ran for President in 1900, and when he ran again four years later he earned more than four times as many votes.

“If my reading of history is correct, the prophecy of Marx will be fulfilled, and America will ring the downfall of capitalism the world over,” a socialist leader predicted in 1906, speaking in Chicago at the annual convention of the Industrial Workers of the World (I.W.W.). Yet, that year, the German economist Werner Sombart asked, “Why is there no socialism in the United States?” There *was* socialism, of course, but less than he and others expected. One of Sombart’s explanations was that Americans hadn’t suffered the worst ravages of “late capitalism” (a term that he coined): “On the reefs of roast beef and apple pie socialistic Utopias of every sort are sent to their doom,” he wrote. Call it the Too Many Arby’s theory of the American left.



“ ‘If found, please return to the guy stuck in the ceiling.’ ”
Cartoon by Roland High

“This is our year,” Debs said in 1912. And it was, but it was also American socialism’s last good year until this year. After that election, the Socialist Party began losing members from both its left wing and its right. At its convention in May, the Socialist Party had formally disavowed sabotage as a labor tactic; as a result, it saw members defect to the saboteur-friendly I.W.W. In November, the Democrat Woodrow Wilson won the Presidency, and soon Democrats began accomplishing much of what socialists had pledged to do. Although they neither abolished the Senate nor held a constitutional convention, progressives achieved the ratification of four constitutional amendments between 1913 and 1920, two in 1913 alone. (The Sixteenth granted Congress the right to impose a federal income tax, and the Seventeenth provided for the direct election of senators.) Other reforms proposed in the Socialist Party’s 1912 platform and adopted by Democrats—minimum-wage laws, maximum-hour laws, the abolition of child labor, old-age pensions, and unemployment insurance—saw success in the states, and by the end of the New Deal had been achieved nationally; meanwhile, the Socialist Party withered.

That was due to forces within and without. In 1917, American socialists divided over the Bolshevik Revolution, with some becoming Communists, and the Socialist Party announced that it opposed America's entrance into the war in Europe: "In support of capitalism, we will not willingly give a single life or a single dollar." To suppress dissent, Congress passed the notorious Espionage and Sedition Acts, under whose terms hundreds of socialists, including Debs, were prosecuted for their opposition to the war. In 1920, Debs, still in prison, ran for President with the slogan "From the Jail House to the White House." Five years later, he declared the Socialist Party "as near a corpse as a thing can be." After Debs's death, in 1926, Norman Thomas, a former Presbyterian minister, replaced him as the quadrennial Socialist Party candidate for President. In 1939, the Party opposed American entry into the Second World War, on the ground that it wasn't a working-class revolution but merely a clash between rival imperialist powers. The sociologist Daniel Bell memorably described the Party's leader speaking in Madison Square Garden at an America First Committee rally in 1941: "Behind him lay only the charnel house of American socialism." By 1950, amid the rise of McCarthyism and the second Red Scare, according to Bell, "American socialism as a political and social fact had become simply a notation in the archives of history."

Commentators then set about pawing through those archives. In postwar America, observers revisited Sombart's question about why there had been so little socialism in the United States. Aside from America's prosperity relative to Europe, the top answers, over the years, have included: the United States has no feudal past and has never had an established class system; the American political apparatus dooms all third parties; American socialists failed to ally with unions; Americans don't like ideas that come from Europe; the government has suppressed the political rights and, especially, the free speech of socialists; the Democratic Party has used socialist ideas to win elections for Democrats; and socialists are their own worst enemies, insisting on strict ideological conformity. As the sociologist Seymour Martin Lipset and the political scientist Gary Marks once wrote, "Explanations of socialism's weakness in America are as numerous as socialists were few."

Bell himself attributed much of socialism's demise to its notorious fractiousness ("For every two socialists there are always three political opinions"). But, more broadly, he was inclined to believe that American socialists "could never resolve but only straddle the basic issue of either accepting capitalist society, and seeking to transform it from within as the labor movement did, or becoming the sworn enemy of that society, like the communists." This dilemma has not abated.

Socialism in the United States failed as a political party. But it succeeded in influencing American economic and social policy, not only during the Progressive and the New Deal eras but also under Lyndon Johnson's Great Society. This last era of influence owed a great deal to the socialist Michael Harrington, who had taken a vow of poverty when he joined Dorothy Day's Catholic Worker Movement, became a Marxist in 1952, and served as a leader of the Young People's Socialist League. By the end of the nineteen-fifties, he'd begun to devote his time to the civil-rights movement. In 1960, the Socialist Party neither nominated nor endorsed a candidate for the Presidency. Harrington explained, "American socialism must concentrate its efforts on the battle for political realignment, for the creation of a real second party that will unite labor, liberals, Negroes, and provide them with an instrument for principled debate and effective action." His idea was that socialism could find a home in the Democratic Party, once "the Southern racists and certain other corruptive elements have been forced out of it."

In 1958, Harrington was asked by an editor at the magazine *Commentary* if he'd write about poverty in America. What he produced led to queries from book publishers. He initially demurred but eventually agreed. The result, "The Other America," came out in March, 1962. At a time when the country was said to be enjoying an age of affluence, Harrington drew attention to the millions of people living in poverty. The American poor needed, he said, "an American Dickens."

Harrington never used the word "socialism" in "The Other America," but Norman Thomas remarked that Harrington had "written a book which consciously or subconsciously, all of us Socialists have been waiting for." Yet the book scarcely made an impact until Dwight Macdonald's thirteen-thousand-word review for this magazine appeared in January of 1963. "Our

Invisible Poor,” still the longest and perhaps the most important book review that *The New Yorker* has ever published, was searing, pointed, and urgent: it sought specific action. “The federal government is the only purposeful force . . . that can reduce the numbers of the poor and make their lives more bearable,” Macdonald wrote. Walter Heller, the chair of John F. Kennedy’s Council of Economic Advisers, read the review and reportedly gave a copy to the President, who began planning a policy that became, under his successor, the War on Poverty.

When Harrington was made the leader of the Socialist Party, in 1968, he was already America’s best-known socialist, which, as he liked to say (borrowing a gibe from William F. Buckley, Jr.), was “like being the tallest building in Topeka, Kansas.” The year he assumed the leadership of a party that he did not believe ought to be a party, Harrington published “Toward a Democratic Left: A Radical Program for a New Majority,” in which he called for a “majority party of the democratic Left” that might well “bear an old label: the Democratic Party.” In 1972, Harrington resigned as co-chairman of the Socialist Party, and the next year he helped form what would be called, by 1982, the Democratic Socialists of America.

After years of slow growth, the D.S.A.’s membership began expanding in fits and starts following Sanders’s Presidential bid in 2016. “America will never be a socialist country,” Donald Trump said in his State of the Union address in 2019. But popular support for socialism, and for positions held by democratic socialists like Sanders and Mamdani, has surged since Trump’s reëlection. This fall, a Gallup survey found that public approval of socialism had reached a new high of forty-three per cent, and that backing for key measures endorsed by the D.S.A. had surged, too: two-thirds of Americans support Medicare for All.

Socialism has been strongest in the United States during eras of high inequality and has been weakest during eras of shared prosperity. The share of income going to the top one per cent began climbing in the nineteen-seventies and has risen to levels last seen in the nineteen-twenties. There may still be, here and there, reefs of roast beef and apple pie, but the same cannot be said of affordable medical care, housing, or higher education. Democrats of the Progressive Era fought for and achieved labor legislation,

campaign-finance reform, social-welfare provisions, and anti-monopoly measures. Democrats from Bill Clinton to Joe Biden have not been half as successful. Hence the Sanders insurgency in 2016, and the prominence of the D.S.A. today. But is a new New Left—what Harrington called the Next Left—really emerging? And, if it is, what is its plan?

Socialists, who advocate central planning of the economy, are strangely ambivalent about issuing plans. Marx himself cautioned against “writing recipes” for “the cook-shops of the future,” but he did imagine what a day without capitalism and the division of labor would look like—a day when people could do whatever they wanted. You could, Marx mused, “hunt in the morning, fish in the afternoon, rear cattle in the evening, criticize after dinner.”

Writing nearly a century later, the economist John Maynard Keynes, a liberal sympathetic to socialism, similarly imagined a future requiring very little labor, a “destination of economic bliss” that, he warned, would produce a new problem: “how to occupy the leisure, which science and compound interest will have won.”

In “Toward a Democratic Left,” Harrington took pains to insist that his ideas ought not to be taken as “blueprints.” But in recent years democratic socialists have not shied away from socialist solutionism. In “The Blueprint: How Socialism Can Work in the Real World,” an economist, a philosopher, and the founder of the magazine *Jacobin* propose a model for a just society and ask readers to imagine a day in a socialist future: “Some people may spend more time reading Russian novels or cooking elaborate meals with people they love or hiking and camping in nature.”



“I tried, but this is the largest size they had.”
Cartoon by Mick Stevens

It’s no surprise, then, that the D.S.A.’s 2026 platform also asks Americans to imagine a day off in a world without capitalism. “Maybe in the morning, you walk your kids to school, run errands, or go to a doctor’s appointment. In the afternoon, you might play a sport, practice a new skill, read, plan a trip. In the evening, you could meet up with friends or family and eat together, maybe go to the movies or down to the park.”

If all this sounds oddly familiar, that’s because it’s the kind of future that Elon Musk and Sam Altman like to talk about, a world of abundance in a planned economy in which poverty has been eliminated and wage labor curtailed. In the twenty-first century, the belief that socialism is destiny has begun to converge with the belief that artificial intelligence is destiny. (A planned economy is far likelier, after all, in an economy run by artificial intelligence than in any future imagined in “Das Kapital,” even if the prospects for human freedom are, alas, far worse.) These days, you can find A.I. boosters repurposing rhetoric once championed by Eugene Debs. “Quit being a wage slave,” one A.I. marketing service tells potential clients. “Stop building their dreams. Replace labor with AI systems.”

What will people do all day in an A.I. future? According to tech titans, there will be no need to do anything—you’ll be paid a universal basic income, or, as Musk likes to call it, a “universal ‘you can have whatever you want’ income.” Altman has proposed that instead of universal basic income people might be given “universal basic compute,” which they can use, sell, or donate. “You own part of the productivity!” he has said, sounding like

Marx. Altman is sure that in this future “we’ll find stuff to do that we really care about.” Musk likens working in this future to growing vegetables even though you can buy them at the store. “Some people still do it because they like growing vegetables,” he says.

The fullest statement of this world view is the philosopher Nick Bostrom’s 2024 book, “Deep Utopia: Life and Meaning in a Solved World.” It begins with a Marxian joke about how Bostrom made his fortune by writing a “recipe book.” He is best known for his 2014 book, “Superintelligence,” which warned of the coming A.I. apocalypse. In “Deep Utopia,” though, he imagines a post-scarcity, post-work utopia whose chief problem is “the purpose problem,” which he meditates on for some five hundred pages that constitute nothing so much as an illustration of his own attempt to find some purpose . . . by writing a meandering book of random, self-indulgent musings about purposelessness.

For socialists in 2026, as for socialists in 1912, absorption into the Democratic Party risks trading the ambition to replace capitalism for the more modest goal of reforming it. But this time around there’s a strange new twist: the convergence of socialist determinism with technological determinism, Marxism become Muskism. The Democratic Party may well advance socialism’s most practical and urgent demands: Medicare for All, a Green New Deal. But Silicon Valley, with more power than any political party, seems keen to turn socialism’s most extravagant dream into a nightmare: a world in which people no longer have to do anything, because they are no longer needed. ♦

Jill Lepore, a staff writer, has contributed to the magazine since 2005. Her books include “The Rise and Fall of the Artificial State” (August, 2026).

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Annals of Music

The Ubiquitous Melancholy of Max Richter

The composer’s song “On the Nature of Daylight” has popped up in countless sob fests including “Arrival” and “Hamnet.” With billions of streams, he’s become one of the most popular and successful composers of our time.

By Jane Bua

November 9, 2026



If a character in a movie is sad, there’s a good chance that Richter’s on the soundtrack.Photographs by Frederike Helwig

If you’ve ever felt down, you may have found your way over to Spotify’s “Sad Classical” playlist—a sixty-song, four-and-a-half-hour collection of such all-time emos as Frédéric Chopin, Samuel Barber, and Gustav Mahler.

But at the very top is a track called “On the Nature of Daylight,” by the composer Max Richter, from his 2004 album, “The Blue Notebooks.” Never heard it? Yes, you have. Any time a character in a film or a TV show experiences anything vaguely approaching melancholy, there’s a good chance that Richter’s brooding, cyclical strings are the soundtrack to their tears—and yours. “Daylight” was used in “Stranger Than Fiction” (2006), when Will Ferrell destroys a lamp after realizing that he’ll soon be dead. In “Shutter Island” (2010), it plays when Leonardo DiCaprio struggles with visions of his wife, who, because of him, is dead. It bookends “Arrival” (2016), when Amy Adams talks aloud to her daughter, who is dead. You hear it in “The Last of Us” (2023), when a couple spends a final day together, before they kill themselves, and are dead. And in “Hamnet” (2025), when Hamnet is dead. Are you crying yet?

“We recorded that album in three hours,” Richter told me one drizzly afternoon, in a booth at Café Chelsea, in Manhattan. Slender and tall, with cropped hair and wearing a crisp black button-down, he went on, “When I’m working on something, I’m, like, ‘Is anyone going to hear this?’ I sort of don’t expect anything. I’m just trying to put notes in the right places.” In part because of “Daylight,” Richter became the best-selling living artist on the classical label Deutsche Grammophon.

Measured and not easily ruffled, Richter comes across like the human version of a beta-blocker. His vocal cadence is similar to his music—lulling and copacetic, with a tendency to repeat. Normal frustrations don’t seem to stick with him. He had recently experienced a disruptive tech issue during a show in North Carolina. “It was the keyboard—it broke in such a wonderful way,” he said. “I stood up and it was still going, and it turned into this blur of noise. Audiences kind of like that stuff, because it’s human, isn’t it?”

For the past two years, Richter has been on tour with two of his albums, “In a Landscape” (2024) and the omnipresent “Blue Notebooks.” He considers them both ever relevant. “ ‘In a Landscape’ is an attempt to model an ideal society,” he told me. “It’s a piece about the world we’re living in, and I suppose every time we think it cannot get crazier, it keeps getting crazier.” “Blue Notebooks” features text from Franz Kafka’s “The Blue Octavo Notebooks,” read aloud by Tilda Swinton. On the first track, which sets a

two-note figure reminiscent of Debussy's "Des pas sur la neige" against typewriter clacks, Swinton muses portentously on "the rattling of a mirror not quite firmly fastened to the wall." The record was conceived as a protest against the Iraq War, an urge for peace amid conflict. "And here we are again," Richter said.

"Here we are again" is an ethos for Richter. His music is defined by simple, repetitive figures, set in simple, repetitive progressions. It is immediately understandable—there's never a need to guess what you should be feeling, for better or worse. "A lot of my work is trying to make things land in a very direct way," he said. "So that you have a situation where if you move a single note it wouldn't be as good."

This directness has made him popular in the streaming era—his stuff is easy to put on as background music. "Most musical artists, their streams go up on the weekends, and during the week they're played less," Richter told me. "Mine is exactly the opposite." His fans listen at home or at work, filling the gap in our brains that finds silence intolerable—while cooking, cleaning, studying, reading. "It's a private, intentional situation," he said. I listened to it while putting together a wedding speech for a friend and while brushing up on "Music in the Late Twentieth Century," by Richard Taruskin. I listened to it while writing this sentence. "It's not up to me," Richter said. "I don't want to prescribe how people encounter the material. To me, making a piece of music is about asking a question: What about *this*?"

The musicologist William Robin told me, "The music's adaptability is key to how it serves listeners. Whether Richter does it better or worse than other ambient figures, I don't know. But the way ambient listening has taken off since the pandemic is certainly related to his success." Richter bristles at the "ambient" label and instead refers to himself as "post-classical," a term he coined half jokingly. "Talking about it has always been a bit of a problem," he said. "I don't really believe in categories."

Since 2002, Richter has released dozens of albums, some of which are retooled versions of his own music—or of other people's. "Intertextuality is pretty fundamental to what I do," he said. After "Blue Notebooks," listeners may know him from "Recomposed: Vivaldi's Four Seasons" (2012), which

extracts swatches of Antonio Vivaldi's concertos and re-stitches them together with Richterian threads: crescendos surging to a sudden stop, recurring gestures of a measure or two, low strings drawn out like molasses. (At one point, the chords below the sprightly violins of the track "Spring 1" even contour through the same circular four-note figure that is in the opening of "On the Nature of Daylight.")

"I had fallen in love with Vivaldi as a tiny kid, but grew to hate it as an adult because you hear it in insurance adverts or when you're on hold, or whatever. So I wanted to get that out of my system," Richter said. "I assumed I was going to be destroyed for it—the end of my career. But it's not like I really had a career." The record topped classical charts in twenty-two countries. Two years later, Richter came out with a follow-up, a spoken-word album, his mellow voice explaining each piece on the record, DVD-extra style. (Track 9: " 'Autumn 1' is pretty much the original Vivaldi for quite a long time, except I've sort of sliced it up and cut holes in it.") Then, in 2022, he released "The New Four Seasons: Vivaldi Recomposed," which is the same music, this time made with era-accurate strings, plus one of many Moog synthesizers he owns. "I heard a performance on period instruments and just thought, This is brilliant," he said. "I thought it was a nice learning journey. A three-hundred-and-sixty-degree project." His label extended the journey three years later, with "Vivaldi by Max Richter," which includes tracks from both versions of "Recomposed." Perhaps a person might save some time by simply listening to Vivaldi.

The masses swooned over the project, but it irritated many musicians. "The way 'The Four Seasons' was adopted by the Pottery Barn Muzak crowd already harmed Vivaldi's status as a serious composer," Ethan Iverson, a critic and composer, told me. Richter's own "defanging," he said, "suggests a future where nobody knows anything about anything: we are all senseless drones, oblivious to the mystery and magic of tonal harmony."



Cartoon by Sofia Warren

Not long ago, an A.I. company approached Richter about a potential collaboration. “Their pitch to me was ‘Hey, Max, say you’re writing a song and you get stuck. You’ve got the beginning and you’ve got the end. That’s where we come in. You click this and it’ll fix that for you.’ But that bit is what I live for. That’s where I learn stuff.” He has advocated before British Parliament on the need to protect artists and regulate A.I. Has that been successful? “No, in short.”

Richter believably insists that the art must always come first. “As far as I know, I’m the biggest seller on D.G., but I see that as kind of their problem, not mine,” he said. “I’m very hazy on the commercial side. I don’t love sitting in meetings. The only thing I can control is where I put the notes on the page.”

Richter was born in 1966, in Hamelin, Germany. “It’s where the Pied Piper came from—that’s the only reason anyone knows it,” he said. When he was three, his family moved to Bedford, England, after his father, an electrical engineer, was posted there. His mother, who eventually ran a health-food shop, was an amateur pianist. At age five, Richter started piano lessons: “My teacher was a very lovely elderly woman named Mrs. Hart. If you played a wrong note, she’d hit you with a ruler.”

During Richter's childhood, the classical world was in the midst of a counterstrike against modernist complexity, which had become an academic norm. In the nineteen-twenties, Arnold Schoenberg had pioneered the twelve-tone method, rejecting the idea of a central key. After the Second World War, this musical language, which yielded a lot of atonal work, became more widely accepted and was further developed by figures like the French serialist composer Pierre Boulez. Artists began to push back against what Richter described as a "modernist hangover," stripping away the elaborate status quo. In 1964, the composer Terry Riley put out the groundbreaking piece "In C," which consists of a high C being pinged to eternity for forty minutes, against pulsing instrumentation. Riley's friend, the New York City-born composer Steve Reich, had suggested the idea of an eighth-note heartbeat—one of many stamps Reich left on the contemporary scene, including "Clapping Music." Philip Glass, who had studied at Juilliard before doing a Fulbright with the composer Nadia Boulanger, knew Reich and was paring back his own compositions. He soon established the Philip Glass Ensemble for experimental work.

When Richter was twelve, his family milkman offered a portal into this burgeoning new world called minimalism. "He'd be hearing me doing my Mozart, and he took me on as kind of a project," Richter said. "For me at that time, new music was Stravinsky. But the milkman was a jazz musician, and he had gone to New York and picked up Chatham Square Phillip Glass records and Terry Riley. And he would just drop them off with the milk in the mornings. I was hearing it, going, 'What *is* this even?' " It became an unquenchable fascination. Richter began, in his words, "scribbling."

In secondary school, music continued to be a vehicle for his curiosity. "It was an insurgency against a very normalizing, conforming over-all project in the Margaret Thatcher–Ronald Reagan era," he said. "Really, all I wanted to do was sit around in cafés reading French novels and smoking cigarettes. I stopped going to classes, and they kicked me out." After completing his A-levels at a training college that had a robust music program, he enrolled at the University of Edinburgh, then transferred to the Royal Academy of Music to study composition. At *RAM*, modernism was still going strong. "If you were writing tonal music, it just meant that you were an idiot," he said. They wanted him to write "post-Boulez," Richter said. "I did that for a

while. I wrote very complicated pieces." But he was drawn back to the intelligibility of minimalism. "The real world makes no sense at all, but a piece of music is a place where things can make sense," Richter said. "It's a way of talking about things. And, therefore, I just took everything away. Simplify, simplify, simplify."

After *RAM*, Richter moved to Florence to study with Luciano Berio, a pupil of Boulez's Darmstadt School who later also taught Reich. "Although he was very much a modernist figurehead, Berio was into folk music, historical materials, working with history rather than trying to erase it," Richter said. "His music was really omnivorous." (Some people I talked to were surprised that Richter was Berio's student, but the signs are there: Berio's "Sinfonia" repurposes Mahler's Symphony No. 2, serving as an inspiration for Richter's Vivaldi project.) While working with Berio, Richter engaged with new ideas coming out of the Baltics. "I had heard the very beginning of Arvo Pärt happening," he said, of the Estonian composer. Pärt developed "tintinnabuli," a style of two-voice minimalist composition. "I went to his concerts and I said, 'Hang on, this is amazing.' So there was lots of stuff that punctured that sort of modernist brain."



Richter has his own Comme des Garçons perfume, which sells for a hundred and sixty-five dollars: “We used all the source materials that I work with,” he said. “Piano-soundboard wood, rosin, magnetic tape, the insides of synthesizers, the forest.”

Richter’s style is, no doubt, descended from Pärt. But, in considering Richter’s path, a closer parallel might be Glass—a composer who, despite the judgment of some people in the classical world, made the journey from post-modernist enfant terrible to well-known creator of scores for blockbuster movies (he has been nominated for three Academy Awards, including for “The Hours”). Nico Muhly, a composer who worked closely with Glass, told me that, decades ago, “if you mentioned Philip Glass’s name in academia, it was, like, horses whinny, thunderclaps, lightning strikes. It was some Wicked Witch of the West shit. Nobody was in dialogue with that music. People were actively hostile.” Glass’s crossover into the mainstream, although reviled by certain purists, was momentous. William Robin, the musicologist, said, “When Glass began writing scores, in the eighties, it set a new kind of standard for film, TV, and commercials to have music that is very generic and also emotionally powerful. Richter is doing a similar thing.” On top of the umpteen uses of “Daylight,” Richter has

scored countless pieces of media, including “The Leftovers,” “The Veil,” “Spaceman,” and “Ad Astra.” His professional success would not exist without the efforts of Glass.

But Glass, Reich, and Pärt tend to ask more of listeners than Richter does. Their work feels easier to actively engage with, rather than passively absorb. They employ microevolutions—changes of rhythm or placement that make it harder to predict what the ear will catch, despite the cyclicality. As Glass explained in his memoir, “It never repeated all the time, for if it had, it would have been unlistenable.” Richter’s work is not unlistenable. On the contrary: it’s so listenable that you can sometimes forget to listen. When he does make subtle changes—and he does—the impact isn’t as evident. Take “Daylight.” The violin’s floating seesaw melody switches up its suspensions, sometimes holding a note over a measure and sometimes playing it on the downbeat. But it’s loyal to the same type of disruption, and the ear comes to expect it as if it were the norm all along. Perhaps that’s part of his point in the quest to be intelligible, and there are certainly other undercurrent changes that the listener won’t register. But that ultimately means they’re missable.

“If you listen to Max, there are some pieces where there’s a really explicit Glass influence,” Muhly said. “You see that in ‘Vladimir’s Blues,’ ”—a track off of “Blue Notebooks.” He continued, “But, to me, its relationship to Glass is cosmetic,” not structural.

Richter isn’t shy about Glass’s influence, but he skirted the suggestion that his work is derivative of him. “The thing that Glass’s music did for me is it gave permission,” he said. “He brings repetition into the foreground as a somatic idea.” He added, “All music is, in a way, about other music. But repetition is in everything. You know, Chopin’s studies are minimal.” Richter doesn’t have a relationship with Glass (“Our paths have never crossed”), but he’s open to meeting: “Why not? I’m sure he’s a fascinating guy.”

The influence of Richter’s minimalist forebears aside, his project falls more in the comfortable pocket of pop music. (He is planning a show at the Sphere, in Las Vegas, with Oprah Winfrey.) He serves as a gateway for non-musicians to safely enter the classical space. One young composer who has

worked with Richter told me, “I used to feel very hostile toward his music. I remember playing this three-hour show, and I was, like, People are sitting through three hours of the same chord progression developing over every minute, going up a fifth every five minutes? This is exhausting for me, and I can’t imagine sitting in the audience listening to it. But people were weeping.” She added, “The market is the market. Maybe there’s something we can learn from that.”

In early September, I visited Richter’s studio, behind an automatic gate in a thirty-one-acre spread near the village of Charlbury, in England. A light rain—rare, after the summer’s heat wave—misted the triangular structure, dappling a glass wall decaled with the letters “SRM”: Studio Richter Mahr. “A big part of this building is about creative community, so we’ve embedded that in the architecture,” Richter explained, standing by an open kitchen in a clinically white foyer. “We’ve got the café in the center, which was very deliberate because it’s a shared space.” Every sound seemed to both echo and disappear instantly. An aide named Joe, who introduced himself as “Mr. Assistant,” brought Richter a small cup of black coffee. (The espresso machine is a La Marzocco Linea PB, which costs as much as a car. Richter said, “I remember in that meeting with the architects, they thought I was joking when I walked in with a brochure for this thing.”)

Richter wore a white shirt rather than his usual black, because, he said, “I’m a bit sleepy this morning.” He’d accessorized with a “Peanuts” watch. “Schroeder’s my guy. He’ll just have a bar of Beethoven in a speech bubble,” he said. “He’s such a pianist.” He led me past a few analog recording machines into the control room—a production area with knobs and screens, and a window onto an open studio. “This room is the end point of the workflow. The whole building is conceived as a kind of an instrument,” he said. “It’s a Henry Ford thing, we’ve got the means of production.” He walked into the recording room. “Oak,” he said, of the walls. “This all comes from a forest in Germany, which has been managed by the same family for two hundred years.” A Steinway D automatic Spirio sat in one corner. A Hammond M102 organ was against the opposite wall. “It’s the same kind of Hammond that Billy Preston played on ‘Abbey Road,’ ” he said. “When I watched that eight-hour documentary, I was just, like, ‘That’s it. I’ve got to have it.’ ” He pointed out the serial number,

which dated it to 1967. “The one he plays was lost, and no one knows where it is,” he said, dropping his voice low. “So this could be the one.”

The studio is where Richter created his new album, “While The Flood Rages.” Revision: the music is not exactly new—it’s drawn from his score for a 2022 ballet, “MADDADDAM,” based on a series of post-apocalyptic books by Margaret Atwood. The ballet translates the tale of the rebirth of society after a horrific disaster into egg-forward visuals: egg-headed figures, a giant egg displaying black-and-white footage of industrial cityscapes, interpretive dancing in egg-shaped costumes.

Richter and the director Wayne McGregor began collaborating on “MADDADDAM” in 2019. “The record is not the ballet,” Richter said. “I made some architectural decisions.” He uses his reliable muses—strings, morose bass lines—to represent the harmonious characters known as the Children of Crake. “They’re sort of these synthetic creatures. Genetically, they’re manufactured in a lab,” he explained. “They inherit the Earth from humanity, but that’s a good thing because they’re nonviolent.” The theme closes out each third of the record, including the first single, “Now We Can Sing”—a Pachelbel’s Canon-esque chord cycle, topped by a falling B-major melody that feels a bit like an ear-training interval exercise. It is, in Richter’s words, “existentially safe,” as opposed to a jittering, electronic track called “Data Ballistics,” which sounds, refreshingly, like it could be played at a techno club. To coincide with the album, he released a limited-edition book of crosswords: “1. Broadcast from Howard Stern, e.g.”; “8. Mountain range on the Europe/Asia border.”

Richter introduced me to his wife, the visual artist Yulia Mahr. Her workspace was as white as the foyer. “These guys are tempestuous,” Mahr said, gesturing to a line of ceramic arm sculptures she had made, marbled with dirt and dried weeds, lying on the floor. “They won’t do what they’re asked to do.” Petite and sparkly-eyed, she and Richter first met at the Edinburgh Festival, in the late eighties. “We’ve always just talked ideas,” Richter said. Their partnership brims with creative support—she wears his custom-made Comme des Garçons perfume, which sells for a hundred and sixty-five dollars a bottle and is called “Max Richter 01.” (“We used all the source materials that I work with,” Richter said. “Piano-soundboard wood,

rosin, magnetic tape, the insides of synthesizers, the forest.") Mahr helped come up with the idea for his 2015 album "Sleep," which was the first classical album to exceed two billion streams across all platforms. It stayed on the *Billboard* Classical chart for three hundred and fifty-nine weeks. It's no mystery why: "Sleep" is an eight-and-a-half-hour, two-hundred-and-four-track concept album that you put on before you go to bed. Richter worked with the neuroscientist David Eagleman to learn about the brain during rest, and the record is an ambient—sorry, post-classical—cloud of cyclicality. Richter has described it, as he does "Blue Notebooks," as "protest music."

Others might wonder if it's a gimmick, a ploy to increase streaming numbers masquerading as art. (It does bring to mind Justin Bieber's desperate attempt to put his song "Yummy" at the top of the charts, in 2020, by urging fans to "create a playlist with 'Yummy' on repeat" and "let it play while you sleep." The song reached No. 2.)

Richter once described "Sleep" as music for when "your conscious mind is on holiday." He has performed the work live twenty-eight times—the lights are dim, the audience are in beds instead of seats, and the musicians take staggered breaks. Ben Russell, a violinist who often performs with Richter, told me, "You have to really time things and keep your mind interested, otherwise you start to drift. I've definitely had some very slow blinks happen during that concert." Backstage, Richter provides cots and snacks. "You grab a little sushi," Russell said. "There's coffee, and even wine helps if you use it judiciously. So sushi, coffee, wine, sushi, coffee, wine."



"Carry me."
Cartoon by Liana Finck

One night, I decided to sleep to “Sleep.” I settled into bed around 11 *P.M.*, queued up the first track, and was greeted by pulsing chords on soft keys. I was playing it from my phone, which I imagine most people do, so the low values in each track got lost in the mix, and I found myself being kept alert by the high-end sounds—violins, or a soprano. My conscious mind was not on holiday.

Maybe I would have had a better time napping to the hour-long “From Sleep” (2015), or the slightly longer “Sleep (Remixes)” (2016), or the thirty-minute, electronic-forward “Sleep: Tranquility Base” (2023). Or perhaps I should try a whole night again with “Sleep (Faded)” (2018), which is the same eight and a half hours of music, but with each track fading out at the end. I’ll think it over more, once I finish watching the 2021 documentary “Max Richter’s Sleep,” about Max Richter’s “Sleep.”

Deep in the S.R.M. property, past a large crow-inspired art work by Mahr, there is a secluded patch of trees. “All right, my dears, settle down!” Richter called, by a fence. The dears were his three alpacas—“Paddington, Finn, and . . . I’ve forgotten his name”—who were trying to kick one another in the head. “They’ve gotten frisky with the rain,” he said, beaming. “The dynamics change constantly. It’s the three-alpaca problem.”

The drizzle pattered on his umbrella. “I come out here every day,” he said. “I really enjoy the effect on your thinking, being in the green.” He walked past a row of short dog hurdles set out for his Labrador, Haku, named after a character from “Spirited Away.” “If I’m working on something, I’m here,” he said. “I’ve written movies in hotel rooms, but it’s a pretty torrid experience.” In fact, he wrote a third of the score to “Hamnet” in one.

The project didn’t originally include “On the Nature of Daylight.” “I wrote a different cue for the ending of ‘Hamnet,’ ” he said. “But ‘On the Nature of Daylight’ really got under the skin of the film.” He sounded defeated. “They played it on set, for hours and hours and hours.” The director and co-writer, Chloé Zhao, hadn’t yet finalized the end of the movie, and Jessie Buckley, who starred as Agnes, Hamnet’s mother, sent her “Daylight.” When Zhao listened to it, she had an epiphany about how to wrap up the story—the hands of the audience reaching onto the stage at the Globe Theatre, set to the strains of the twenty-year-old song.

“We had a lot of conversations where I was saying, ‘Look, it’s been in loads of films. I think we need an original score,’ ” Richter said. “It was quite an intense back-and-forth.” (Zhao told *IndieWire*, in 2025, “We live in a culture that is so afraid not to generate new things.”) Richter went on, “But, ultimately, it’s the director’s baby. Even though I’d written some other music which I personally prefer.”

That piece, called “Of the undiscovered country,” wound up being shovelled to the film’s end credits. I overlaid the final scene with the song, and found myself undistracted by familiarity. As Agnes mourned her son and forgave her husband, the music—high, pearly voices; deep, sombre strings—became a buttress rather than an engine. It allowed the scene to be.

Richter told me that he turns down licensing offers for “Daylight” all the time now, and doesn’t know if he wants it to appear anywhere in the future. “It’s problematic,” he said. “I’m cautious about it because I think it hijacks a movie.” Part of the issue is that British licensing laws allow national TV broadcasts to use the piece without his permission. “So, to some extent, you can’t control it,” he said. He quickly added, “But I’m very grateful.” With thirty-one acres, three alpacas, and a perfume, how could he not be?

One evening, I travelled to Newark, New Jersey, in a downpour to see Richter perform on tour. The *PATH* train was dotted with flight attendants and World Cup fans. Despite the weather, the New Jersey Performing Arts Center was packed, and Richter’s mass appeal was on full display. A guy downing a Miller Lite sat near a woman in an evening gown. “I listen to him a lot when I read,” a young woman with glasses and a slicked-back ponytail said. This was her first time seeing his music live.

Since Richter emerged as a commercial success, services like Spotify have been flooded with imitators, compiled on such playlists as “Peaceful Strings” (five thousand saves), “Focus Piano” (four hundred thousand saves), and “Peaceful Piano” (nearly eight million saves). In the streaming era, how we consume music has become less intentional—we’re fed what the machine thinks we’ll like, and then more of it. Richter is a cross-genre artist who could lead a listener into the world of classical music, which, in an ever-struggling industry, is a phenomenal contribution. But chances are that an algorithm will feed Richter fans the music of Hans Zimmer or

Ludovico Einaudi, and not Dvořák or Messiaen or Fauré. The gateway becomes less of a gateway than an echo chamber.

Blue stage lights dimmed, and Richter, in chunky black glasses and a black shirt, walked out with his ensemble. A rectangular spotlight appeared center stage, like sun coming in from the small window of a stone church. The ensemble began playing “In a Landscape.” Fog-machine smoke billowed across the stage, choreography to the looping bass line.

After intermission, it was finally time for “On the Nature of Daylight.” Slow string notes blossomed out, and the fog wafted into the audience. A couple in front of me huddled closer together. Maybe it was the rain. Maybe I was thinking about dead little Hamnet. Maybe it was because, three nights earlier, my boyfriend had said he wasn’t in love with me. Somewhat against my will, I started to cry. After the piece ended, several people headed toward the exits—they had gotten what they came for. ♦

Jane Bua is a member of The New Yorker’s editorial staff who covers classical music for Goings On. Previously, she wrote for Pitchfork.

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When Jontay Porter was ten, his father woke him up most mornings before dawn. He and his siblings piled into the family's Sprinter van and drove to an empty field house off the highway. Then, while their friends slept, they ran basketball drills with their father. "All I remember is it still being pitch-black outside, and the two dreaded double doors on the side of the building that would always be left open for us," Jontay told me recently. In the bleary moments just before one of his siblings tugged the field-house doors open, Jontay always secretly wished that they'd be locked. And, one morning, they were. Jontay smiled as he climbed back into the van and drifted off to sleep. But his brother Michael, Jr., who was seventeen months older, was furious. "Michael was the opposite," Jontay said. "He *wanted* to go."

Jontay grew up in Columbia, Missouri, the fourth of eight children. His father, Michael, Sr., worked in Christian ministry, and his mother, Lisa, homeschooled the children. Both had played college basketball—Lisa, as a high-school senior, had averaged a nearly impossible fifty-eight points per game—and they saw the sport as their children's ticket to college. All eight of the kids eventually got basketball scholarships. By the time Jontay was sixteen, he was six feet ten. In most families, as a five-star high-school recruit, Jontay would have been the main attraction. But Michael was Mozart. In 2010, their father got a job on the coaching staff for the women's team at the University of Missouri. The men's coach spotted Michael shooting alone in the arena one night and offered him a full scholarship; he was still in seventh grade. When he accepted it, as a high-school senior, he was the top recruit in the country. His highlight reels had racked up millions of views on YouTube. N.B.A. scouts believed that he could be the next Kevin Durant. "He's a game-changer," a league executive told the New York *Post*.

Big state schools turn their best athletes into local celebrities, but the hype that followed Michael to Missouri's campus on his recruiting visits was closer to Beatlemania. Fans asked for autographs and took selfies. Jontay, who came along, was seduced by the hysteria. "Frat houses are putting up posters, and he's literally treated like a king," he recalled. "I wanted to be a

part of that circus.” He skipped his senior year of high school to join the team, too. The brothers were best friends. Still, it was sometimes hard to be one of the top players in the country but just the second best in his family. “He got all the attention,” Jontay said. “I was just kind of his biggest fan.”

For a time that first season, Michael was sidelined with a back injury, giving Jontay a turn in the spotlight. “He’s the best player I’ve ever been around,” Chris Hollender, then an assistant coach at Mizzou, told me. “I’ve always said I thought he was a more complete player than Mike.” At eighteen, Jontay led his team to the N.C.A.A. tournament. “For me to finally get a taste of stardom?” Jontay said. “I was the man. I controlled the narrative.”

Michael went to the N.B.A. draft that summer. Jontay planned to enter the following year. Then, during the final scrimmage before his sophomore season, he pushed off his right leg to explode toward the rim. “I felt, like, every crack in that moment, and just crumpled to the ground,” he said. He had torn the major ligaments in his knee. His teammates lifted him off the ground and laid him on a table in the training room. “He was beside himself,” Hollender said. “Couldn’t catch his breath, he was crying so hard.” It wasn’t from the pain; Jontay knew what his injury meant for the team’s chances that season. “The only thing he said to me was ‘I’m so sorry,’ ” Hollender said. “It was gut-wrenching.”

In 2019, while Jontay was in rehab for his knee, he injured it again. “Everybody’s telling me, ‘You’re going to be O.K.,’ ” he said. “I knew it wasn’t true.” By then, Michael was a rookie with the Denver Nuggets. (He went on to win a championship with the team, in 2023.) But Jontay, watching the N.B.A. draft in his parents’ basement, saw sixty picks go by without a team calling his name. Eventually, the Memphis Grizzlies took a chance and signed him to a contract as a free agent. He loved the N.B.A.—luxury travel, assistants to run his errands, last-minute reservations at Michelin-starred restaurants—but he felt that he was a tourist there. He had to take painkillers just to play, and after games he had to stick needles into his knees to drain fluid, in order to keep them from swelling. After just two seasons, he was cut from the roster.



Jontay, middle, with his siblings, around 2006.Photograph courtesy Jontay Porter

In September, 2021, Jontay was in Memphis, living like any other twenty-one-year-old kid—except for the money. He'd made two million dollars from his N.B.A. salary, and had received an insurance settlement for another $2.7 million (the difference between his projected N.B.A. earnings before his injury and his actual deal). One Sunday, he invited some friends over to watch football. Sports betting had recently been legalized in several states, and apps like FanDuel and DraftKings, which previously hosted fantasy-sports contests, were suddenly the biggest sportsbooks in America. Jontay had always avoided them; it seemed improper for an N.B.A. player to bet even on other sports. But now he was out of the league, and had started dabbling in sports gambling. He opened up FanDuel and placed a hundred-and-twenty-five-thousand-dollar bet that the Kansas City Chiefs would beat the Baltimore Ravens. He put another ten thousand dollars on a parlay—a riskier bet that strings together multiple outcomes to increase the payout—wagering that the Chiefs would win, that their running back would rush more than his expected yards, and that the Ravens' quarterback, Lamar Jackson, would run for a touchdown himself.

In the fourth quarter, the Chiefs were up eleven points, and Jackson raced along the right edge and into the end zone, clinching the last leg of the parlay. If the Chiefs held on to their lead, Jontay would win hundreds of thousands of dollars. His friends recorded a video of him jumping off his couch, hands in the air, shrieking, "Let's go! Let's go!"

But, in the final minutes of the game, the Ravens scored to take the lead. The Chiefs then fumbled while setting up what would have been a game-winning field goal. Ravens 36, Chiefs 35. Jontay slumped into his bed. “Literally, like, the party was over,” he said. That night, he stared at the ceiling, unable to sleep. How could he have been reckless enough to lose six figures on a football game? Then again, he had come so close to winning. In basketball, his body had betrayed him. But in sports betting all he needed was his brain. “That moment where I tore my knee is where everything that is on the news right now kind of started from,” he told me. “That point where I no longer had control.”



Jontay and his brother Michael playing for the University of Missouri, in 2017.Photograph by Jeff Roberson / AP

In 2015, amid a familiar flood of Bud Light and Allstate commercials, football fans were inundated with cheap-looking testimonials—men in jerseys holding oversized checks and spraying champagne. Some had taglines like “More sports, more winners, more millionaires.” The ads were for FanDuel and DraftKings, which had recently launched as fantasy-sports apps. That year, they spent a combined two hundred million dollars on TV advertising; in September, they ran a national spot every ninety seconds. The C.E.O. of DraftKings, Jason Robins, bragged that his business had signed up two hundred thousand new players in a single day.

The companies were taking advantage of a legal loophole. In 1992, sports betting had been made illegal almost everywhere in the country except Nevada, through the Professional and Amateur Sports Protection Act. But fantasy sports had been a staple of American fandom going back to the nineteen-eighties—a social activity that the comedian Joey Mulinaro once

likened to a “book club for regular guys.” Traditional fantasy sports were slow and methodical. Friends and colleagues got together, forked over twenty dollars or so, and drafted an imaginary team of real players. Then they pored over newspapers and tallied up their players’ stats with pencil and paper. The person with the best record at the end of the season took home the pot. Eventually, leagues moved online so that computers could do the math, but the scrappy ethos remained. In 2006, lawmakers banned online gambling, but they exempted fantasy pools. They didn’t want the F.B.I. kicking down the doors of suburban dads on N.F.L. Sunday.

Nigel Eccles, a sandy-haired former McKinsey consultant, grew up on a dairy farm in Northern Ireland and knew nothing about American sports. But he saw that there was an opportunity to monetize the endless optimism of dudes who think they know ball. Eccles founded FanDuel out of his home in Edinburgh, in 2009, and began offering weekly, or sometimes daily, fantasy competitions. Pay an entry fee, draft a football team to compete against scores of strangers on the internet. If your team is good, you win some money; if it’s terrible, you can try again the next day. The action never stopped. “People love fantasy, and the idea that you could take something they love and make it faster, more exciting, give it real money, and they could play it on their phone was just, like, Yes, yes, definitely yes,” Eccles has said. (He left the company in 2017.) DraftKings launched soon after. In 2011, FanDuel had one U.S.-based salesperson, who worked out of a home office. Four years later, it had a forty-thousand-square-foot headquarters in the Flatiron district, with seats from the original Yankee Stadium. It also had a billion-dollar valuation.

The ad blitz brought in millions of new players, but it also drew scrutiny. To observers, the apps looked a lot like illegal sportsbooks. They collected entry fees that were essentially bets on a player’s performance, and kept a cut of around ten per cent. ESPN reported that FanDuel pitched investors on targeting players with a “higher preponderance to gambling.” In 2015, Jim Leach, a former congressman from Iowa who had co-sponsored the ban with the fantasy-sports carve-out, said he’d had no idea that it would “morph into today’s cauldron of daily betting.” By 2016, states were sending cease-and-desist letters to FanDuel and DraftKings, and both were facing bankruptcy.

That’s when they caught a lucky break. A couple of years before, New Jersey, hoping to revitalize Atlantic City, had attempted to legalize sports betting, eventually arguing in a lawsuit that the national ban violated states’ rights. In 2018, the Supreme Court struck down the ban, permitting states to decide for themselves. Jeremy Kudon, a lobbyist working for FanDuel and DraftKings, then started in on a plan called Project Aftermath. (“I’d just seen the N.W.A. movie, and that’s what Dre names his company after Death Row,” he said, laughing.) He went state to state, leaning into the similarities between sports betting and fantasy competitions. “I’d meet with legislators who were, like, ‘Didn’t we pass this already?’ ” he said.

Kudon had a powerful new ally. In the early nineties, major professional-league commissioners had testified in support of the sports-betting ban. “We should not gamble with our children’s heroes,” Paul Tagliabue, the N.F.L. commissioner at the time, said. The leagues even sued New Jersey to defend the ban. But by 2015 they had also cashed in on fantasy-sports deals. The N.B.A. became a direct investor in FanDuel, and M.L.B. in DraftKings. Twenty-eight of thirty-two N.F.L. teams formed partnerships with at least one of the companies. FanDuel, wooing the leagues, cited research showing that its customers watched forty per cent more sports after becoming members. The year after the Supreme Court ruling, the leagues were prepared to capitalize on the legalization of sports betting; the N.B.A. even advocated for it. “The data is clear,” Adam Silver, the N.B.A. commissioner, said at the time. “If someone has a bet on a game, even a small bet, they’re much more likely to engage in that match.”

Silver became the public face of the leagues’ flip-flop. The day after the N.B.A. closed on its deal with FanDuel, in 2014, Silver wrote an Op-Ed in the *Times* calling for sports betting to be legalized nationwide. He argued that Americans were already betting huge sums in unregulated markets. “Some estimate that nearly four hundred billion dollars is illegally wagered on sports each year,” he wrote. This figure was later debunked, but the idea allowed the leagues to appeal to the same sentimentality that they’d once used to argue against gambling—the purity of the games was at stake. Kudon began lobbying lawmakers with famous athletes by his side. “Everybody has a pennant for their favorite baseball team,” he said. “Nobody has a pennant for their favorite casino.” The effect was obvious.

“We brought Joe Torre to the New York State Legislature,” he said, referring to the former manager of the Yankees. “And I watched grown men cry. I mean, people were weeping.”

Traditional casino giants like MGM and Caesars didn’t see what was coming. Sports gambling is typically a small slice of the betting pie relative to roulette and slots. The big casinos “were kind of almost patting us on the head: ‘What are you guys doing?’ ” Kudon joked. The casinos started building apps, but FanDuel and DraftKings were already on everyone’s phone. MGM and Caesars were like shops at the mall; FanDuel was Amazon.

By the end of 2021, thirty states and Washington, D.C., had legalized sports betting, many crafting legislation with substantial input from industry lobbyists. The companies launched another ad blitz. A study by McKinsey found that just five per cent of fantasy-baseball players were responsible for seventy per cent of the businesses’ profits. In a pitch to investors, according to ESPN, FanDuel noted internal data showing that twenty per cent of its customers would describe themselves as “a bit of an addict.” The companies spent a fortune on promotions, but it was nothing compared with the “customer lifetime value” of the guy who stuck around, day after day, to try his luck.

Strangers have always stared at Jontay Porter because of his height. Recently, I visited him at his brother’s house in Columbia, where he dipped under doorframes and moved through the living room like a parent navigating a child’s play fort. “There’s times where I wish I just lived a normal life,” he said. His size makes it difficult to find clothes that fit, or to squeeze into a commercial-airline seat. Still, he told me that he never once thought about buying a first-class ticket to get extra legroom. He saw himself as a frugal person.

Jontay had been fixated on money since childhood. In seventh grade, he started a side hustle fixing iPhone screens. At fifteen, he got hold of his mom’s driver’s license to create a Coinbase account, and bought bitcoin before most people had any idea what it was. He watched the price soar, and bought his first car with the proceeds. “I felt like, I’m better than these hedge-fund guys,” he said.

After his knee injury, he signed up for a Robinhood account and began day-trading stocks. In the N.B.A., ungodly money was the norm. “You’re just used to guys that are spending three thousand dollars on a bottle of wine at dinner,” he said. Jontay began to enjoy a reputation in the league as a market guru. He went “diamond hands” on meme stocks like Big 5 Sporting Goods and GameStop. This fuelled his belief that he didn’t need basketball to make what he called “N.B.A. F-U money.” (He rarely curses.) Soon, he and a partner were selling stock tips to subscribers on Discord through a company that he started called the Financial Cloud. “We couldn’t technically give financial advice, because we’re not licensed,” Jontay said. “We had automated algorithms that would spit out alerts of stocks to go buy.”

Robinhood’s interface was gamified: digital confetti exploded on the screen after customers placed a trade. “It looks like a casino,” Jontay said. “I’m not a scientist, you know. But that type of thing that gambling fed? Robinhood did the same thing.” He started playing a little blackjack on offshore-casino sites such as Stake, later made famous by the rapper Drake, who regularly streams six-figure bets. Jontay signed up for FanDuel two months shy of his twenty-first birthday. (He was underage, which made it illegal to sign up, but this didn’t seem to pose a problem.)

For Jontay, there was truth to Paul Newman’s iconic line from “The Color of Money”—that money won is twice as sweet as money earned. He made a hundred thousand dollars on an unlikely ten-leg college-baseball parlay. But there were warning signs. He told me about his first big bet, on the Chiefs, yet he had memory-holed the fact that, the same weekend, he’d made a hundred and forty-three other bets for more than a million dollars. When I reviewed his transaction history and texted him about them, he replied, “Omg!!!! No way.”

Jontay’s family gave him the benefit of the doubt. He was bashful, but his brother Michael seemed to enjoy stirring up controversy. Michael had suggested that the *COVID* vaccine was a means of population control, and once warned that kids who attend public school might one day identify as “a cat.” He recently said that, when he’s dating women, he will “throw on some Andrew Tate and see how they react.” These takes, some offered on

his own podcast, “Curious Mike,” have led fans to give him the nickname *MAGA* Porter, Jr. (More tragically, Jontay’s younger brother Coban, in 2024, pleaded guilty to vehicular manslaughter for driving drunk and causing a crash that killed a young mother. Two weeks after his sentencing, another brother, Jevon, got a D.U.I.) Jontay, by contrast, had never so much as stayed out past curfew.

Around the time Jontay started gambling, he began a long-distance relationship with a woman from Seattle named Kelli Kingma. She hadn’t initially been interested in him, because he played in the N.B.A. “I wanted a normal life,” she told me. But, she added, “I fell for how kind and humble and gentle he was. He seemed so innocent.” In 2021, he decided to sell his house. Kelli hoped to use the money to start a nest egg. What she didn’t know was that Jontay had taken out a five-hundred-thousand-dollar loan against the house, and then lost it all gambling. When he realized that she was sure to learn his secret, he panicked. “I’m instantly, like, I gotta make that five hundred thousand back real quick,” he said. While driving his Tesla from Memphis to his parents’ house, in Missouri, he put the car on Autopilot and spent the whole six-hour trip playing blackjack on his phone. By the end of the drive, he had lost another two hundred thousand dollars.

Later that month, Jontay holed up at his brother’s penthouse in Denver and opened FanDuel. He had discovered that his favorite sport to bet on wasn’t football; it was table tennis. It can take weeks to make money from a stock trade. But “a Ping-Pong match, it takes fifteen minutes,” he told me. FanDuel let players “live bet” a match while it was happening. Starting around midnight, he began repeatedly betting hundreds of thousands of dollars on Russian table tennis. “It’s exhilarating because, in your mind, your whole life rides on how good a serve this Ping-Pong guy has,” Jontay said. “It drives you insane, quite literally. Eyes bloodshot. Staring at the screen. I think you’re addicted to the thrill of the in-between, when you don’t know if it’s going to win or lose.” He bet for nearly three days straight, and won more than a million dollars.

Jontay called Kelli ecstatic. He told her that he’d earned the money trading futures. “I was super proud,” he said. “But she was equally, if not more, hurt.” Kelli was a financial adviser, and the story didn’t add up: what edge

could her basketball-player boyfriend possibly have in commodities trading? She pressed him for details, but, ultimately, she backed down. “When you’re close to people, your own perspective makes you cling to things you want to be true,” she said. “I just wanted to get married. And I trusted that it was all O.K.”



Jontay playing for the Toronto Raptors, in 2024.Photograph by Rick Osentoski / USA TODAY / Reuters

Frank Cardenas started a job as a V.I.P. account manager at FanDuel a few months before Jontay began betting. At forty-two, Cardenas is a natural sportsbook host—classically good-looking yet weathered, like an aging frat guy. He had been working in casinos since he was sixteen, when he handled greyhounds at a dog track in Iowa. At FanDuel, part of his job was to scout big bettors. Poring over spreadsheets of fresh betting data, he quickly spotted Jontay. “I looked at his wagering history and I was, like, Damn,” he said. “I know that a guy making this many bets, betting every single game in the world right now, he doesn’t have some edge. He’s just a hard-core gambler.”

Online sportsbooks like FanDuel and DraftKings offer V.I.P. programs modelled on the perks that Vegas casinos provide for high rollers. DraftKings V.I.P.s can win the kinds of prizes one might expect (golf clubs, a Peloton) but also more exotic ones (a thirty-thousand-dollar crystal decanter of rare Cognac, a trip to the Pyramids of Giza). Cardenas regularly hosted clients in box suites for sporting events. He bought them steak dinners and took them to swank night clubs, where bottle-service girls in bikini tops lit sparklers and served alcohol under a banner that read “We bet on FanDuel only!” He took them to parties with Chris Rock, and to a track

where they test-drove Porsches. The purpose of it all was to keep them betting.

The irony was that, to be a V.I.P., you had to be a loser. Unlike Vegas casinos, where hosts typically confirm the assets of their mega-rich whales, online sportsbooks don't typically do so. Some of Cardenas's clients were wealthy. But a V.I.P. could also be a "Taco Bell manager" who "was betting five hundred dollars a week, and then it goes up to two thousand," he said. Bettors who show a propensity for winning often face restrictions on the apps, or are sometimes even banned. Isaac Rose-Berman, a professional tennis "sharp" and a gambling researcher, told me that, when he tried to place a bet on FanDuel predicting the winner of a tournament last summer, the app gave him a maximum wager of a hundred and ninety dollars. His friend, a V.I.P., could make the same bet for seventy-six thousand. "These are companies that want to make the most amount of money," he said. "That's their prerogative."

Some pros will make dumb bets just to get V.I.P. status, so that they can unlock higher betting limits. It's also now a common (though prohibited) practice to pay existing V.I.P.s for access to their accounts. I talked to two of these "straw bettors"—people who loved sports and jumped at the chance to let someone else bet for them as long as they could use the box seats. They expected a raucous atmosphere at the games they attended, with V.I.P.s living like kings. But both found quiet rooms of young men glued to their phones, placing bets. "Every other person in this box must be a gambling addict," one told me. "It was profoundly joyless." The other told me that, once his pro started winning, he never heard from his V.I.P. host again.

The real V.I.P.s, Cardenas said, are the people who "just can't stay away." I spoke with a former client of his whom I'll call Chris. He told me that he had bet more than a billion dollars in two decades of relentless gambling, and that he'd tried "every modality of treatment" to quit. "My life's been an absolute disaster for twenty-one years," he said. "I'm getting evicted. I have a one-year-old daughter." But nothing has worked. "I'm a zombie. Sex is whatever. Food is whatever. Everything is so mundane—unless I get a hundred thousand on a parlay."

Jontay's habits would have raised a red flag with any mental-health professional. One week, Cardenas told me, Jontay wagered more money than anyone else on FanDuel. Harry Levant, a counsellor and gambling-recovery coach who is one of the country's leading experts on gambling addiction, and a recovering addict himself, told me, "Here's a sentence that has never in the history of mankind been uttered. You ready? 'I know what I want to do with my money for enjoyment purposes today. I'm going to go bet on Ping-Pong from the Czech Republic.' "

Cardenas wasn't directly compensated for his clients' losses, but, per a job posting, V.I.P. hosts were expected to use their clients to "drive revenue." "These guys make all our money for us," Cardenas said. When he first welcomed Jontay to the V.I.P. program, he sent him a bonus of ten thousand dollars to gamble with. For Jontay, it was a rush. He was used to offshore-casino apps in which he had to "beg for a bonus after losing" so that he could keep playing. When Jontay asked for another ten thousand the next night, Cardenas gave it to him. The following day, Cardenas got a call from a supervisor. "I got my ass chewed out," Cardenas said. " 'Don't you give him another dollar without our say-so!' " Cardenas was in trouble not only because he'd exceeded his discretionary-bonus limit but also because he'd given out the extra bonus while Jontay was winning. "Yeah, he might be up off 'Monday Night Football,' " Cardenas said. "But we're gonna get the money back." The next day, Jontay lost six hundred thousand dollars. Cardenas's bosses quit scolding him. Then the company gave Jontay another thirty-five thousand dollars in credit.



Frank Cardenas, Jontay's V.I.P. host at FanDuel.Photograph by Caitlin O'Hara for The New Yorker

FanDuel didn’t ask Jontay for proof of his income. All he needed was his name. “It’s right away known that he’s a basketball player,” Cardenas said. “And it doesn’t take much of a deeper dive to find out he’s M.P.J.’s brother.” Michael had recently signed a contract extension with the Nuggets worth more than two hundred million dollars. “There was certainly a sentiment at some point, like, Well, what’s the big deal if M.P.J. has to break him off a million?” Cardenas said. Early on, the accounts team noticed that Jontay had made more than thirty million dollars’ worth of bets during his first two weeks on FanDuel, and when Jontay didn’t respond to an e-mail asking whether he was “comfortable” with his “level of spending,” his account was briefly suspended. Cardenas berated the employees, pointing out how much money Jontay’s brother had. Cardenas walked Jontay through replying, and FanDuel reactivated the account.

In fact, Cardenas said, the company had evidence to suggest that Jontay couldn’t afford his bets. Deposits from PayPal into Jontay’s FanDuel account were instant, but PayPal took a couple of days to actually withdraw the funds from a bank account. About a month after Jontay began betting on FanDuel, according to Cardenas, PayPal notified the company that Jontay owed half a million dollars in overdrawn deposits, and asked for help retrieving the funds. FanDuel decided to suspend Jontay’s account until receiving proof that he’d paid PayPal back. Cardenas said that the company could have used the incident to investigate how many V.I.P. players were betting with overdrawn deposits, though he speculated that the company didn’t want to know the answer. “A lot of these states don’t allow you to bet on credit,” he said. “But with PayPal you essentially can.”

A former FanDuel V.I.P.-program executive I spoke to defended the company’s actions, saying, of Jontay, “At no point when he was on FanDuel was he in such crazy debt.” When I suggested that FanDuel would have no way to know this without verifying Jontay’s finances, the executive agreed that there should be mandatory income checks and other safeguards, particularly for V.I.P. players. “It was never supposed to be twenty-four hours a day,” he said.

As one of the top V.I.P.s at FanDuel, Jontay was offered all kinds of perks: a new iPhone, courtside seats at N.B.A. games, tickets to the Super Bowl.

Jontay and Cardenas became friends. They texted almost every day. Jontay called him the "*goat* of bonuses." He told me that, while he was hiding his gambling from everyone else, it felt good to have someone who shared his secret. "Frank became why I stayed," he said.

The anthropologist Natasha Dow Schüll spent fifteen years studying how casinos developed electronic gambling machines such as slots and video poker. In her book "Addiction by Design," from 2012, she wrote that executives said the machines were engineered to increase "time on device" by entrancing players into a kind of dissociative state that came to be known as "the zone." The companies sped games up by increasing the lines in slots or the playable hands in blackjack and poker. They removed "frictions" like pulling levers or depositing coins. The machines flashed with bright lights and played rhythmic sounds. The zone was so hypnotic that some gamblers soiled themselves rather than leave their machines to go to the bathroom. A compulsive gambler named Mollie told Schüll, "The thing people never understand is that I'm not playing to win" but, rather, "to keep playing—to stay in that machine zone where nothing else matters." One industry consultant admitted that the goal was to keep players so enchanted that they stopped only because they ran out of money: to "play to extinction."

Traditional sports betting didn't have much in common with machine gambling. The hypnosis of the zone shared characteristics with the Skinner-box effect. Beginning in the nineteen-thirties, the behavioral scientist B. F. Skinner discovered that, when pigeons were given a lever that dispensed food pellets at random, as opposed to in a predictable pattern, they began to unceasingly peck at it. Unlike slot machines, sports bets were not random. Games were narrative contests. There was a limited number of bets that a player could make, and matches took hours to resolve.

But FanDuel and DraftKings found ways to increase the speed and the volume of sports betting. They offered bets on everything from soccer to jai alai, to insure that there was always something to bet on. In Colorado, one of only a few states that publish the amounts wagered by sport, table tennis, which is prized among gamblers for its speed, is now the fourth most popular, ranking above soccer and hockey. Professional leagues agreed to

lucrative licensing deals to sell their official stats, allowing sportsbooks to offer a dizzying number of in-game “prop bets.” Now, in a football game, you can bet not just on who will win but also on the next guy to score a touchdown, and whether a drive is going to end in a punt. During the last Super Bowl, you could’ve built a parlay betting that no one would cry during the national anthem, that Bad Bunny’s first song during the halftime show would be “Tití Me Preguntó,” that the color of the Gatorade dumped on the winning coach would be red, and that the game’s M.V.P. would thank Jesus first during his post-game speech. Ten bucks to win five hundred and seventy-two—but you would’ve lost, because the Gatorade was yellow.

The thing is, sports betting is fun. I love college football, and one time I bet twenty dollars on a long-shot parlay that six underdog teams would all win their games. The sixth game went into four overtimes, and, when my team won, I raised my fists in triumph. I won a thousand dollars, and felt like I’d succeeded because I was smart, not lucky. One of FanDuel’s taglines is “Make Every Moment More.” By taking endless moments and making them bets, the company has made football look a lot like a multiline slot machine. I wondered how many more bets I would need to place before I found my way to Russian Ping-Pong.

Our phones are already addictive, in the way of Skinner boxes. Sports-betting apps operate less like casinos than like TikTok or Instagram, using thousands of personalized data points to keep gamblers engaged. “It’s a perfect sort of surveillance-capitalism story,” Schüll told me. She pointed to a 2005 study showing that people who live within ten miles of a large-scale gaming operation are ninety per cent likelier to develop a gambling problem. Now we all have casinos in our pockets. “Bathroom stalls, more than we’d like to think, are now the sites of sports betting,” Schüll said.

The result has been the largest expansion of gambling in American history. In 2017, the year before the sports-betting ban was overturned, Americans wagered about five billion dollars on sports through official channels. Last year, they bet more than a hundred and sixty billion. Half of men under fifty now have a sports-betting account. Not long ago, broadcasters avoided even a hint of gambling conversation. These days, N.B.A. games feature

FanDuel betting odds onscreen. LeBron James has starred in DraftKings ads and has shared custom N.F.L. parlays.

We are just beginning to understand the ramifications. A recent study found that gambling addiction has risen by sixty per cent in states that have legalized sports betting. “The evidence is overwhelming that expanded sports betting has led to increased harm on a national scale,” Keith Whyte, who led the National Council on Problem Gambling for more than two decades, told Congress in 2024. (He has since become a safety consultant for online sportsbooks and has advocated for more states to legalize betting.) A national survey found that forty-three per cent of thirteen-to-seventeen-year-olds had gambled in the past year, and that ten per cent of them qualified as high-risk problem gamblers. An addiction counsellor in New Jersey recently said that one of her clients, a fifteen-year-old boy, had stolen his parents’ and grandparents’ Social Security numbers to create four FanDuel accounts, and had bet nine hundred thousand dollars in a single year. Rose-Berman, the professional bettor, told me that he gives regular talks in high schools about the dangers of gambling, only to find a line of teen-age boys afterward waiting to ask what he thinks of their bets. He noted parallels between the normalization of gambling culture and the Joe Camel ads that helped make smoking cool among young people. “In five, ten years, we’re going to look back and be, like, Why the fuck is LeBron James doing these ads?” he said.

Sports-betting companies claim that they don’t want addicts to gamble. But chasing those most likely to gamble often means chasing addicts. In a case that recently became a scandal in the U.K., Sky Bet, a subsidiary of FanDuel’s parent company, was accused of targeting a compulsive gambler. The player, who went by RTM in court, began gambling after taking advantage of a free promotion and soon developed an addiction. Sky Bet ultimately collected thousands of data points to build a “propensity model” that would predict his behavior. He tried to quit, but Sky Bet had labelled him a “high value” customer and sent him targeted e-mails and bonus credit to keep him playing. He eventually lost his entire life savings, and came close to killing himself. “They took his addiction and turned it into code,” Ravi Naik, RTM’s lawyer, told me. “We know that online-gambling companies use those codes to algorithmically target, in the U.K. and across

the world.” (The case is pending at the U.K. Supreme Court.) A recent *Times* investigation found that DraftKings used artificial intelligence to send compulsive gamblers promotions and free-bet credits, but declined to use the technology to help identify at-risk bettors.

Whereas the algorithms find the people who are most likely to gamble, the V.I.P. host provides the human connection to keep them going. Several lawsuits in the United States allege that online sportsbooks use V.I.P. programs to groom addicted gamblers. In one case, a V.I.P. lost more than a hundred and fifty thousand dollars in four months; she was offered promotional credits even after she asked her V.I.P. host if DraftKings could give her a loan to help her pay her mortgage. “Probably means I need to quit gambling soon,” she messaged. (The case was settled before trial.) In another case, a V.I.P. realized that he was addicted and asked DraftKings to close his account. A month later, he realized that he could still log in, relapsed, and lost three hundred and fifty thousand dollars. (DraftKings won the case, and it is being appealed.) Matthew Litt, a lawyer who has filed several suits against DraftKings and FanDuel, said, “The scale of it? I think we haven’t even scratched the surface.” (DraftKings and FanDuel declined to comment on pending litigation, but, in court documents, both deny any wrongdoing.)

Cardenas, Jontay’s V.I.P. host, once asked his boss what percentage of V.I.P.s he thought had a gambling problem. “He says, ‘Oh, I don’t know,’ ” Cardenas recalled. “And I said, ‘Well, I do know. It’s about a hundred per cent.’ ” He added, “What is problem gambling? Is there a specific sign? Yeah, when they get into the V.I.P. program. That’s when I know they’re a problem gambler.”

In 2022, Jontay married Kelli on a golf course in Seattle, with panoramic views of Mt. Rainier. Their wedding photos document a day of joy: feeding each other cake, laughing with friends on the dance floor. In one, Jontay is on a balcony as Kelli sneaks up behind him for their “first look.” “I’m looking out at the beautiful horizon,” Jontay said. “And I’m just thinking about the four bets I need to hit to be able to pay back a bookie.”

The first year of their marriage was tumultuous. Kelli discovered Jontay’s gambling problem soon after the wedding. She cut off his access to their

joint accounts, but at night he would Venmo himself from her phone, hoping to put the money back before she woke up in the morning. He gambled with her credit cards and then insisted that it was fraud. On Thanksgiving Day, he stole thousands of dollars from his mother's Apple Pay. "Literally, I got shingles twice," Kelli said. "I was so sick." The following year, Jontay's family staged a tearful intervention. Michael paid for a thirty-day treatment at a top facility in Florida. Jontay went to group therapy and read the Bible. He promised he would get clean. Kelli thought the worst was over.

Jontay had also managed to resurrect his basketball career. His knees had improved, and in December, 2023, he was offered a contract with the Toronto Raptors. He and Kelli moved into a condo in Toronto. He played his first game in early January. "It's quite the comeback story, I guess," he told a reporter afterward. "Hopefully, it has a happy ending."

But, behind the scenes, the gambling hadn't stopped. By that point, Jontay had bet more than fifty million dollars on FanDuel and, through a friend's account, millions on DraftKings. He'd lost millions in cryptocurrency gambling on such sites as Stake. "I was pretty much living off scraps," he said. "I was sitting in my locker, like, leaned back so nobody can see my phone, watching college basketball, betting on that."

In 2022, Jontay had met Johnny Kalaj, a heavily tattooed fitness influencer. Jontay asked Kalaj if he knew any bookies who would let him bet on credit. Kalaj hooked him up with a group that he called "the Jews." Jontay came to understand this to be the Jewish mafia. Within two weeks, he had lost more than a hundred and sixty thousand dollars. When he didn't pay his balance, Kalaj texted him: "Tay you think I'm joking when I say these are the worst people." When Jontay asked if they would kill him if he didn't pay, Kalaj told him that they didn't "deal in violence." What they did was "worse." "These are the type of people who hack your computer, fill it with kid porn and alert police," he wrote.

Kalaj eventually said that he had paid off the debt for Jontay by selling two expensive watches. "What I just did, you fucking owe me," Kalaj texted. After a year, Jontay still hadn't paid Kalaj back, and Kalaj threatened to go public with Jontay's gambling. "Just do the right thing. I swear on my

mother I dnt want to take the next step," Kalaj texted. (Kalaj did not respond to multiple requests for comment.) Jontay also owed money to an Antiguan politician he'd met at rehab named Asot Michael. "You want me to finish you?" Asot texted him. "You better send my money today Jontay or I'm exposing you." (Asot was later murdered, for unrelated reasons.)

But Jontay interacted most with another bookie whom Kalaj had introduced him to named Ammar Awawdeh, a thirty-five-year-old Palestinian American with a thick build, soft brown eyes, and the vibe of a Spike Lee character. His family owns grocery stores in New York City. He bragged about having run "the biggest poker games in New York City," with guest lists that included Leonardo DiCaprio, Kevin Hart, and the N.B.A. All-Star Paul Pierce. He told me that, while the Lakers were visiting New York, LeBron James had once rented a house where Awawdeh hosted poker games. (A representative for DiCaprio declined to comment. James's spokesperson denied that he had rented the house. Pierce and Hart did not respond to requests for comment.) Though Awawdeh was friendly, Jontay knew that he was connected to some dangerous associates, including the Gambino crime family in New York.

What happened next is a bit of a black box, because most of the planning occurred on the encrypted messaging service Telegram, and the messages were deleted. Jontay says that, about a week after making his début with the Raptors, he had dinner with Awawdeh in New York, their only time meeting in person. Now that Jontay was back in the N.B.A., his stats were also potential bets. According to Jontay, Awawdeh suggested that, to pay back the money, he could do a "special": fake an injury or an illness so that the "unders" on his stats all hit, like a boxer taking a dive in a fight.

Awawdeh claims that this was Jontay's idea. "I was, like, 'Hey, listen, I'll go sit courtside and watch you fucking poke your eye out in person,' " Awawdeh said. Regardless, the pair agreed on a plan. Jontay was initially nervous, but Awawdeh told me that he and his friend Bruce Pham were confident that Jontay would get away with it. Pham was part of a crew that had allegedly done this before, using a player far more prominent than Jontay: a guard for the Charlotte Hornets named Terry Rozier. Awawdeh and Pham told Jontay that they would spread the bets across multiple

sportsbooks, including on offshore sites, to make them harder to trace. With his cut, Jontay could pay off all of his debts. He would finally be free.



Jontay outside his home last year.Photograph by Sarah Blesener for The New Yorker

Last year, I met Awawdeh at his apartment, in a waterfront building in Brooklyn. He wore a Yankees hoodie, and a sunset view of Manhattan filled the floor-to-ceiling windows behind him. He had recently been arrested, and he recounted how federal agents had swarmed the building. “I smiled at them,” he said. “It’s a fucking gambling case, and they’re treating me like I’m Pablo Escobar.”

In October, 2025, the Justice Department unveiled charges in a far-reaching N.B.A.-betting conspiracy involving Awawdeh’s crew and three of New York’s five Mafia families. Prosecutors allege that Awawdeh and some thirty co-conspirators helped rig several high-stakes poker games that cost unwitting players more than seven million dollars. Chauncey Billups, a basketball hall of famer and the head coach of the Portland Trail Blazers,

and Damon Jones, a former player and assistant coach, were paid to act as “face cards,” helping to recruit players for the games. (Jones has pleaded guilty to a wire-fraud charge. Billups has pleaded not guilty. Neither responded to requests for comment.) Awawdeh and his crew then deployed hacked shuffle machines, electronic chip trays with hidden cameras, and even special glasses that allowed people in on the scam to read marked cards.

Poker was only part of the con. Billups and Jones allegedly also shared inside information with sports bettors in Awawdeh’s circle, including Pham and a friend named Shane Hennen, which they then used to place bets. (Pham and Hennen both pleaded guilty.) Jones, for example, purportedly texted one of the co-defendants that LeBron James, a close friend of his, would be sitting out a game in 2023 because of an injury. A co-conspirator is said to have paid Rozier seventy thousand dollars to fake an injury and exit a game. (Rozier has pleaded not guilty, and did not respond to requests for comment.) Kash Patel, the F.B.I. director, called the scheme “the insider-trading scandal of the N.B.A.”

On January 26, 2024, Jontay suited up to play the Los Angeles Clippers. His mom, Lisa, was in the crowd—her first chance to see him play in the N.B.A. again. He checked in late in the first quarter and grabbed a few rebounds, but didn’t take any shots. “I don’t remember too much,” Jontay said. “You’re buzzing, you know? It’s a lot on the line.” At the end of the first quarter, a ball bounced off the rim and he started to reach for it, then awkwardly tapped it toward a teammate. Footage shows him walking off the court and pointing to his left eye, as if it were hurt. He had gotten poked in the eye in the previous game, and he told me that this seemed easier than inventing a new injury. It wasn’t until he was sitting in the hospital, having his eye checked out, with Kelli and his mom by his side, that the realization of what he’d done set in. “Just an overwhelming amount of shame,” he said. “It felt like I was taking advantage of the very thing that gave me the world.”



The hall of famer Chauncey Billups; Terry Rozier, formerly of the Miami Heat; and Damon Jones, a former assistant coach, were all caught up in a betting scandal in 2025.Photographs by Soobum Im / Getty; Carmen Mandato / Getty; Andres Kudacki / Getty

Worst of all, the plan didn't even work. DraftKings noted that the unders on Jontay's stats were the most profitable bet of the whole night, a surprise for such a small-time player. But Awawdeh said that, because of spending limits that they hadn't anticipated, they couldn't put enough money down to clear Jontay's debt. They pressed him to do it again. For weeks, Jontay resisted.

By that time, Awawdeh had put Jontay in touch by text with a guy named Vinny, whom Jontay understood to be a bookie for the Italian Mafia. Soon, Jontay owed Vinny some two hundred thousand dollars. According to Jontay, Awawdeh warned that Vinny had just been released from prison for manslaughter, and "didn't take kindly to people who crossed him." One gambler who hadn't paid his debt, Awawdeh told him, was tied to a chair in a warehouse and had his finger cut off before giving up his crypto wallet. (Awawdeh denies saying this.) Jontay said that, at one point, he received a threat that enforcers would pay Kelli a visit in Toronto. "I guess that was my weak spot," he said. Kelli had recently told him that she was pregnant, and Jontay didn't want to bring a child into the world with a gambling debt to the Mob hanging over his head.

In March, 2024, Jontay pulled himself out of a game against the Sacramento Kings, saying that he felt sick. Meanwhile, Awawdeh went with Pham, their friend Timothy McCormack, and a friend of Jontay's named Mahmud Mollah to a brick-and-mortar DraftKings location in Atlantic City. According to prosecutors, surveillance footage shows them approaching the casino cage with a blue gift bag full of cash and handing the money to a

teller. They made at least seven parlays against Jontay's stats, which would have paid out for more than a million dollars.

Instead, the bets were immediately flagged. Sportsbooks track bets in real time and use algorithms to spot suspicious activity. A huge parlay on LeBron James would earn a second look. One on Jontay Porter, a little-known reserve, might as well have been a confession. The minute Jontay took himself out of the game, a digital dye pack exploded all over their cash. (FanDuel and DraftKings, unlike illegal operators, can accept suspicious bets because if a bet loses they can keep the money, and if it wins they can notify law enforcement and will likely never have to pay out.) Jontay didn't know it at the time, but the plan had also been leaked to other co-conspirators. Similar bets had been placed on several other sportsbooks. DraftKings reported the activity. (Mollah, Pham, and McCormack have all pleaded guilty to wire-fraud charges.)

A few days later, while taking a pre-game nap in a hotel suite, Jontay got a call from the Raptors' general manager, who told him that he was under investigation for "suspicious betting activity." "I knew I was toast," he said.

He was soon banned from the N.B.A. Kelli considered divorcing him. Jontay Googled whether or not he could still go to Heaven if he killed himself. He bought a gun. "There was one incident where I—I don't even think my wife knows this—but I held it to my head and I was just crying: 'I can't do this anymore,' " he said. Gambling has the highest suicide rate of any addiction; nearly twenty per cent of addicts attempt to take their own lives. But, as he thought about pulling the trigger, he imagined his unborn son. "I can't leave this earth without meeting him," he said.

Jontay flew to New York and turned himself in. He walked past a holding cell and noticed the size of the toilet. It was so small. He glanced at the twin-size prison cot. Would he even fit? "That moment, I was, like, This could really be my future," he said.

Three days after the news of the investigation broke, Jontay got an e-mail from FanDuel. A few months earlier, his account had been deactivated because he had tried to place a bet with a co-conspirator's debit card. This

time, the e-mail offered to reactivate his account if he could provide proof of income.

In 1994, the C.E.O.s of the seven major American tobacco companies denied before Congress that nicotine was addictive. The testimony earned them the nickname the Seven Dwarfs. Soon after, Frank Fahrenkopf, the founder of the American Gaming Association, a trade organization that represents gambling operators, brought a photo of the tobacco C.E.O.s into a meeting of casino executives. “This is not what we’re going to do,” he said. “We’re not going to lie.” Fahrenkopf was a political operative—he had once been the head of the Republican National Committee—and he understood how important public opinion was to his industry’s long-term success.

The casino executives acknowledged that gambling addiction was real, though they downplayed its prevalence. They convinced lawmakers that a self-regulatory framework was sufficient to protect consumers, calling it “responsible gaming.” Casinos helped fund organizations combatting addiction, such as the National Council on Problem Gambling, and gave gamblers voluntary tools, like deposit limits and self-exclusion lists, which allow people to effectively ban themselves from gambling operations. But, ultimately, they put the responsibility on the gambler.

FanDuel and DraftKings both declined to answer questions for this piece, but they affirmed their commitment to responsible gambling. They pointed to tools like Real-Time Check-In, which uses A.I. to monitor players’ deposits, and My Budget Builder, which makes it easier for customers to set spending limits. They offer free telehealth therapy for players who self-exclude. Marketing material is tagged with information about how to access gambling-addiction resources. In a statement, FanDuel acknowledged making “significant changes” since Jontay’s time in the V.I.P. program, including “additional employee training” and “proactive account reviews when concerning play patterns are detected.”

But Rose-Berman, the professional bettor, pointed out the absurdity of asking addicts to resist modern technology companies. “Alcohol stores don’t give you a coupon for a free drink if you’ve taken a week off drinking,” he said. “It used to be man versus vice. Now it’s man versus vice

combined with a billion-dollar tech company. That's not a fair fight." Multiple studies have shown that casinos make most of their money from a small percentage of users. I recently obtained data collected by FanDuel's V.I.P. program during the time that Jontay played. V.I.P. players made up less than half a per cent of the company's monthly users, but were responsible for nearly six hundred million dollars in revenue. FanDuel reportedly had two billion dollars in revenue that year. "It's just very hard for me not to believe that this industry only exists because of people who are harmed," Brianne Doura-Schawohl, a lobbyist pushing for stronger regulations, said.

None of the experts I spoke to think that we're going back to the days of prohibition. Sports betting has become too big to deconstruct. But countries like the U.K. and Australia, both of which legalized online gambling well before the United States, have put laws in place to curb predatory behavior. They have cracked down on V.I.P. programs, implemented mandatory affordability checks, curtailed opportunities for constant prop bets, and limited advertising during televised games. So far, the industry has fought similar regulations in the U.S. Experts worry that the result is a looming public-health crisis. "Mr. Porter is not a bad person who tried to do harm," Levant, the counsellor, told me. "He's a gambling addict in a world where the government has given license to these companies to take these people for everything."

As the leagues have raked in exorbitant additional revenue from sports-betting partnerships and increased viewership, many athletes have found themselves mired in scandal. A study of European athletes showed that a third bet on their own sport. The N.F.L. has suspended several players, including Calvin Ridley and Jameson Williams, for breaking league gambling rules. The former Detroit Pistons guard Malik Beasley recently pleaded guilty to manipulating his prop bets. Prosecutors indicted two Cleveland Guardians pitchers for conspiring with bettors to intentionally miss the strike zone. (Both have pleaded not guilty.)

When I spoke to Cardenas, the V.I.P. host, he was reckoning with his role in all of this. He had been fired from FanDuel shortly after the Jontay Porter scandal broke, for violating the company's code of conduct. (Cardenas

claimed that the timing was a coincidence.) FanDuel, he said, had asked to review his personal cellphone and passwords after accusing him of having unsupervised communication with players. Cardenas refused. He did admit that, on a few occasions—and never as a kickback for Jontay's gambling with FanDuel—the two had loaned each other small amounts of money. "The code of conduct?" Cardenas scoffed. "I'm not the one with the moral deficiency. Their entire business model is legal theft." Cardenas himself is a gambling addict. (A study found that casino employees are nine times likelier than the general public to develop addictions.) He had been a V.I.P. on online sportsbooks such as BetMGM and Fanatics, and had lost money wagering on just about every sport: virtual horse racing, Icelandic women's basketball. That's what made him such a good host. "I find a job with FanDuel where it's, like, Hey, we want you to just text with V.I.P.s all day about sports betting," he said. "Yeah, it's kind of what I'm doing anyway." When we talked, last year, he had been evicted from his apartment, and was bouncing among friends' couches. He was trying to quit gambling, but he said, "I don't know who I am without it."

When I asked if he had regrets about encouraging an addict like Jontay to bet, he replied, "No one ever tried to stop me." Still, he was haunted by where it had led Jontay. "That's what I hate about gambling," he said. "It broke my heart."



Jontay with his wife and first child last year.Photograph by Sarah Blesener for The New Yorker

Last year, I watched Jontay play in a semi-professional basketball tournament in his home town of Columbia. I'd played basketball at Mizzou a decade before Jontay, and had been watching him since he was in high school, but I'd forgotten what a joy it was. The competition included former high-level college athletes, some making a living in professional leagues overseas, but, compared with them, Jontay seemed like a dad playing in the driveway with his kids. It was no N.B.A. arena, but he smiled a lot during the game. His family cheered from the sidelines. Jontay grabbed a rebound and flung the ball seventy-five feet to his younger brother Jevon, a perfect pass that ended in a dunk. "That boy crazy," a guy next to me said.

Jontay pleaded guilty to wire fraud. Fans now sometimes joke that when a player is struggling in a game he must be "pulling a Jontay." He didn't blame them. He also refused to deflect responsibility onto the sportsbooks

or his co-conspirators. “We live in a generation of consumerism and greed,” he said. “And I was the pinnacle of that.”

As I dug through the records of Jontay’s extortion, some details didn’t add up. Jontay dealt with the Jewish mafia and the Gambinos over text, but he never spoke with them directly. He placed bets on credit, and, when he paid after losing, he sent the money to Kalaj or Awawdeh. The phone number for “Murray,” Jontay’s point person from the Jewish mafia, came from what appears to be a burner-phone service provider with an office registered in midtown. The number for “Sal,” one of Vinny’s “enforcers,” came through the same carrier, even though the two organizations were supposed to be unrelated. When I traced Vinny’s number, it turned out to be registered to a person I recognized: Bruce Pham, Awawdeh’s partner.

It’s impossible to know for sure what all of this means. But multiple professional bettors and a source connected to the case told me they suspected that Awawdeh and Kalaj had pulled a common scam. Middlemen tell a bettor he’s placing bets with a bookie. If the bets win, they make an excuse not to pay. If the bets lose, they collect the money. On at least one occasion, Jontay was up nearly six figures, but Awawdeh didn’t pay him, citing Jontay’s previous late payments as a reason to void his winnings that week. When I pressed Awawdeh on whether Vinny was real, he got quiet and took a deep breath, then said, “A wise guy once told me, ‘Ask me no questions and I’ll tell you no lies.’ ” He wouldn’t say any more.

Awawdeh pleaded guilty to wire-fraud charges, and is scheduled to be sentenced next year. He’s out on bail, and hoping that his legitimate businesses will provide for his daughters when he goes to prison. He told me that gambling is a bigger problem among N.B.A. players than we yet understand, and that the league, by embracing sports betting, has opened a Pandora’s box. Awawdeh, too, is a gambling addict. He told me that it was partially his own gambling debts that had led him to get involved in the scams. He thought it was ironic that FanDuel and DraftKings (called Betting Company 1 and Betting Company 2 in the case) were technically the victims of Jontay’s crime. “The real criminals here are the guys in the suits—the guys who run FanDuel and DraftKings, and their N.B.A. partners,” he said. “You got Charles Barkley and Shaq talking about their

prop bets. Bro, there's little kids watching these games. This is the society they fuckin' built."

In Missouri, I asked Jontay if he ever thought about an alternate scenario in which he'd gotten out from under the debts, and was still playing in the N.B.A. "You don't stop the addiction until the pain of the addiction outweighs the pleasure," he said. He told me that one night, after he'd already racked up debts with the bookies, he played blackjack on his phone. He'd started the evening with twenty thousand dollars. "I'm winning a ton," he said. "I keep winning." By 4:30 *A.M.*, he was up a million dollars—enough to pay off all of his debts and start fresh. He began the withdrawal process, which takes a few hours, then closed his eyes to go to sleep. But, he said, "my brain is exploding. I wake up and I'm, like, I got to keep going." Within an hour, he'd lost it all. "I just won a million dollars that would have saved my life," he said. "And that wasn't enough for me."

Today, commercial gambling is ubiquitous. FanDuel and DraftKings are both lobbying states to pass "iGaming" bills that would legalize online casino games like blackjack and slots. It's obvious why: in the course of a month last year in Pennsylvania, where online casinos are legal, sports bettors lost twenty-seven million dollars; casino-game players lost more than two hundred million. Prediction markets like Kalshi and Polymarket are the new disrupters. They allow users to bet on the Rotten Tomatoes score of the new "Cat in the Hat" movie or on the number of people Donald Trump will deport. But sports betting is their most popular offering by far. They have circumvented state legislatures by arguing that a sports bet is simply a commodity-future contract, like betting on the price of wheat, and therefore already legal. FanDuel and DraftKings recently created their own prediction-market apps, which have enabled them to bring sports betting to Texas and California, where legalization has stalled.

Chris, the former FanDuel V.I.P., has spent a lot of time in manosphere-adjacent crowds online. He was troubled by the gambling fervor that he witnessed, but also understood it. "Doing things quote-unquote the right way? It didn't get us anywhere. We ended up broke," he said. "There's just a desperation from people who want to break free from the middle. And I think one of the clear and present ways to do that is massive risk. People are

just trying to gamble their way to the top.” According to a study, ninety per cent of young users believe that they will make money on sports betting. Yet only four per cent of accounts are profitable. Americans are now on track to lose a trillion dollars of personal wealth to commercialized gambling in the next five years. Bankruptcies are up nearly ten per cent in states that have legalized online sports betting.

Jontay estimated that he has wagered at least half a billion dollars in his life, but he hasn’t placed a bet since before his arrest, more than two years ago. Still, he doesn’t feel cured. He admitted that he sometimes missed the thrill of gambling. “This war on my soul is going to continue,” he said. He’s in regular therapy for his addiction. His relationship with Michael, which fractured after he was caught, has mended. Kelli stayed with him, and the couple had a second son. She now works while he stays at home with their children, changing diapers and taking them to the park. As we were speaking, he heard his older son, Jayce, waking up after a nap; he carried him back into the room and bounced him on his lap. When I asked if his boys would play basketball, he laughed. “Oh, yeah,” he said. “They don’t have a choice.” Jontay had regrets, but getting caught wasn’t one of them. “I’m thankful to God that the F.B.I. investigated,” he said. “Because if that didn’t happen, I wouldn’t be sitting here today.” ♦

Nick Berardini, a documentary filmmaker and a writer, has contributed to the Daily Beast, MSNBC.com, and The Intercept.

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The Control of Nature

What It Takes to Save a Town from Wildfire

Catastrophic blazes are exposing the limits of individual precautions. Can communities build a system of collective defense?

By Eric Klinenberg

November 9, 2026

Photography by Benjamin Rasmussen for The New Yorker

In 1991, when the city of Boulder asked Larry Donner to become its fire chief, he couldn't believe his luck. A Denver native, Donner was forty-two and working as the fire chief of Iowa City. He and his wife, Susan Loo, missed the natural beauty of the Rocky Mountains: rolling meadows, colorful wildflowers, dense forests, rushing creeks. They also missed the outdoor adventures and the community that came with them.

The kinds of outdoor adventures that Donner would contend with as fire chief, though, were stressful and dangerous—wildfires, damaging winds, flash floods—and Loo insisted that they find a home in a relatively safe area. "I didn't want Larry worrying about his own house when there was an emergency," she told me in September as the two of them sat at their dining-room table in bluejeans and T-shirts, casual as weekday hikers. They settled in Louisville, a pleasant suburb about nine miles southeast of

Boulder, surrounded by open grasslands. “We’re miles from the foothills where the forest fires happen,” explained Donner, now seventy-seven and retired, with thin gray hair, glasses, and skin marbled by the fierce Colorado sun. “I figured it was safe.”

Over the years, Donner worked hard to make his house fire-resistant. “I put in James Hardie board siding”—made of a noncombustible fibre-cement composite—“and a Class A fire-rated roof. I took a wood deck off the back, cleared out vegetation, and built a flagstone area next to the house. We had two giant spruce trees on the property that I just couldn’t cut down, but otherwise I thought I’d done everything.” In Boulder, he led a campaign in 1994 to ban wood shingles on new construction. “When you get a fire, they burn,” he said, “and in high winds they’re like Frisbees, flying torches.”

For thirty years, as Boulder endured major fires and floods, Donner’s home remained untouched. But, in 2021, the weather turned. The grasses grew four or five feet during a wet spring, and, after a dry fall, the result was “like a field of matchsticks, chest high,” Donner said. The meadows that historically buffered his home, protecting it from wildfires, had now turned into fuel.

On December 30th, a powerful windstorm swept down the Front Range foothills, with sustained winds in excess of forty-five miles an hour and gusts of up to a hundred. They rekindled a controlled debris fire on property occupied by Twelve Tribes, a fundamentalist Christian sect. Another fire was ignited by arcing power lines near the Marshall Mesa trailhead. At 11:05 *A.M.*, the Boulder County Sheriff’s Office dispatched firefighters to a conflagration spreading across dry grassland, fuelled by every shingle and shed in its path. The Marshall Fire, as it became known, rapidly consumed structures, advancing east at what Donner described as “the speed of wind.”

At 11:47 *A.M.*, authorities issued the first evacuation orders, expanding them continuously as hurricane-force winds projected airborne embers ahead of a roughly half-mile front across wide streets and even across a multi-lane highway near Donner’s development. “Once you get an urban conflagration, there’s really nothing you can do to stop it,” Donner told me. “Now the fuel isn’t just grassland. It’s every house that catches fire, sending heat and flames and flying embers to the houses next to them. No water

system is designed to handle an urban conflagration. It just collapses, and all you can do is pray.”

Donner and Loo say they saw the fire approach their neighborhood long before they received an evacuation order. They grabbed a few cherished items and drove to a relative’s home, where they turned on the TV. “I could see our house burning behind the reporter,” Donner recounted. “I’d been worried about the spruce trees catching, but they were fine. The problem was I hadn’t put ember shields on our vents. I needed about one-eighth-inch wire mesh to cover attic vents, which I could have gotten at Home Depot.” Without that, embers got into the attic. “Our house burned top down, then inside out.”

By the time the winds died, the Marshall Fire had destroyed more than a thousand structures and shattered communities. Donner and Loo lost nearly everything. Luckier neighbors, including a woman named Peggy Driscoll, returned to standing homes, but they were so saturated with smoke and soot that disaster-mitigation companies, after peeling them like onions for months, deemed them uninhabitable.



Susan Loo and Larry Donner, on their porch in Louisville, Colorado. They rebuilt their home on the same spot as their previous one, which burned down in the Marshall Fire.

“Look around,” Driscoll told me at her rebuilt mountain-modern-style house in unincorporated Boulder County. “It’s the suburbs. I’d always thought of wildfires as forest fires, and, since we’re not the typical landscape that burns, I didn’t think we were at risk.”

The Marshall Fire showed that the danger of wildfires is broader and more serious than most people realize. Once wildfires reach dense residential areas, their spread resembles that of infectious diseases: no household can be fully protected unless surrounding properties are protected, too.

“If you want your home to survive, you need to have herd immunity,” Jennifer Balch, a fire ecologist at the University of Colorado, Boulder, told me as we walked through her neighborhood, steps from a stunning mountain trail that’s rich with fire fuels in the fall. Dressed in the form-fitting athleisure endemic to the city, Balch explained that her community sits in the wildland-urban interface, or *wui* (pronounced “woo-ee”), where fire risk is highest. “I do get nervous when it’s hot, dry, and windy,” she said, brushing her curly blond hair from her eyes. “As you can see, we’re pretty far from herd immunity here.”

For much of the past century, urban conflagrations seemed, like polio or measles, a scourge that science and government had conquered. Modernized fire departments, safer building materials, hydrants, and building codes had largely eliminated catastrophes like the Great Chicago Fire of 1871. But, by the nineteen-nineties, housing developments were spreading into forests and grasslands increasingly parched by climate change, bringing structure-to-structure fires back. The 2018 Camp Fire, in Paradise, California; the 2023 Lahaina Fire, on Maui; and the 2025 Palisades and Eaton Fires were devastating examples. Communities abroad face similar dangers, from Australia’s bushfire-prone suburbs to parts of Europe, Asia, and South America.

Some residents whose homes were engulfed by fire understood that they lived on a combustible landscape; others were surprised. Balch, the ecologist, spent a decade building a data set that combined satellite

information about the speed and spread of more than sixty thousand American wildfires from 2001 to 2020 with daily incident-command reports from fire-suppression teams, and two hundred million housing and property records. “The trends are remarkable,” she told me as we walked through the foothills near her neighborhood, grass crunching beneath our feet. “Here’s the main thing: Forget megafires. It’s fast fires that do the most damage.” Balch and her colleagues reported in *Science* that, among the conflagrations in their database, fast fires—those growing by more than sixteen hundred and twenty hectares on any single day—made up less than three per cent of the total but accounted for almost ninety per cent of the structures damaged or destroyed.

Another *Science* paper, by a team led by Volker Radeloff, an ecologist at the University of Wisconsin, Madison, reports that from 1990 to 2020 the number of American homes in the *wui* increased by forty-six per cent, from thirty million to forty-four million. Although most U.S. regions are vulnerable to destructive conflagrations, Balch’s data show that such fires are becoming more prevalent—and much faster—in the West, where the average maximum daily growth of wildfire area increased by two hundred and fifty per cent between 2001 and 2020. “In California, it’s four hundred per cent,” she told me. “If you have a house there, that’s a terrifying fact.”

Among the first institutions to recognize this change was the insurance industry, on which the modern housing market rests. By the nineteenth century, American mortgage lenders commonly required borrowers to carry fire insurance. During the New Deal, the federal government began insuring mortgage lenders against losses when borrowers defaulted, adding a second layer of protection. Together, these arrangements became foundational to American homeownership.

In the twenty-first century, extreme weather has cracked that foundation. A hotter and more violent climate, combined with runaway development in high-risk areas, has helped make billion-dollar disasters more common. Soaring claims have been accompanied by soaring premiums. Meanwhile, insurers have increasingly exercised their option not to renew existing policies. For growing numbers of Americans, the insurance required for a mortgage is prohibitively expensive. In high-risk areas, it may be available

only through state-run residual markets, including Fair Access to Insurance Requirements (*FAIR*) plans, which often come with high prices and limited benefits.



Cartoon by Ellie Black

Insurers have long sought to reduce risk by rewarding safety measures such as smoke alarms and security cameras. More recently, actuaries, policymakers, and fire experts have explored ways to do the same on a community-wide scale. Among them is Nancy Watkins, a property-and-casualty-insurance actuary at the global consultancy Milliman, who has had struggles with her own homeowners'-insurance coverage, in California.

"I loved that old policy," she said wistfully, as if recalling a beloved pet. But her insurer pulled out of the state, and the one she turned to next decided not to renew about half its policies in the area, including hers. We sat in her yard in Orinda, over the hills from Oakland, amid oak, redwood, maple, and lemon trees, overlooking dry grassland. "The chief actuary of another company told me, 'Orinda is my worst nightmare,' because we have so many high-value homes in a small area with terrible access, twisty roads, lots of overgrown vegetation, and very little mitigation. It's so beautiful, but when I drive through these hills, I often think, Wow, an insurer could lose a lot of money here."

Watkins, who is sixty-five, has a mild Southern drawl, purple-dyed hair, and an analytic mind that eventually forced her to confront the fire risk she had long downplayed in her personal life, despite her professional expertise. Her husband led their local "Firewise" group, part of a National Fire

Protection Association program that helps residents and neighborhoods organize around wildfire resistance. “He had been telling me for years that we should clear five feet around our house,” she said. “But we’d spent a lot of money on landscaping, and I liked it. I didn’t want to make the change.” She and her husband had invested heavily in her “California dream home,” but now they needed a better option than the state’s *FAIR* plan. “That’s when we decided to do the mitigation makeover.”

There are two main ways to protect a home from fire. The first, “hardening,” replaces vulnerable building components, such as single-pane windows and vinyl gutters, with fire-resistant alternatives, such as double-pane, double-tempered windows and metal gutters. The second, creating “defensible space,” clears combustible material from the perimeter, particularly “Zone Zero,” the five feet closest to the building. That can mean removing vegetation, mulch, wood decks, fencing. “We put gravel and a stone stairway next to the house, got rid of a bench, moved the planters, found a way to keep leaves from piling up in the back,” Watkins told me. “I was afraid we’d have to cut down trees, but we only had to limb them.”

Her house, which still has wood shingles and an ipê deck, falls short of the highest fire-resistance standards. But it proved safe enough for a new policy from a “non-admitted carrier,” an insurer operating legally without a California license. She knew that many families wouldn’t be so lucky. Amy Bach, of the consumer group United Policyholders, calls the trend toward insurance with higher premiums and diminished coverage “shrinkflation.” Watkins said that rate-setting rules adopted in California in 1988 prevent insurers from pricing policies according to risk, contributing to their retreat from the state. Meanwhile, progressives calling for reform point out that homeowner insurers in the U.S. are hardly suffering: according to the credit-rating agency AM Best, they posted $16.5 billion in underwriting profits in 2025.

Watkins’s struggle to find coverage left her determined to improve the system. She joined forces with colleagues, including a director of fire research at Cal Poly, in San Luis Obispo, and a former fire chief for Orinda and a neighboring town, modelling fires and looking for ways to protect

entire neighborhoods and towns. Right now, homeowners who reduce their fire risk may see little benefit in their insurance rates, Watkins explained, because their exposure depends heavily on neighboring properties, and there has been no systematic way to measure community-wide mitigation.

“We’ve found a solution to this problem,” she said. She and her colleagues propose assessing entire neighborhoods and making the data available to insurers, lenders, scientists, and residents. This project, “*wui* Data Commons,” would help insurers identify safer communities—and, eventually, charge them less.

Watkins and her collaborators have published research and pressed insurers to take community-level protection into account when setting premiums. “The assessment isn’t as easy as looking at photos on Google Maps,” she told me. Inspectors would have to examine windows, vents, siding, and defensible space, then check again as vegetation regrows. Homeowners might also upload videos of their property from their phones.



“It’s a free concert, but you pay in other ways.”
Cartoon by Victoria Roberts

How much mitigation is enough? Perhaps the most rigorous home-level standards come from the Insurance Institute for Business & Home Safety (I.B.H.S.), an industry-funded nonprofit that tests building materials and designs. But those standards may be too costly for existing homeowners to meet, and insurers debate what should qualify a policy for a renewal or a

discount. Setting a threshold for an entire community, Watkins said, is even harder.

To see these standards in action, I travelled to an I.B.H.S. demonstration at a fire-rescue training center in Lakewood, Colorado. Two small houses with fences stood on a paved lot. One had fibre-cement siding, Class A roofing, ember-resistant vents, closed eaves, double-paned, double-tempered windows in metal frames, steel patio furniture, and a five-foot perimeter of pavers. The other had open eaves, vinyl gutters, wood siding, a mulch bed, and juniper and fir trees planted against its walls. A narrow garden stretched before both houses. Four industrial fans stood ready to simulate high winds.

It was a cool, unseasonably cloudy summer morning. Two uniformed firefighters wearing thick white gloves approached the garden and shot flames at the vegetation with red drip torches. Ignition proved surprisingly difficult. After delivering months of drought to the Rocky Mountain region, Mother Nature had sent light rain to the fire show. Instead of an explosive conflagration, the audience—developers, officials, and others—watched a slow, damp burn.

“This is going to take a little longer than we expected,” Roy Wright, the insurance institute’s fifty-two-year-old C.E.O., said as he oversaw the proceedings. He was in a blue quarter-zip sweater and a white collared shirt, his manner professorial. “But it’s actually going to be a better demonstration, because, instead of seeing everything burn down quickly, you’re going to watch the fire progress in stages, one element at a time.”

The first thing to ignite around the conventional house was the juniper, whose dense needles and twigs are filled with volatile oils and resins. It’s a notorious fire hazard in Colorado, where developers and homeowners plant the shrubs in clusters as inexpensive sources of privacy and shade. Minutes later, when the firefighters sped up the fans, flames and flying embers caught the wooden fence and the open eaves along the roofline. Dark smoke swirled up from the vinyl gutters as, at ground level, the fir and the mulch bed burned like candles.

“Now watch,” Wright said softly. “The fire is spreading vertically up the wood siding. It’s going to keep climbing, and, since it got in that eave, it’s

about to get inside, under the roof. From there, it's over. The whole thing is coming down." Soon the house was a bonfire, its radiant heat boring into my skin.

Wright and I retreated to the back of the viewing area. "We've all been looking at the fire, because it's hard not to," he said. "But the real action today was at the other house. Look at it." The hardened structure appeared unchanged. "The steel fence didn't ignite. The roof didn't ignite. The patio furniture didn't ignite. There's not a single mark on the siding. The windows are intact. You can see the effectiveness of the five-foot zone, too. The mulch around the edge is burning, but it's not going to get past the pavers. The fire isn't getting close."

I left the demonstration with a deeper appreciation for how homeowners and developers can reduce catastrophic property loss. Still, I remembered Peggy Driscoll, who lost her intact house to smoke damage after the Marshall Fire, and wondered whether the structure that survived the conflagration staged at Lakewood would still be habitable.

Steve Ruffner, an executive at KB Home, one of the nation's largest residential-construction companies, had a similar thought after a 2024 I.B.H.S. fire demonstration in Anaheim, California. He and I.B.H.S.'s chief product officer, Alister Watt, came up with an idea: What if they built an entire community in a fire-prone area to the I.B.H.S. mitigation standards, hardening not just each property but everything on the development's land?

In late September, I travelled to the suburbs northeast of San Diego to see Ruffner and Watt's vision realized: a community-mitigation project that persuaded insurers to offer good coverage in a fire-prone area at reasonable rates. Dixon Trail, a nearly completed residential development at the base of high, dry foothills, consists of sixty-four ranch-style houses, most priced at about a million dollars and ranging from roughly two thousand to three thousand square feet. KB Home bought the land in 2022 and was preparing to build when Ruffner saw that fire demonstration in Anaheim. Dixon Trail became the first U.S. community to meet the I.B.H.S. Wildfire Prepared Neighborhood Technical Standard.

I parked at the sales center, housed in one of four remaining unsold homes, and Ruffner greeted me before I reached the entrance. A tall man in his sixties, he had a jocular air and wore a blue corporate polo, black sunglasses, and khaki pants. “Before you see the property,” he told me, “you need to know that we are standing in what’s called a high fire-severity zone, and this is a wind corridor.”

The temperature was in the mid-eighties, and a gentle breeze gave little hint of the Santa Ana winds that heighten the danger during the colder months. “Now let’s get you inside. You look like you don’t get much sunshine. I don’t want to barbecue your skin.”

The demo unit, a four-bedroom house on an oversized corner lot with dramatic foothill views and an indoor-outdoor feel, was cool and spacious. It had high ceilings, double-paned sliding glass doors opening to a patio, and all-electric climate control powered by solar panels and heat pumps. Ruffner led me to the back yard, where fire-resistant lawn furniture sat on pavers. Young hopbush trees, Texas privets, and crimson pygmy barberries lined the perimeter, helping shield a block wall and a metal post. When I’d learned about the project, I’d wondered whether the rock gardens, stucco walls, and heavy masonry might make the development feel like a fortress, eliminating vibrant green life along with fires. In fact, Dixon Trail felt, if not lush, appealingly comfortable and colorful. The aesthetic, more Palm Desert than Pacific Grove, suits the habitat.

As we left to tour the development, Roy Wright, of I.B.H.S., joined us, smiling like a proud parent. “There’s something I need to show you,” he said, leading me toward five houses near the community’s center. They predated Dixon Trail by decades, and their verdant landscaping—tall, leafy banana and queen palms, birds-of-paradise, red-flowering bougainvillea, shrubs planted in mulch—offered plenty of fuel for a fire. We stopped near an adobe-block house, where Wright pointed to hedges beneath the windows. “I’m not concerned about the structure siding as the first point of ignition, but look at those hedges,” he said. “Now, remember that, on the day the fire comes, we’ll have high, hot winds. They’re going to dry out that vegetation and, when the embers hit those hedges, they’re going to be

connective. As soon as things heat up, that window's going to fall out, and when that window falls out, the fire goes in."



Cartoon by Jason Adam Katzenstein

At the start of the project, the owners of those older houses had asked Ruffner how to harden them. "But when it came to removing plants and trees next to their houses," he told me, "they weren't too hip." Wright added, "They're obviously not at the standard we want to see here." The good news, he added, is that the older homes sit inside the development, where the new houses and fire-resistant landscaping will help buffer them from fires.

Even the new houses will require ongoing fire-safety maintenance. In high-risk zones, homeowners' choices—metal or wooden patio furniture; the proximity of trees and hedges to the building—make a difference. "We have design guidelines and maintenance rules that buyers agree to in their contract," Ruffner told me. "But we don't have to manage it much, because of the peer pressure here. If someone sees something, the homeowners' association gets to them first."

Financial incentives help, too. "There's one very big reason residents are respecting the guidelines," Ruffner explained. "When we did this project, we found insurers that were willing to write homeowners' policies at a rate that's simply unbeatable. Sixteen hundred dollars per year. For comparison, the guy in the house next to this development told me he's paying nine thousand dollars. That's worse coverage for more money. Buyers can't believe it when we tell them the price of their policy. One woman hugged me in the sales office! She said, 'I never thought we'd save so much!' So,

yeah, they could try to change the design guidelines, but, if they did, they'd be paying a very steep price."

Ruffner and Wright know that communities across California and the rest of the U.S. are desperate for home insurance at Dixon Trail prices. That's unrealistic. "It's nearly impossible to hit the highest standard of fire protection all the way through a legacy neighborhood, especially one in a *wui*," Wright told me. "In a new development, it's just a question of spending a few thousand dollars more on certain design elements, and we know they're going to pay for themselves quickly, in insurance savings alone." I asked about the cost of hardening an older home nearby to the same level. "You're talking tens of thousands of dollars," he replied. "If you have to replace the windows, enclose the eaves, and change out the other elements, you're talking maybe a hundred thousand dollars." Even after such an expensive project, a local homeowner might qualify only for a *FAIR* plan. Without similar measures from neighbors—and insurers' use of the community-level mitigations that Nancy Watkins and her colleagues promote—a decent policy would remain hard to find.

Still, some communities are working toward herd immunity, making enough homes safer that they meet insurers' thresholds. In a *wui* in the Berkeley Hills, I met Michel Thouati, a sixty-five-year-old technology entrepreneur wearing a white polo, black pants, and a phone holster. His house stood two streets away from a park featuring rolling grasslands and giant redwood and eucalyptus trees. He bought the house in 1997 for its sweeping views of the Golden Gate Bridge, explaining that, "for Europeans, that bridge is the great symbol of freedom and the American West, and I couldn't think of a more beautiful place to live."

Thouati grew up on a French military base in Algeria and holds an engineering doctorate from the University of California, Berkeley. He speaks rapidly and precisely. We talked in his living room as the Bay and the San Francisco skyline glimmered in the late-afternoon sun. Earthquakes had long been his chief worry as a homeowner. "When we bought this house, it was made of the cheapest goddam materials. But I'm a systematic person, and I put together a long-term plan. As we started to remodel, whenever we demolished something, we would build earthquake anchors

and shear walls, and triple the nail schedule to make it more earthquake-resistant. When we had to get rid of our siding, which was combustible, we went to fire-resistant fibre cement. Then we put in a metal roof."

Thouati and his wife spent most of the twenty-tens in Wisconsin, and returned in 2019 to a hotter and drier Berkeley. "Lawns had turned to rock gardens," he said. "The whole area was less lush." Neighbors warned him about wildfires, but, he confessed, "at first, I was in denial. I loved my gardens. I'd planted so many trees and plants here." Outside, he showed me a carefully tended evergreen dogwood and a weeping dwarf sequoia with a rough, curling trunk. A Japanese maple was hung with winged seeds. The trees stood several feet from the house, behind gray-and-white gravel and near a cluster of potted plants. More trees lined a metal fence behind them, where a rock river wound toward a stone fountain. "It was just too emotional, the thought of losing all of this."

As Thouati weighed mitigation costs, *COVID*-19 pushed wildfire down his list of worries. He helped organize a mutual-aid network of four hundred drivers, which delivered more than a hundred and seventy-five thousand meals in its busiest year. "We had enormous good will in the community, and a real system for working together," he told me. As *COVID* receded, he saw how residents might help address another problem the city was struggling to manage: wildfire.

Thouati became a force behind the neighborhood's Firewise group, expanding its volunteer services beyond education and home assessments to hands-on help with clearing vegetation. "I know how daunting it is to take on home mitigation," he told me. When I cited Roy Wright's estimate of a hundred thousand dollars, Thouati laughed. "If you're trying to comply with I.B.H.S. enhanced standards, which you might need to get insurance coverage, the cost for a house like mine can easily reach three hundred thousand dollars. It's impossible, unless you have money and you do it in stages. Ours took thirty years! But you can reduce fire risk by eighty per cent with some simple and fairly inexpensive things—a few thousand dollars. In Berkeley, the city will give you mesh for ember shields and gutter screens, which are very expensive, for free."

Walking with me along his street, Thouati sized up each house's fire precautions and its residents' willingness to help. "This one is mostly compliant," he said, as we passed a property with a dark-wood back deck. "I don't love wood, but it's dimensional lumber, which is hard to burn, and, look, he's got eighty feet of new metal fencing. It's totally fire-safe." At a stucco ranch with a walker on the patio, he explained, "She's eighty-eight. We cleared most of her land last spring. We're trying to get her enrolled in the residential-assistance program for people over sixty-five. She's ninety per cent compliant, and the city will pay for the rest." Across the street, a small home sat within a jungle of vegetation. Thouati sighed. "This one, they're not interested. They think every plant and tree is a gift from God."



At a demonstration burn organized by the Insurance Institute for Business & Home Safety, flames spread from landscaping to a house with wood siding and open eaves. A neighboring structure, built with noncombustible materials and surrounded by a five-foot perimeter of pavers, sustained no visible damage.

The insurance-consumer advocate Amy Bach had told me about residents she calls Good Karens, who reduce their own fire risk and press their neighbors to do the same. I asked Thouati how he handled holdouts. "We train our volunteers to never do enforcement," he said. "That's for the

Berkeley Fire Department. Be the friend. Be the educator. Be the helper. Sometimes it takes years. See the house here?" He pointed to a two-story home with a patchwork of gray and green in the front yard. "They never wanted to cut anything, but this May a contractor showed up and started clearing out vegetation. They're nowhere near where we want to be, but it's getting better, and it's all because of gentle pressure."

Despite these efforts, Thouati recognized the limits of volunteer organizing. "The fire modellers say you need about eighty-five-per-cent compliance to reach something like herd immunity in a neighborhood," he told me. "We've made huge progress here, but in most places, even where there's money and leadership, it's hard to get to twenty-five per cent. Doing it on a voluntary basis won't work." He wanted local and state policies that mandated strict fire-safety codes for private properties and that funded substantial mitigation on public land.

This past January, Berkeley rolled out the *EMBER* ordinance, which is among the nation's most ambitious local wildfire-control efforts. It requires a five-foot ember-resistant buffer around buildings and at least six feet of clearance between roofs and overhanging tree branches in the Grizzly Peak and Panoramic Hill Mitigation Areas. In August, California's Board of Forestry and Fire Protection approved similar, but slightly looser, rules. They were quickly pulled back for review, but statewide requirements could still take effect soon.

Protecting communities also means managing the land around them. On a hot morning in Boulder, I drove to the Fourmile Canyon Creek trailhead to meet Paul Dennison, a rangy, bearded thirty-nine-year-old in bluejeans, brown boots, and a black T-shirt, who oversees wildfire mitigation in the city's foothills and parks. He told me that a road trip through the Rockies had drawn him to firefighting. He joined Colorado's fire service at twenty-six. Three years ago, he traded active suppression for the safer, equally challenging work of keeping wildfires from becoming cataclysms.

Dennison led me into a parched meadow. Dried grasses bordered houses in one direction and stretched for miles into the foothills and mountains in the other. "We manage a seventy-two-square-mile public-land system, a greenbelt, that surrounds residential Boulder," he explained. "It's all a fire-

prone environment. Natural areas to the west, primarily. Agricultural lands to the east. Sixteen thousand homes fall within our three wildfire-ignition-risk zones, and the strong downslope winds we get, usually in the fall, can drive a fire pretty much everywhere."

Since the Marshall Fire, Boulder has developed a plan to reduce fire risk across its varied terrain. Dennison led me off the canyon trail, warning that my shoes were no match for the cactus I'd nearly stepped on. He pointed to the grasses around us: just an inch or two high, several feet shorter than those farther uphill. "Once or twice a year, we do what we call our urban cattle drive, and just walk the cows from one treatment area to another on the outside of residential Boulder, occasionally crossing major roads," he explained. "This year, a lot of drivers seemed confused about what we were doing, but when we explained it they thought it was pretty cool."

Dennison wanted a healthy, fire-resistant landscape, but the cattle had eaten too much. "See these patches of bare ground here? We didn't have much rain this year, and since the grass wasn't high when the cattle arrived, now it's grazed down to the nub. In the future, we want to hit a four- to eight-inch range in areas like this. It's kind of a high-wire act." Other agencies use goats to trim mountain shrubs, but he was wary of that approach. "In some of these projects, goats eat so aggressively that they kill the shrubs, which means you're taking live vegetation that retains moisture, and turning it into sticks that carry fire. We're considering goats to create little breaks to help us get in and remove fuels by hand. But we want to be careful with this ecosystem. It's easy to do harm."

Near communities, the priorities shift. "The closer you get to the homes," Dennison told me, "the more the balance swings toward risk reduction, and the more aggressive we will be." Beside the neighborhood off the canyon trail, he showed me a thirty-foot strip of grass separating back-yard fences from the wildlands above. "Right here, this is where we do perimeter mowing. We have hand crews—often locals who have been homeless and need work that's not too technical—using weed whips, so they can avoid the little rocks on this landscape, and take away the fuel. We do it because, if a wildfire were approaching this community, you'd have firefighters behind these homes to defend them, and this creates a thirty-foot space

where they could work safely.” Dennison draws on housing-location data and fire research by scholars like Jennifer Balch to decide how far to extend the work. “In this area, we do mowing and grazing up to a hundred feet from the houses, because the trail creates an additional buffer. In other places, where there are no roads or trails to slow down a fire, we go as far as three hundred feet.”



“First, let’s figure out the turtlenecks. Then we plan the heist.”
Cartoon by Rich North

His pickup, a red Chevrolet Colorado, took us to South Boulder’s pine savanna, near Shanahan Ridge. He gestured to grasslands beside the road. “Another one of our projects is shoulder mowing along the evacuation routes,” he told me. “If a fast-moving wildfire approaches Boulder, we’re going to have thousands of evacuees driving out while hundreds of firefighters are driving in. We don’t want high-intensity fire impacting those roads, and we want to create safe space for firefighters to engage the fire away from the roadway whenever possible.”

At the *wui*, he showed me where the city was working to keep fire out of the tree canopy. “The goal here is to keep these trees from torching, because that’s when you get the most ember generation, with long-range transport to all those houses,” he explained, pointing to a row of houses between us and some scattered cottonwoods and pines. “From that neighborhood, we’ve got a continuous dried-grass understory leading right to the tops of the trees, so we’re pruning the lower tree limbs and using grazing and other methods for

the grasses. Both help eliminate the ladder fuels, and keep fire out of the crowns.” The nearby houses, with abundant vegetation beside wooden fences, showed how much work remained.

Before leaving Shanahan Ridge, we rested beneath a ponderosa pine, grateful for the shade of its combustible crown. I asked whether Boulder would revive prescribed burning, a practice that is rooted in the region’s Indigenous cultures and that, fire scientists had told me, has been shown to reduce wildfire risk. “I’d like to,” he replied. “It’s the best way to reduce surface fuel loads in forests, and it can be helpful for grasslands, too. But recently we haven’t been able to do it much. This year, during burn season, the whole county was under fire restrictions.”

The risks weighed on Dennison. “This is city-managed land,” he explained. “If we have a prescribed fire escape, we have all these vulnerable, dense residential neighborhoods. Also, this is America, and there have been high-profile cases when burn bosses were criminally charged for fires that did damage. That’s a lot of responsibility for one person to carry.”

The most contentious part of community mitigation happens at the property line, where one person’s landscaping can imperil a neighbor’s home. Even among people rebuilding after the Marshall Fire, the question of how much they owed one another remained unsettled.

Before leaving Colorado, I returned to Louisville to meet Tawnya Somauroo, a fifty-year-old patent attorney and mother of twins who lost her house in the fire. She has since made neighborhood mitigation a civic mission. Her rebuilt home sits close to others in a hilly cul-de-sac with dramatic views. It’s a minimalist modern farmhouse built to resist fire, with a steep gable, white board-and-batten siding, and large, asymmetrical windows. A long bed of colorful wildflowers runs beside metal fencing, separated from the house by a wide concrete patio and an irrigated lawn. “We did everything we could to prevent another fire here,” Somauroo, in a dark-brown button-down sweater, her expressive face framed by blond curls, told me. She pointed out ember shields on the vents and a rock-and-gravel garden that had replaced vegetation and mulch. “It cost a little bit, but, the way I saw it, we didn’t have a choice.”

Somauroo's husband has chronic health problems after getting *COVID*, and her daughters need treatment for developmental issues. Evacuating, losing nearly everything, and rebuilding while holding a demanding job had upended her life. "Everyone here has been traumatized," she told me, her voice shaky. "I did therapy. We have teen-agers in the neighborhood who still get in bed with their parents at night. What got me through this is the community. When the fire came, we didn't get an evacuation order in time. We dove into each other's houses, smashed into doors, yelled, screamed, and got each other out. Then we stuck together through the recovery—which wasn't easy, because we were scattered all over the area. But we started a Slack to share information about everything, like insurance adjusters and mortgage servicers. We did happy hours, where you could just drink a beer with other people who were in the same situation, and got it."

When her new house was ready, about two years after the fire, Somauroo couldn't wait to return. "It wasn't just the house," she told me. "This is a cool neighborhood. We've got older people, young people, families with kids for my girls to play with—that's what made it worth coming back." At first, she was relieved to see neighbors rebuilding with similar precautions: Class A roofing, Hardie siding, five-foot perimeters free of mulch and vegetation. But, as more houses went up, some for new families, she felt that standards slipped. "We'd see inconsistencies, like metal fencing, which is good, but then lots of new juniper trees, which is like asking for fire," she said. "Or a fire-mitigated house with wooden fence wings attached. It can feel like having someone walk into a restaurant and lighting a cigarette. They aren't just putting themselves at risk, they're putting you at risk, too."

In the past two years, Somauroo has become a Good Karen, helping secure a local Zone Zero ordinance and a juniper-tree ban, then pressing neighbors to comply. Not long ago, a family moved in across the cul-de-sac. One of their daughters quickly became best friends with her children, but Somauroo was alarmed when ten trees appeared in the newcomers' yard, some of which she thought stood within the required five-foot buffer. She texted the parents to ask whether they were violating the ordinance. They took offense, then insisted that their landscaper had misplaced just one tree, which they had promptly moved. Somauroo was unconvinced.

She knew that her safety still depended on her neighbors. Every new owner or freshly planted shrub could reopen the question of how much they owed one another. Standing in her driveway, she looked across the cul-de-sac at the new vegetation and the arid hills beyond. “I wouldn’t care if people were just going to burn their own house down,” she said, “but we’re at a pretty high level of conflagration danger. As climate-change survivors, we have a right to live in a safer neighborhood. We’re not going through that again.” ♦

Eric Klinenberg, the Helen Gould Shepard Professor in the Social Sciences at N.Y.U., is the author of “2020: One City, Seven People, and the Year Everything Changed.” He has contributed to The New Yorker since 2012.

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Shouts & Murmurs

- **If Trump Did Standup**
  By Steve Martin | “I had lunch at Mar-a-Lago the other day. It’s like the Cheesecake Factory but more expensive.”

Shouts & Murmurs

If Trump Did Standup

By ***Steve Martin***

November 9, 2026



Illustration by Luci Gutiérrez

Hey, how we doing tonight? . . . Feelin’ good? Me, too.

How many dumb people do we have here tonight? . . . Wow, that many? See, the fact that you raised your hand proves that you’re dumb. I love dumb people, because without them who would raise their hand? . . . The reason I ask is cuz I’m gonna be using words—really good words—and a lotta dumb people just sit and stare in amazement, wishing they had a dictionary. Hey, you ever realized that the word “dictionary” has the word “dick” in it? A lotta people don’t even realize that. The dictionary people love me because I use a lot of their words. It’s free promotion for them.

I see a lotta hot women in the audience. I can’t tell if the guys are hot because I can’t see their asses . . . because they’re sitting on ’em. You can’t see a guy’s ass when he’s sitting on it. And you can’t interpret a guy’s ass from his face. Unless he’s James Talarico. He’s probably got a small ass, cuz he’s got a small face. . . . Wow, that’s very kind of you. Thank you.

I had lunch at Mar-a-Lago the other day. It's like the Cheesecake Factory but more expensive. I get my lunch free, but my lunch friends had to take out loans. They came in rich and left in bankruptcy. And they're all sad, and I say, "Hey, if I can do it, you can do it." And it perks them up, because they think my bankruptcies are the best bankruptcies. They come to Mar-a-Lago in a limo, and they leave in a three-wheeled Volkswagen.

But one day I'm at Mar-a-Lago, and I'm having lunch with this Big Tech guy, and I say, "Pass the salt." And he says, "Pardon me?" So I did.

How many people out there have a free plane from the Qataris? None? Where'd this audience come from, the Ukraine? . . . Thank you! . . . Man, you gotta get a free plane. A plane is not something you can save up for, especially if you have lunch at Mar-a-Lago. One guy wanted dessert the other day and couldn't pay, so I took his watch. It's a beautiful timepiece. You know that word, "timepiece"? Lotta people don't. They just say "clock" or "watch." But I love "timepiece." The dictionary people love me for using "timepiece."

How many of you have bachelor's degrees? I got a bachelor's degree. Well, two. One from the University of Pennsylvania, and the other from women I dated. The women kept begging me to take it, saying, "You're the greatest bachelor." When you're President, you can't date anymore. Too many eyeballs on you. Hey, you realize the word "eyeballs" has the word "balls" in it?

O.K., lotta other acts coming up here. You'll see them and think, Bring back the other guy. And maybe give me a like on Insta. I like likes. Ever think of that? You can like a like? Ha! Like a like. Remember, I'm the guy who said that.

People say to me, "You're a great standup! Why don't you quit being the President so you can do it full time?" Well, I would, but I like the money. . . . Thank you. ♦

Steve Martin is an actor, a musician, and a writer. His books include "Steve Martin Writes the Written Word."

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Fiction

- **“The Death of a Certain Woman”**
  By Yasushi Inoue | Every child in the village knew about Omitsu and had learned the unfamiliar word “mistress.”

Fiction

The Death of a Certain Woman

By **Yasushi Inoue**

November 8, 2026



Illustration by Molly Heng Cheang

The first time I met Omitsu was the summer before my third year of elementary school, in the seventh or eighth year of the Taisho era, 1918 or 1919.

I had been left in the care of my uncle, who brewed sake in Shinano, a small farming village a couple of miles outside the city of Nagano, in order to be able to attend the local school. My father, who was a government official, had been posted in Taiwan, and my mother had accompanied him there. But I had been prone to glandular ailments since I was a baby, running a fever at the slightest illness, so my parents left me with my relatives, certain that the southern climate in Taiwan would not be good for my condition. During my uncle's busy season, a large number of young men and women stayed with us to help, and the house would become as chaotic as a battlefield. But during the rest of the year there were only four of us—my uncle, my aunt, a taciturn young maid, and me—so the spacious house was quiet.

One day in late August, I had gone out with the neighborhood children in the morning to play at the edge of the village. The long school holiday was coming to an end, and though the sunlight still offered the brightness of summer, the breeze that blew suggested the sombre quality of autumn. I returned home close to noon to eat. I took one step into the earthen-floored entryway and stopped. An unfamiliar woman of twenty-three or twenty-four was standing there talking with my aunt, who was sitting on the stoop.

Read an interview with the translator for the story behind the story.

This must be the woman they call Omitsu, I thought. My aunt and the woman were exchanging polite remarks, but there was a cold, unpleasant air between them.

"This is merely a token of my gratitude. Please accept it."

The woman spoke in a clear, delicate voice that seemed to match her delicate build. The trace of rouge on her lips caught my eye.

"Oh, no. We can't accept this. Let's just leave it at that."

My aunt, who was one of the heaviest women in the village, spoke in a suitably heavy voice. What looked like a box of cakes sat between them. I sensed that the two women had faced off over the item.

“Is this your son?” the woman said, turning toward me. I just stared at her face, stunned at how gentle and beautiful she was, forgetting even to bow my head. I wondered how something called a “mistress” could have such a face.

My aunt always told me to bow when I appeared before guests, but this time was different. She made no indication that she would later scold me for failing to lower my head. She just motioned with her chin for me to leave. I started to back out of the entryway.

“Here, young man.” The woman gestured toward me, and in an instant I found myself holding the box. Both the woman and my aunt said something, but my ears had ceased to function. I stood there half dazed. The mistress’s approach had struck me dumb; something luxurious and sweet was emanating from her body and had rendered me unable to move. By the time I came to my senses, Omitsu had already cut through the front garden and was about to turn down the stone path toward the road, offering a retreating view of her slender figure in a kimono.

“We’ve ended up with quite a gift.” My aunt, stepping into the entryway, cast a fearful eye down at the box. “Open it,” she finally said.

I did as I was told. The box appeared to be filled with candies wrapped in silver paper, a sort that one rarely saw except in Nagano. They were chocolates, but at the time neither my aunt nor I knew that. My aunt gazed at them in wonder for a long while. Then she gave me one, ate one herself, and took the rest inside.

I had heard rumors about Omitsu for some ten days before I met her. Every child in the village knew about Omitsu and had learned the unfamiliar word “mistress.” Sometimes on the road or in the rice fields we would shout “There’s the mistress!” and scramble off, pretending to be pursued by her. We imagined that a mistress would look something like an ogre, and though

a mistress was not as powerful as an ogre, we considered it a creature of greater treachery and evil.

Because we had only heard rumors of a mistress and had never seen one, we played every day near the house in which she was to live. It was the old storehouse of a farming family named Tamura, who had been using it as a junk shed. But now the mistress had rented the place and would be living there. In the preceding decade, the younger members of the Tamura family had died off, one by one, leaving only an elderly grandmother. The old woman was criticized by the villagers, who said she had been blinded by greed when she agreed to rent the storehouse to a mistress even though there were others to whom she could have rented it.

The children even knew that the mistress's name was Omitsu. Following the adults' example, we referred to her as "Omitsu" or "Miss Omitsu," talking about her before she had ever moved into the Tamura family's storehouse.

Omitsu was originally from a village about five miles from our own. She had gone to work at an inn in Nagano, and had recently become the mistress of a middle-aged construction contractor who had acquired much through his influence in the area. There seemed to be circumstances that prevented her from living in Nagano, so she was to stay in our village. Word of Omitsu immediately spread through our village, it being a rural area and Omitsu coming from nearby. Whenever villagers gathered, gossip that a not very nice woman was moving in never failed to surface.

Soon after she arrived, Omitsu paid the courtesy call to my house, because my uncle and aunt were influential people in the village, and the place she was renting stood just behind the building where my uncle kept the sake he brewed. Later that afternoon, some neighbor children asked me to go with them to spy on her at the storehouse, but, having already met the woman, I had lost all my curiosity about mistresses.

"A mistress is no big deal."

That is what I told the other children, but they could not be convinced and needed to confirm it with their own eyes. They climbed the chestnut tree or

the walnut tree or the persimmon tree outside the storehouse to try to glimpse a mistress in its true form through her window.

One of the children fell from the chestnut tree and twisted his ankle. After the incident, it occurred to us that perhaps we should not approach the storehouse so casually. That was what you might get from a mistress. She might even use black magic. We children discussed matters like this with grave looks on our faces.

By the time autumn came, we had resumed playing near Omitsu's house. This mistress was not as frightening or as weird as the adults had claimed. Indeed, we found it somehow more enjoyable to play with Omitsu close by.

Sometimes, when we were playing flip cards, Omitsu would come out of the storehouse and stand silently beside us, watching. Our eyes gleamed. It excited us strangely, but we set our jaws firm. We were not going to lose the game.

We children were not the only ones who let down our guard. Adults no longer spoke ill of Omitsu, either. Despite what they might have expected of a mistress, there was nothing at all disagreeable about her. Also, the contractor who kept her never showed himself in the village.

"Perhaps she has been abandoned." "Maybe her lover is in jail." These were the rumors that the villagers now whispered.

Omitsu occasionally came to my house. My stubborn, old-fashioned uncle never changed his mind about her. "That worthless woman."

But she impressed my aunt. "Even a mistress can be a well-mannered woman like her," my aunt often said at suppertime, which invited a scolding from my uncle.

Just after the first of October, my aunt sent me to deliver some sushi to Omitsu. It was the time of day when evening shadows began to creep onto the white road.

I carried the unwieldy bundle out the back and around the sake warehouse, emerging in front of the place where Omitsu lived.

I could see a light in the second-story window of her house, but the heavy door was closed tight.

“Miss Omitsu,” I called. There was no answer. I was about to call again when I heard the rumble of footsteps coming down the stairs. Finally, a man I had never seen before stuck his head out. I could not see his face very well in the dark.

“Is Omitsu here?”

“Yes.”

“I brought some sushi.”

“Sushi? Oh, well, then thank you. And where do you live?” the man asked.

Omitsu came downstairs. “Oh, it’s you. Please do come up. I’ll give you something good as a reward.” I did not want to go upstairs. I wanted to run straight home.

The man spoke again. “Hey, boy, come on upstairs.” His words sounded coarse to me. But I feared that something bad might happen if I didn’t go upstairs, so I did as I was told. I took off my clogs. The storehouse was dark inside.

“Be careful. The stairs are dangerous,” Omitsu called from below, as I ascended the steep steps to the second floor, which had been made into a parlor. An electric light that must have been installed when Omitsu moved in glowed in the middle of the room.

A small round eating table had been placed under the light. Sake bottles, teacups, and plates lay in a jumble, as if Omitsu and the man had just finished supper. And, beyond the table, the bedding had been left spread out from the night before. There was little else, other than a cupboard.

The man was wearing a white shirt, long underwear, and a woven belly warmer. His voice had made him seem frightening, but in the light he looked pleasant, even to a child like me. He had a big round face, gentle eyes, and a pale, stout body. He struck me as the kind of person that children would take to. He had a heroic crewcut, and sat cross-legged at the table.

“How old are you, boy?” His tone was the only rough thing about him.

“Nine.”

“Have you ever seen a moving picture?”

“Yes.”

“Did you like it?”

“Yes.”

“O.K., then I’ll take you to see one sometime. And, in return, you bring dinner to this lady every once in a while, the way you did today.”

Omitsu sat beside him wrapping some sponge cake. “Don’t be silly,” she said, reproving the man. “Stop that.” I was dazzled by Omitsu, who was in an unkempt state, her sash loose.

I left as soon as Omitsu handed me the wrapped cake. I did not tell my uncle or aunt that another person had been at her place. I felt it was somehow best for Omitsu that I say nothing.

My concern for Omitsu was in vain. Early the next morning, the man went out walking through the whole village, carrying an air rifle and wearing the same white shirt, long underwear, and woven belly warmer from the night before. And he said the same thing, in the same tone, to everyone he met.

“I am certainly feeling good today!” he called out. His manner could be taken as either arrogance or openheartedness. We children tagged along behind Shinjo Shinsuke. That was his name.

When Shinsuke readied his gun, we all held our breath, and when he pulled the trigger, we shouted and ran toward the rice field, where the sparrows had scattered.

With the appearance of Omitsu's lover, her reputation among the villagers, which had improved, took an unfavorable turn. When the village women saw Omitsu now, they'd turn away, as if to avoid something unclean.

From then on, Shinsuke appeared in the village about once a week. When he was here, the children would gather in front of the storehouse early in the morning and wait for him to come out with his air rifle.

"I don't come here that often. Can't you at least let me sleep in with my lady?" He made crude remarks like this to the children, peering at each of them.

"Your faces. Have you washed your faces? I won't take you with me if your faces are dirty."

The children would all run to the stream at once to clean up.

Although Shinsuke became popular with the village children, the adults regarded him with a cold eye.

One of Shinsuke's visits happened to coincide with the autumn festival. A stage had been built in the middle of the village, where an amateur talent show was to be held, attracting everyone's attention.

Shinsuke performed old narrative songs in the show. He was so talented that one could hardly imagine he was a mere amateur. We children sat toward the front and enjoyed watching Shinsuke lean over and extend his face toward the audience.

Shinsuke returned to the stage time after time. "More! More!" people cried, and Shinsuke kept performing.

The talent show continued for three nights, and Shinsuke appeared every evening. On the third night, Omitsu brought a big teacup to Shinsuke

onstage. “Miss Omitsu!” the adults called, their voices showering on the young woman, who was blushing.

Following their example, we children shouted, too: “Miss Omitsu!” We called her name as loudly as we could until she left the stage.

To the child that I was, this image of Omitsu left a good impression. In her appearance, I saw nothing resembling humiliation at her peculiar status as a mistress. How clear it was that she was a woman diligently serving her lover! There were criticisms that emanated from some of the adults, voices that deemed her brazen or presumptuous, but in general her attitude seemed to be met with unquestioning good will.

After the festival was over, the villagers gave neither Omitsu nor Shinsuke any of the judgmental looks they had before. It was as if the couple had somehow become regular members of the village.

One day in late November, I got home from school at about two o’clock and went out past the storehouse to take a look at a digger wasp’s nest, which I had found recently at a dike down by a rice field. There I ran into Omitsu. It seemed she had been standing at the spot for a while. She looked sheepish.

“Would you go to the storehouse,” she asked me, “and check whether there are any women’s clogs sitting at the foot of the stairs?” Then she added, “They’re new ones with red straps.”

I did as I was told, running straight to the storehouse. I immediately recognized the new clogs, so I picked them up and raced back to Omitsu.

“What! Oh, no! You brought them here? They belong to another woman. Put them back where you found them.”

I took the clogs back to the storehouse and placed them neatly on the stoop, then I returned to Omitsu.

“Thank you,” Omitsu said. “Now do your studies. Go on back home.”

I always obeyed Omitsu. This time, too. I went straight home and sat at my desk. But I was uneasy. I wondered why Omitsu had been standing in a place like that.

About an hour later, I went back out past the storehouse. And, sure enough, Omitsu was still there, the same awkward look on her face.

“Would you go to the storehouse again and see if the clogs are still there?” Omitsu asked.

“Sure.”

I ran toward Omitsu’s house but stopped in my tracks when I saw Shinsuke sitting on the stoop, talking loudly with a woman I didn’t know. She was much older than Omitsu, and her bloodless face was screwed into an irritated look.

I approached them. Shinsuke glanced at me but continued speaking to the woman as if I did not exist. He looked like a completely different person. His face soon took on an air of annoyance.

“Anyway, I’m going home, so come with me. Let’s go. You come with me,” Shinsuke said.



Cartoon by Glen Baxter

“No. I’m staying here until that woman gets back.”

“There is nothing for you to do, even if you do meet her.”

“I have something to say to her.”

“It makes no difference whether or not you meet her, so I’m saying I’ll go with you.”

“It won’t do me any good if you go home with me now, then come back here again,” the woman said.

“What kind of foolish talk . . .”

“I am not going to be deceived,” she said.

Shinsuke went on and on, but the woman did not listen. She kept her face turned away.

I thought Shinsuke might speak to me, but he paid me no attention, so I left. I went back to Omitsu.

“He and the woman are fighting,” I reported.

“He? Who are you talking about?”

“Shinsuke. Who else?”

Omitsu suddenly looked flustered. “Oh, no. That’s awful. When did he get here?” she said.

Then she mumbled, “This is the end of everything.”

She looked terribly sad. I didn’t understand the situation. I knew only that Omitsu was troubled, and I felt sorry for her.

“You go back home and study,” Omitsu said.

“I did all my homework a little while ago.”

Then Omitsu seemed to come up with an idea. “Shall we go to see a moving picture in Nagano?”

When I heard her say “moving picture,” my heart danced. I got to see a movie only once a year, during the Obon festival in the summer. I told her I wanted to go.

“Tell your family that you’ll have to be late. If they give you permission, I’ll take you,” Omitsu said. My aunt happened to be away at a memorial service for a relative in a village nearby, so I just told the maid I was going to Nagano, then I returned to Omitsu. She walked down toward the highway without going home first.

I followed after her. She stopped every now and then to wait for me to catch up, but she did not say much. After we had walked a bit, a truck came along and we hitched a ride to the train.

When Omitsu and I reached Nagano, we ate chicken and egg rice at a cafeteria in front of the station. Then we went to the theatre, in the business district. I didn't understand the plot of the movie, but just watching people move on the screen was interesting enough. Halfway through, Omitsu asked if we should leave, but I did not listen to her.

By the time the movie ended, it was past ten o'clock. We went outside, and Omitsu took me to have sweet bean soup at a shop near the theatre. She did not have any, so I ate alone.

It was 11:30 *P.M.* when we got off the train at the station in the next village. "We have to walk from here. It will take half an hour to get home. It doesn't matter if you're tired. You can't sleep yet." Omitsu made certain I understood. She had fed me dinner, taken me to a movie, and treated me to sweet bean soup, so my sense of gratitude certainly didn't allow me to complain that I was sleepy.

Omitsu took me by the hand. The road was narrow and ran through flat fields. There were no houses along the way, but it did not seem all that desolate. There was no moon, but stars were scattered in profusion across the black sky. The night air felt more like winter than autumn.

I kept moving, without rest. Even so, it seemed to take more than thirty minutes to get to the entrance to our village.

"I wonder what that is over there?" Omitsu said.

I saw two fires burning near the fire station. Before we had gone another fifty yards, someone questioned us harshly.

"Is that you, Omitsu?"

"Yes."

As soon as she answered, the person shouted in the darkness, "She! . . . is! . . . here!" One word at a time, in a ridiculously loud voice.

There was a shout in response and then another echoed it, and another, and another, all rising up from the dark fields. Gradually, they grew more distant —fainter, quieter, lonelier. Several villagers surrounded us.

When Omitsu realized that the commotion concerned her, she brought her face close to my ear. “Don’t say anything about seeing a movie, O.K.? It’s better if you don’t tell anyone. All right? Do you understand?” I nodded. I would never say anything about it, I thought, even under pain of death. We kept walking. Along the way, I left Omitsu so that I could take a shortcut home. I ran toward the house.

When I got home, no one scolded me. I had other relatives in Nagano, so my aunt and uncle figured that I had probably got a family member to take me there. I told them that I had gone with Omitsu and that she treated me to dinner and sweet bean soup, but I did not mention that we had seen a moving picture.

As for Omitsu, the whole village had been searching for her. Shinsuke had worried that she might have committed suicide, as she had left during the day and had not come back. That was the reason the village had been in an uproar.

After the ridiculous false alarm, it appeared that Omitsu and Shinsuke’s stock among the villagers dropped once again.

For a long time afterward, Shinsuke did not show his face in the village. The general consensus was that Shinsuke could not visit Omitsu because his hysterical wife was keeping him under surveillance.

We children sometimes visited Omitsu upstairs on the second floor, but she seemed sad and lost in thought. We would jump and run around, but Omitsu just looked at us and smiled. She made no attempt to reprimand us.

Winter that year was extremely cold. In December, snow glistened almost every day. After the New Year, we had several big snows. One of those was said to be the heaviest in some decades.

Shinsuke reappeared briefly at New Year's, but then he did not come again until late January. As soon as I heard that Shinsuke was in town, I went out to Omitsu's storehouse. At New Year's, Shinsuke had told me that he would buy me a boys' magazine the next time he came, so I thought he had perhaps brought one.

By then, I was completely accustomed to the storehouse and would enter without invitation. This time, I just called out "Omitsu" and shuffled up the stairs. When I reached the top, I realized that I should not have come. The electricity in the village had been out for two or three days because of the snow, so the lights were off. Twilight was creeping into the dim room, and I sensed two bodies intertwined. It sounded as though they were cursing each other.

Finally, Omitsu stood up. "You idiot!" she said to Shinsuke as she lit the lamp. Her hair was dishevelled and her kimono was open.

"Oh, you've come at just the right time. Stay here," Omitsu told me. She sat down. About three feet away, Shinsuke sat cross-legged as if sulking, still gasping.

"I'm going home," I said. This was no time to ask about magazines. I did not know why, but I knew that I should not be there.

Just then, Omitsu pulled me toward her. "No, I want you to stay here with me. Shinsuke's giving me trouble, so I want you to protect me," she said.

"Don't make jokes," Shinsuke bellowed. "It doesn't matter what you say—I love you."

"I know you do. And I love you, too. Wasn't it because we love each other that we decided to part? Have you forgotten how firm a pledge we made at New Year's? Being apart is much more painful for me than it is for you. But didn't we resolve to part, just as if I were dead . . . for your sake?"

Then Omitsu fell face down on the floor, her shoulders heaving.

"I'm going home," I said.

“No, don’t,” she implored, sitting up. She continued to speak, looking at my face as if talking to me, but her words were clearly intended for Shinsuke.

“Shinsuke is weak-willed, and I don’t know what to do. Isn’t that right, boy? At the end of last year, Shinsuke failed at work and had no money left. So he got someone to scrape together some money with a promise that he would break with me. He’s forgotten all about that. What a fool he is!”

After that, she turned directly toward Shinsuke. “If it gets out that you haven’t broken with me, you’ll be in real trouble. You’ll be ruined.”

“It will be all right as long as no one finds out.”

“How could they not know?”

“All right. This will be the last night.”

“What are you saying? No. No. It won’t work. If you stay tonight, I’ll be the one who won’t let you go. I’m telling you this because I’m afraid of that side of me. All right? Let’s just end with a handshake. You’ll have to make do with that.”

Omitsu extended her delicate white hand toward Shinsuke, who sat sullen, arms folded. Looking angry, he put out his hand, grabbed Omitsu’s, and tried to pull her toward him.

“No. We’re not going to lay a hand on each other. Let’s take another pledge.”

Omitsu slowly removed Shinsuke’s hand, which he had placed on her shoulder, and linked her little finger with his in the manner of a solemn promise. “The boy here is our witness,” she said, as she brought my right hand to theirs. She placed my palm over their linked fingers.

“I’m going home,” I said again.

“Well, then I’m going to take Shinsuke to the station, so shall we all go out together?”

I stood, then Omitsu. Shinsuke, last of all, reluctantly rose to his feet. Then we went out into the snow, the wind rising. I parted company with the two of them in front of my house.

I watched from the entryway as they headed off through the snow toward the train station. Shinsuke was in front, wearing an overcoat and a brown hat like the ones Mongolians wear. Just behind him was Omitsu, with an overcoat and a scarf wrapped around her face.

I found this out later, but after they saw me home, Omitsu and Shinsuke went to the only tavern in our village. Shinsuke had three bottles of sake and Omitsu ate some noodles. They left the shop at ten, around the time that the snow turned into a raging blizzard. It would have been just a twenty-minute walk to the station, but the path ran through fields that offered no protection from the wind.

The next day, Omitsu's and Shinsuke's frozen bodies were found, about half a mile apart, in the snow-covered fields. It was assumed that they had been caught in the blizzard, lost their way, got separated, and, finally, died in the snow.

The day after the blizzard that claimed their lives, the sky was clear and cloudless. Shinsuke's body was taken by car to Nagano, and Omitsu's to her home village. As the truck carrying Omitsu's body lumbered along through the drifts, the villagers walked beside it, occasionally helping to sweep away snow.

There were a number of perspectives on the incident. Some villagers speculated that it might have been a premeditated lovers' suicide, while others thought that Omitsu had been forced into a double suicide as they walked along the road. The prevailing assumption, though, was that the two had been punished. There was evidence to support all these interpretations. Shinsuke's enterprises had taken a bad turn, and when you considered the triangle between Shinsuke, his wife, and Omitsu, it didn't seem so strange for old-fashioned village people to conclude that the couple's fate was divine retribution.

Now, thirty-odd years later, Omitsu has become small and faint in my memory, and the incident in which the young mistress died with a man in a blizzard a distant story. Even for the people who were there back then, it remains just a vague shadow. The question of whether it was a premeditated lovers' suicide, a forced double suicide, or a punishment from heaven has faded over the years. It now seems that all that happened was that a fearsome blizzard engulfed the two in death.

As a child at the time, I could not help but feel that the cause of Omitsu's death was none of the things that people imagined. Yet I could not express clearly what I sensed. All I could do was cry out in my heart, "That's not it!"

Ten, twenty years passed with me harboring this irritation. It was only recently that the significance of the two deaths came to me in vivid color, just like fireworks exploding in the sky.

It happened when I came across the German word *Ringwanderung*, as I was reading a book about mountain climbing. *Ringwanderung* is what mountain climbers in a blizzard or a fog must guard against most. Even when they are certain that they are walking in a straight line, they are apt to wander in a circle, some people veering left, others right. The book said that the best way to avoid *Ringwanderung* was for several people to walk abreast, moving forward while staying in contact.

When I read this, I slapped the book shut, immediately recalling Omitsu and Shinsuke. People had felt it odd that the bodies were discovered half a mile apart. Perhaps the two had fallen victim to *Ringwanderung*, unable to wander in the blizzard together.

Surely Omitsu had gone her own way and Shinsuke his.

Had she refused Shinsuke's hand in the blizzard, just as she had brushed it away in the storehouse? Perhaps she had had to refuse his hand. I recall the feeling of my small hand on top of Omitsu and Shinsuke's linked fingers. My own small child's hand.

The love of two people wandering in the whirling blizzard, each in their own circle.

I am now more than twenty years older than Omitsu was then. Two or three years ago, when I drove past the rice field where they died, I discovered that it had been turned into an apple orchard. ♦

(Translated, from the Japanese, by J. Martin Holman.)

Yasushi Inoue, who died in 1991, received Japan's Order of Culture in 1976. His books include the story collection "The Death of a Certain Woman" (2027).

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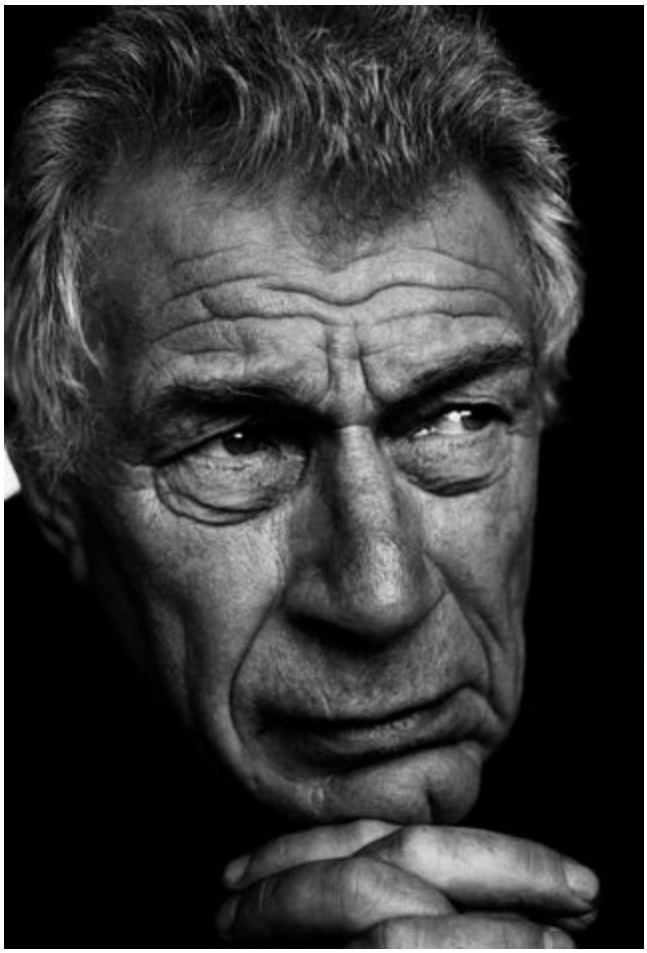
Books

The Lasting Influence of John Berger

His TV series “Ways of Seeing” popularized a Marxist view of art and made him a star. In his centennial year, his wide-ranging output continues to inspire and infuriate.

By **Merve Emre**

November 9, 2026



Always a charismatic figure, Berger established his reputation as a critic by the age of twenty-five.Photograph by Ara Güler / Magnum

Biographers do not advertise themselves as mediums. Still, the fantasy is there—that a book's subject will rise from its pages, like some stranded ghost, to clap one hand on the writer's shoulder and the other on the reader's. It is a fantasy that imparts romance to the work of intruding on the dead: flattering the family, interrogating the neighbors and lovers, sorting through mostly useless documents in the archive. Left unchecked, however, it can turn a biographer into a sentimental illusionist. He touches a finger's smudge on a letter. He walks into a bedroom and sniffs the air. He seems to see the man himself: his features fine and lined, his white shirt unbuttoned at the top of his chest, his mouth open, as if about to speak.

I am looking at the photograph on the cover of Tom Overton's "John Berger: From Life," the second biography of the British art critic and novelist that Verso Books has published since his death, in 2017. The first, Joshua Sperling's "A Writer of Our Time" (2018), was a brisk study that appraised Berger as a leftist popularizer of the Western tradition in art. Berger made his reputation as a critic by the age of twenty-five, asserting himself in contrast to the patrician figures of his era. A friend recalled how he would pull up to gallery openings on his motorcycle, cigarette dangling from his fingers and "lips always poised for utterance"—against private collectors, museums, and the cold, cerebral designs of abstract art, and for the people, the land, and largely realist paintings of the human body. Berger argued that art should be for everyone, rich or poor, no matter their country or creed. His low, deliberate voice could be heard over the radio and on television—most notably, in the BBC series "Ways of Seeing"—a gorgeous man with a startling impudence of gesture. In the first episode of "Ways of Seeing," he held a knife and appeared to carve Venus's head out of Botticelli's "Venus and Mars." The series united the country in the simultaneous acts of looking at him and listening to him deliver his judgments. He became known, Overton writes, as "the thrusting, tieless Marxist taking the tweedy establishment down a peg or two."

What We're Reading

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This month marks the centennial of Berger's birth, with numerous events arranged to celebrate his enduring influence. Overton's biography arrives on the heels of Verso's the Essential John Berger, thirteen reissues of various novels and essay collections. To pick through this haul is to realize that Berger's reputation rests not on a single, incomparable novel, and not even on his sizable and varied œuvre, but on a kind of attitude, adopted since his earliest reviews were published, in the nineteen-fifties. For Berger, the artist did not simply perceive the world; the world trained the artist's perceptions, teaching him what to look at, from what perspectives, and in what proportions. The artist, in turn, could wield his brush against the world's accepted values, its tendency to see people from a unitary, fixed perspective. He could paint "old, tired prostitutes" (Toulouse-Lautrec), "holy humble peasants" (Millet), or "the great sexual image of the nude" (Giorgione, Rembrandt, Watteau, Courbet) so that the viewer would glimpse these subjects from an odd angle, with tenderness and clarity. Berger formulated an idiosyncratic notion of Marxist criticism: an evaluation of an artist's greatness based on whether his creations could "encourage men to know and claim their social rights."

In reading Berger, one discovers that his Marxist aesthetic is less a doctrine than a vague and ennobling justification for why he liked the art that he did. What makes Berger special are, as he wrote about Picasso, "not his individual works, but his existence, his personality," his "new ways of looking at the world." Berger was an ideologue; most charismatic people are. As they age, they risk shrivelling into preachers or bores. Berger was saved from this fate by his restless searching, among mediums and forms, for the purest expression of his way of seeing. His novels, in particular, drew inspiration from Cubism's use of overlapping perspectives to arrive at a collective sense of reality. In "A Painter of Our Time" (1958), an artist's enigmatic journal entries are annotated by an art-critic friend. "G." (1972), which won the Booker Prize, is the story of a seducer, presented in a collage of memories, histories, essays, sheet music, and naughty doodles. The blind

narrator of “To the Wedding” (1995) has splintered visions of a father, a mother, and their daughter, who is dying of *AIDS*. A woman writes anguished letters to her imprisoned lover in “From A to X” (2008). These novels concern very different characters, in very different times and places. But their common subject is human perception, in all its variousness and instability—what Berger heralded as “the functioning of sight itself.”

Overton, who grew close to Berger while cataloguing his archives at the British Library, and who found, in a fallout shelter Berger once used for storage, a tranche of sooty diaries and drafts, had a mass of material from which to sketch a dense and sober portrait. Yet his biography is anything but rigorously archival. Like Berger, Overton wants to create the illusion of a life seen from many different perspectives. He calls his subject “John,” sometimes addressing him directly, and often breaks into the present tense, to speculate about what John is, at this very moment, thinking or feeling. The smallest details are magnified, whereas significant events pass with almost no mention. I could not keep the procession of Berger’s wives and lovers straight, but I did get a vivid impression of the blue window shutters, on which he painted lines from “A Winter’s Tale,” at a house in Gloucestershire where he lived for a time. The biography is as random, repetitive, uneven, and blurred as life itself, which makes it an unusual and exciting experiment, if not an entirely successful one.

Overton recalls Berger snarling, “My fucking biography.” Not very comradely, John. But one respects his resistance to a genre whose conventions he resisted so strenuously in his novels—in particular, the heroic individualism of an exceptional protagonist. One respects, too, Overton’s effort to graft Berger’s literary techniques onto the story of his life, as if to revive his consciousness in the present. “John liked the idea of stories as a way of rebuilding the connection with the dead,” Overton writes. “What he did uniquely was to use paintings, drawings, photographs to drill holes in time.” Biography can also open a portal between past and present, admitting the ghost. He is here, hunched over the biographer as he writes.

Berger rarely spoke about his childhood. His only extended pieces of writing about it are two essays, “Mother” (1986) and “Ulysses” (1991). His

mother, Miriam, the daughter of a warehouse foreman in South London, was a thrifty and secretive woman who reminded Berger of an agouti, a kind of Latin American rodent that he once saw at London Zoo. Stanley, his father, was a fastidious petit-bourgeois boy from Liverpool. An aspiring Anglican priest, Stanley had left theological college at the beginning of the First World War, to enlist. After the Armistice, he worked at the Institute of Cost and Works Accountants, ascending its ranks—by 1941, Berger wrote, he was doing "work for the government on the question of how to increase factory production." Priestly and actuarial leanings conspired to make Stanley an anxious father. He audited his son's reading, for fear that the boy's soul would come to a bad end. When Berger was fourteen, Stanley confiscated his copy of James Joyce's "Ulysses" and locked it in a safe. Berger retaliated by painting a diabolic portrait of his father "with the colors of Mephistopheles."



Cartoon by John O'Brien

Still, the impression one gets is of a typically mid-century English upbringing: rigid, reserved, irreproachable. After his parents died, Berger contemplated writing an autobiography so that he might keep their company a little longer. "Yet I have no wish to do so," he wrote. "All that interests me about my past life are the common moments. The moments—which if I relate them well enough—will join countless others lived by people I do not personally know." This is the sort of declaration that makes

the biographer's heart sink, before he rolls up his sleeves and gets to work padding things out. From the records of the War Office, Overton tracks Stanley's battalion through the French trenches. In court filings, he discovers that Miriam was married before, to a man named Alfred, who suffered from "frigidity and impotence." The meteorological report issued for the month of the Bergers' wedding documents shifting winds. Overton's account of Berger's birth, on November 5, 1926, Guy Fawkes Day, is pure, overwrought conjecture:

> I don't know where Stanley is in Hackney, but, in the noise and the flashes, I know where he is in his memory: wherever he is when John hears him screaming in his sleep. Then he holds his newborn son. The boy's face is liquid, turbid with generations of resemblances. As they flicker to the surface, the father recognizes some of them.

Berger was sent to St. Edward's School in Oxford, where he scowled and wrote morbid little stories. With only a smattering of childhood diary entries and letters to hand, Overton cites "boarding-school syndrome" to explain his surliness. Berger's own descriptions are cheekier, more self-ironizing. "I was in revolt against Caesar, whose histories I had to read, the school chaplain, the school barber who cut my hair too short, middle-class philistinism that had no time for poetry and art, the Officer's Training Corps," he wrote. He read *Labour Monthly* and wore a hammer-and-sickle pin in the buttonhole of his school jacket. His parents and teachers assumed, improbably, that he would stay in Oxford and attend the university that had minted colonial administrators like so many dirty banknotes. Instead, he won a scholarship to London's Central School of Arts and Crafts, where he studied for just over a year before being called up to the Army, in 1944. Aiming to get himself "psycho'd out" of service, he burned himself with cigarettes and ended up manning the library at a military psychiatric hospital near Belfast.

Returning to London when the war was over, Berger began to paint in earnest. His work was featured in several exhibitions, with modest success. When he met an illustrator named Pat Marriott, she represented for him a kind of limitless "physical freedom." In 1949, they married and immediately clashed over money: he wanted to spend his days at the bell

foundry in Croydon, drawing the workers' hands as they adjusted pulleys and chains; she wanted him to write for magazines, which, in those days, paid quite well. An early essay, "Drawing," from 1953, stages a rapprochement of sorts. Berger describes sketching a nude model as a delicate interplay between looking and sensing the pressure of each pencil stroke, one after the other, turning "the infinite, opaque possibilities of the blank page" into a "particular and lucid" image. "I saw that the line down the center of the torso, from the pit of the neck, between the nipples, over the navel and between the legs, was like the keel of a boat," he writes.

As a draftsman, he was a sensualist, enraptured by the human body and scornful of abstraction. As a critic, primarily for the *The New Statesman*, he railed against Pollock's "great walls of silver, pink, new gold, pale blue nebulae," signs of a decadent culture whose artists refused to connect with the public. A lumpy Henry Moore sculpture of a woman in repose expressed "nothing about the way a body moves, grows or is controlled." But Poussin's nymphs, Courbet's nudes, and Goya's "Maja" struck him with an "intensely sensuous vision of the human body" and protested against its unfreedom in the modern economic order.

Berger's polemics received a more astringent airing in his first novel, "A Painter of Our Time." The book is presented as the journal of Janos, a proud and neglected Hungarian painter. Janos cannot bear the corruption and greed of London's curators and collectors. Yet he has no desire to return to Budapest and become a "professional revolutionary," surrendering his canvases to socialist-realist kitsch. He is a kind of double émigré: there is no country where he can reconcile the demands of his artistic ambition with the obligation he feels to serve mankind in its struggle for a more just social order. "We become half-men, sophisticates, cynics, time-servers," Janos writes. "Such half-men abound in this society, for it is a society incapable of recognizing or using the capabilities of a vast majority of its citizens." His entries are interspersed with commentary from his art-critic friend John. In italicized sections around the journal entries, John tells a story that grounds Janos's abstract ideas in believable figures. Together, these two half-men create a whole picture of the vexed position of the socialist artist in a capitalist world.

“A Painter of Our Time” seeded the idées fixes that Berger would tend for the next half century. Among them was the nude as “a revolutionary subject.” The nude was a pictorial genre that, historically, turned a woman’s naked form into an “erotic ornament,” and was “closely associated with values of tact, luxury and wealth.” The artists Berger admired painted nudes that negated these values, whether through choice of subject—the “ ‘vulgar’ nakedness” of Courbet’s countrywoman washing her clothes in a river—or through choice of style, as with Rubens’s “compulsive painting of the softness of fat flesh.” Berger ascribed a similarly revolutionary potential to sex. To unleash this potential, the artist would have to lay bare “the shared subjectivity of sex,” a phrase that Berger repeated across several essays and defined as the way two people in bed can jointly inhabit a reality available to no one else.

“It is easy enough to treat sex as a comic aspect of John’s life, or in some ways a reprehensible one,” Overton writes. “It caused plenty of hurt.” The exact timing of this “hurt,” of Berger’s many flirtations and infidelities, is difficult to follow. Berger eventually divorced Pat Marriott to marry Lady Rosemary Kilmarnock, whom he had met when she purchased one of his paintings. Then, in 1958, he divorced Kilmarnock to marry Anya Bostock, a Russian translator with whom he had corresponded for years. Together, they moved to Geneva—she could get good translating work there, and Berger was keen to leave England behind—and had two children. He dedicated his next three books to her: two novels of British middle-class life, “The Foot of Clive” (1962) and “Corker’s Freedom” (1964), and his moving nonfiction account of an English country doctor, “A Fortunate Man” (1967). Even in that book, when the bodies being documented are in disrepair, eros comes crashing through. “Her overworked brown arms, her deeply lined face, her creased strained neck were suddenly denied by the whiteness of her breast,” Berger writes, of a wheezing old woman who will die later that day.

Given Berger’s appetite for women—“He considers making love to be the most worthwhile thing in life,” an acquaintance said—Overton’s attention to the dead seems suspiciously partial. He promises to be forthright about sex. Most biographical writing about Berger has tried to “politely ignore it and pretend we can just talk about the work,” he chides. But, in the main,

Overton represses sexuality as a momentous force in Berger's writing and one crucial to his political imagination. This repression ricochets onto the biographer himself; there is an uninterrogated Oedipal longing that has driven many men on the left to adore and emulate Berger. If Berger had stayed merely an art critic and an experimental novelist, then he would not have been the subject of a biography animated by such a distracting desire for his physical company.

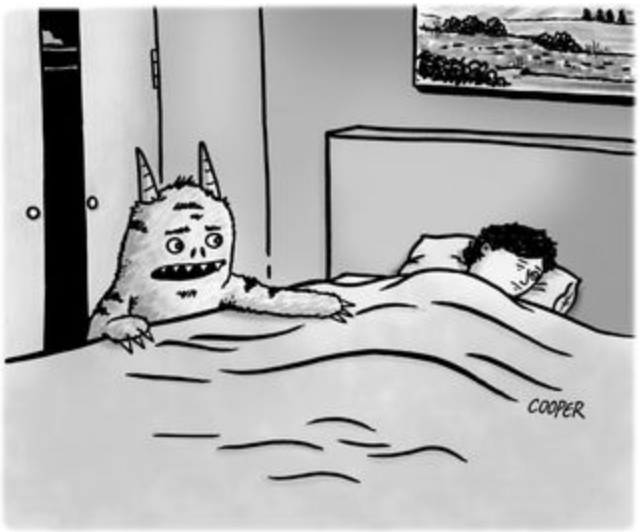
For that, Berger had to become a celebrity, an irresistible and unparalleled public figure. His ascent to fame took place in 1972, with two triumphs: the broadcast of "Ways of Seeing" and the publication of "G." "Ways of Seeing" was a sensation, the first time a British socialist had commandeered a medium as diffuse as "telly" to comment on culture. The first episode was an elegant distillation of Walter Benjamin's essay "The Work of Art in the Age of Mechanical Reproduction": The visual arts had originated as a form of magic, of divine revelation. Then their authority became inseparable from wealth, from the palaces, museums, and fine homes where art works were displayed. Now, Berger explained, images of art had become "ephemeral, ubiquitous, insubstantial, available, valueless, free." What was needed was a corresponding change in how images could be used to connect "a people or class" to its past.

The most thrilling of the episodes was the second, on the history of the nude:

> To be born a woman has been to be born, within an allotted and confined space, into the keeping of men. The social presence of women has developed as a result of their ingenuity in living under such tutelage within such a limited space. But this has been the cost of a woman's self being split into two. A woman must continually watch herself. She is almost continually accompanied by her own image of herself.

From this split self, Berger derived a distinction between nakedness and nudity. To be naked is simply to be oneself, but to be nude is "to be seen naked by others and yet not recognized for oneself." The best paintings manage to turn nudity into nakedness by rendering the body as "impossibly

dynamic,” creating a play of light and shadow that deepens the mystery of the sitter’s innermost self as much as it reveals her outer figure.



“You may have given up on your dreams, but your nightmares will always be here for you.” Cartoon by Nathan Cooper

Much the same words appear in “G.,” Berger’s fragmentary novel about a modern Don Juan whose sexual escapades, in the decades before the First World War, take place against a backdrop of mass uprisings. G. is a vector of history. His father is a nouveau-riche Italian candied-fruit manufacturer, a fat, philandering capitalist, his mother an American heiress who becomes a Fabian socialist. G. is raised in the English countryside by his mother’s family and is seduced by his aunt Beatrice, whose sadistic husband was killed in the Boer Wars. This seduction establishes the blueprint for what follows—that sex will oppose violent, imperial conquest. G. swiftly alights on a series of women: an Italian hotel maid in Brig, where crowds gather to see if a young aviator will be the first to successfully fly across the Pennine Alps; a bourgeois Parisian in Domodossola; a Slovenian peasant and an Austrian diplomat’s wife in Trieste, during clashes there between Italians and Slavs. His seductions seem to gain their exquisitely attentive energy from the people’s anger and hope.

G. is maneuvered around Europe by a peculiarly restless omniscient narrator who may be, in one moment, far removed from the action—in a monoplane circling the Matterhorn, say—and, in the next, under the covers with G. and a woman. Often, the narrator breaks off the story to deliver an

aperçu, cite a news headline, draw a dirty picture, or speak to readers in the first person, from Paris in 1972, where he shaves and picks up his dry cleaning. Berger is as present in the novel as he was on television, and he never lets his readers forget that he has deliberately selected the Don Juan story to reveal that political freedom and sexual pleasure are atmospherically connected. But he also cleverly updates the tale. Don Juan is a callous seducer, resented by the women he has deceived and dragged off to Hell for his sins. Berger's libertine is a liberator, a vehicle of pleasure. He elicits a reciprocal exchange of gazes: sensuous, precise, and awed, equally desiring and equally vulnerable. Both he and the woman have to appear singularly naked, not nude, before each other.

Ben Lerner, in an introduction to a recent reissue of "G." (New York Review Books), seems to shuffle his feet and look down at the ground, all but apologizing for the novel's emphasis on sexual penetration. Well, what of it? Berger's vision of sex hinges not on what goes where but on the shared experience of reality that sex creates. His grammar of sex privileges verbs over nouns. "Applied to the central moment of sex, all written nouns denote their objects in such a way that they reject the meaning of the experience," he writes. Whereas "sexual verbs (fuck, frig, suck, kiss, etc., etc.) remain less foreign than the nouns," as they illuminate the shifting "relation between subject and object." Isolating a moment in sex makes as much sense as isolating a note in an opera, or a sentence in a novel. Each moment derives its meaning from the moments leading up to it, and from the moments that follow. One judges not the individual parts or the positions but the collective rhythm.

In "G.," the experience of sexual rhythm is writ large, onto the form of the novel itself. "G." moves entirely to its own beat. Its sudden shocks and its dramatic leaps in time and place are interleaved with calmer reveries on the revolutionary arc of history. Just as the rhythms of sex convert a single, fixed subjectivity into a shared, dynamic one, so, Berger writes, do mass demonstrations "manifest a greater freedom and independence—greater creativity" than anyone could achieve "individually or collectively when pursuing their regular lives."

Berger joked that the novel's utopian coupling of political and sexual desire would make him into a "marxist Stendhal." When it won the Booker Prize, Berger found the award intolerable, because it had been endowed by a family whose wealth came from plantations in Guyana. The stirring, outrageous climax of Overton's biography is a present-tense vignette of Berger drunkenly rejecting the prize at the Booker's celebration dinner and pledging to donate half of his winnings to the Black Panthers of Britain. "That speech is why you became famous enough for your archive to go to the national library in the city of your birth, why I end up cataloguing it, and why I find myself speaking to you now," Overton writes.

"Is it your best year?" Overton asks. "The next though, 1973, is certainly your worst, the year I find it hardest to respect you." There had been plenty of affairs—Nella Bielski, Annar Cassam, Lorraine Gill (the names pile up, meaninglessly)—but 1973 was the year that Berger left Anya Bostock and their two young children for Beverly Bancroft, the scion of a prominent Californian family. Having previously read Sperling's biography, I had no strong judgments about Berger's treatment of women. It was hardly a shock to learn that men on the left did not extend the same principles of equality and nonexploitation to their wives that they did to mankind in the abstract—that they could be unfaithful or abandon their children, citing, all the while, the punishingly conventional nature of marriage. I was, however, shocked that Overton sees fit to absolve his subject. "Perhaps you didn't do what was expected of contemporary fathers, but you were there," he writes. The dead rarely come back as we would like them to. They are covered by the grime and the stink of life. It is not the biographer's job to wipe them clean.

In 1974, Berger and Bancroft moved to Quincy, a village in the French Alps, where he lived until shortly before his death. He shovelled shit and tended to animals and wrote the loose novels that made up his "Into Their Labors" trilogy: "Pig Earth" (1979), "Once in Europa" (1983), and "Lilac and Flag" (1990). In Quincy, Berger wrote as if he had been transported to a simpler time, when wandering storytellers told tales by the fire and the landscapes of Courbet and Millet had not yet been ravaged by industrial capitalism. Yet these peasant fictions—their local vistas and workaday rhythms, their folksy dialogue and descriptions shorn bare as sheep—feel

more affected than the painterly daubs and flourishes that Berger now renounced.

In interviews, Berger described his turn to the pastoral as the outgrowth of his “Romantic Marxism.” Overton seizes on the figure of the Romantic Marxist as a historical type, aiming to replace a “mushy reverence” for Berger among the British left with a more concrete case for his significance. But what type of person is a Romantic Marxist? A class-conscious libertine? A womanizer who supports women’s lib? The vague and stentorian tone of Berger’s late political pronouncements provides a clue. He came out on the side of what was good: the rights of animals, peasants, migrants, political prisoners. He showed no deep interest, however, in the particulars of their histories. If he typified anything, it was not a Romantic Marxist but what the late Hungarian philosopher G. M. Tamás called a Rousseauian socialist: an intellectual devoted to equality among the people, but without a radical commitment to class abolition. Berger longed, instead, to return to “a more natural (and with luck, completely natural) way of life” and championed “the folk-art virtues.”

Class was an abstraction, and Berger hated abstraction. “The people,” however, could be embodied, drawn close to and lived among. But his peasant fictions sapped his writing of its revolutionary energy and replaced it with a moral imperative. The aim was not a way of seeing—sharply, dialectically—but a way of living, nostalgically. Yet Berger had long anticipated this criticism. In “A Painter of Our Time,” the director of a London gallery dismisses Janos as a “Desperate Optimist”: “They’re sentimentalists at heart. They idealize what’s called The People. But, believe me, people just aren’t like that.” The final act of Berger’s life argued otherwise, with a desperate optimism of the will. A little more pessimism of the intellect would have been most welcome. ♦

Merve Emre is a contributing writer at The New Yorker and the Shapiro-Silverberg Professor of Creative Writing and Criticism at Wesleyan University.

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Books

Briefly Noted

“The End of Everything,” “Gloria Don’t Speak,” “Shakespeare at Thirty,” and “Almost Animal.”

November 9, 2026



The End of Everything, *by M. John Harrison (Riverhead).* In this accomplished work, both dreamlike and incisive, strange beings of an unknown nature have colonized Earth. Years after their arrival, an elderly woman with dementia, who lives in a house near a crashed Airbus A330, and her beachcomber nephew, embark on a kind of quest with no grail. The novel brings them, by turns, to a space-telecommunications facility, an abandoned museum, and other locales half prosaic, half bizarre. Flush with gorgeous descriptions of the environment and observations about art, science, difference, the past, and the future, Harrison’s book is also a reminder of how easily humanity can incorporate transformation, or dissolution: “The apocalypse seemed to withhold itself, quickly becoming just another historical continuity.”



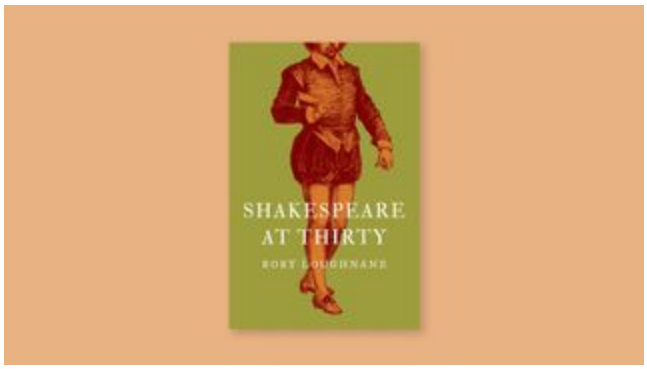
Gloria Don’t Speak, *by Lucy Apps (Mariner)*. Nineteen-year-old Gloria, the neurodivergent and minimally verbal protagonist of this début, spends her days wandering around London alone, “trying not to attract too much attention.” Then she meets Jack, a rant-prone man who feels overlooked by society. “He has no one to talk to and she has no one to listen to, so they can fit with each other”—or so Gloria thinks. They pass time drinking Coke and eating chips, until one night Jack violently lashes out. As the novel follows Gloria over the ensuing decades, she processes her and Jack’s consequential relationship, and Apps thoughtfully sketches the psychology of a person often relegated to the periphery.

What We’re Reading

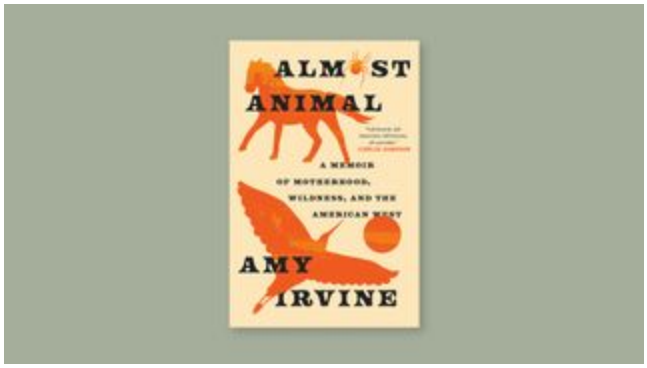


Illustration by Henri Campeã

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Shakespeare at Thirty, *by Rory Loughnane (Princeton)*. Who was Shakespeare before he became the Shakespeare of “Hamlet” and “King Lear”? Loughnane considers the inevitability of the most celebrated English writer by concentrating on the Bard’s early life, when he was still “a relative nobody.” Alongside a nuanced picture of the poet-playwright’s upbringing, marriage, and professional beginnings, a simultaneous portrait of Elizabethan England emerges: a place of recurrent plague, political instability, bitter literary feuds, and a nascent theatregoing culture. Loughnane pays attention to the practice of collaborative playwriting, a common technique that Shakespeare moved away from as his artistry developed.



Almost Animal, *by Amy Irvine (Spiegel & Grau)*. This memoir begins in Salt Lake City, on the night that the author, whose family has been in Utah for six generations, goes into labor. Until that point, Irvine writes, she had spent her “whole life taking off or getting away.” Becoming a mother limits this tendency; it also brings, for Irvine, postpartum depression. When she moves to a mesa in Colorado with her husband and daughter, she encounters the unruly ways of the wild in the form of invading creatures (a bear, black widows) and strange illnesses that afflict her young child.

Growing increasingly lonely, she wonders whether her Mormon female forebears similarly felt “some unshakable sense that they were an exotic species imported from a wildly different habitat.”

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https://www.newyorker.com/magazine/2026/11/16/the-end-of-everything-gloria-dont-speak-shakespeare-at-thirty-almost-animal

Books

Why Are We So Good at Feeling Bad?

A behavioral economist sets out to explain why we're so prone to overreacting and spiralling.

By Louis Menand

November 9, 2026



"At the heart of so many of our miseries," George Loewenstein says, "is not the fact that we feel bad, but the belief that we should feel otherwise." Our brains fight with themselves.Illustration by Tim Enthoven

Charles Darwin was not a well man. As a youth, he suffered from scarlet fever and eczema. He couldn't stand the sight of blood at medical school, and his five-year voyage on the Beagle brought seasickness, headaches, and infections. After returning to England, in 1836, he developed severe anxiety and gastrointestinal issues, including bouts of vomiting and flatulence. He also suffered from insomnia, fatigue, and depression.

In 1849, ten years before he published "On the Origin of Species," he wrote to a friend of "dreadful vomiting every week" and reported, "I was not able to do anything one day out of three." He thought that he was "rapidly going the way of all flesh." In fact, he lived another thirty-three years, though the ailments never left him. Giving a scientific paper, or even attending a party, could overwhelm him. By then, he had moved to a village in Kent, rarely venturing out without his wife, Emma.

From 1849 to 1855, Darwin kept a "diary of health," recording his conditions as "goodish," "poorish," and "very bad fl[atulence] with fright." He consulted some twenty doctors and tried Victorian cures, including hydrotherapy, which offered some relief, and galvanism. Diagnoses included nervous dyspepsia, water brash (acid reflux), and "suppressed gout" (whatever that is).

What We're Reading

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What was the problem? Retrospective diagnoses range from Chagas' disease, a parasitic illness he might have contracted in South America, to lactose intolerance. He may have suffered from some combination of diseases and allergies, and possibly Crohn's. But some symptoms suggest a psychological condition. Agoraphobia with panic disorder is a plausible diagnosis.

Whatever the cause or causes, Darwin must, at some point, have asked himself, I got naturally selected for *this*? Of course, not every affliction has an evolutionary purpose. People get sick. But our extraordinary susceptibility to misery does raise a question about what kind of creatures natural selection has made us. We get depressed when we win the lottery;

we lie awake worrying about whether the car needs new tires; we feel jealous when our girlfriend talks too long with the barista.

Anxiety might have adaptive utility when we are in danger of being eaten by a sabre-toothed tiger. But there are not a lot of sabre-toothed tigers around anymore, and we still get anxious, frequently for no very good reason. We don't just react emotionally to things. We overreact. Why have genes for emotional overreaction, rather than genes for being cool, calm, and collected, been passed along? Wouldn't we be reproductively fitter if we weren't unhappy so much of the time?

These are questions George Loewenstein tries to answer in "The Opposite of Happiness: How Bad Feelings Make and Break Us" (Harper). Loewenstein, who teaches at Carnegie Mellon, is a leader in the field of behavioral economics. Neoclassical economics relied on the fiction of the rational actor, someone who makes decisions by way of a judicious calculation of self-interest. Behavioral economics, by contrast, emphasizes the nonrational factors in economic decision-making. Whatever human beings are rational about, it's not money. We overspend it; we under-save it; we buy stuff on impulse. We generally don't do the math. Why it took so long for this to dawn on economists is mystifying. Didn't those people ever read a novel? Virtually every famous nineteenth-century novel is about people behaving badly around money.

Still, figuring out why we act foolishly when we could, or should, or want to act otherwise is a worthy academic pursuit. Among Loewenstein's contributions is the identification of what he calls "empathy gaps," our inability to imagine how we would feel or behave in an emotional state different from the one we're in. When we're pain-free, we can't really remember what pain feels like. When we're angry, we can't imagine being calm. Emotions, Loewenstein argues, can reprogram our whole psyche. He gives a personal example: learning that it is better to wait a day before responding to an annoying e-mail.

Didn't we know this already, though? Adam Smith made similar observations in "The Theory of Moral Sentiments" (1759). And some of Loewenstein's work does seem to amount to a confirmation of common sense. One of his experiments, for instance, measured the effect of sexual

arousal on judgment and decision-making in male students. Guess what? A sexually aroused young man reported a greater willingness to engage in morally questionable behavior to obtain sexual gratification.

Explaining how feelings affect our judgment is one thing. Why so many emotions make us unhappy is another. That's the larger question Loewenstein takes up. His thesis is that these emotions "were built to keep us alive and reproducing, not to keep us happy."

Loewenstein is hardly alone in proposing evolutionary explanations for misery. Randolph M. Nesse, a psychiatrist, made a similar case in "Good Reasons for Bad Feelings: Insights from the Frontier of Evolutionary Psychiatry" (2019), a work Loewenstein discusses. Such arguments recall the "selfish gene" model. Evolution is not about the reproduction of persons, is the idea. It's about the reproduction of genes. And, from a gene's point of view, the body is just a disposable gene container. It can fret about the tires, climb the Matterhorn, write "On the Origin of Species"—whatever, as long as the genes keep getting passed along. Darwin may have been wretched much of the time, but he had ten children. He checked the evolutionary box. Was he also farting and throwing up a lot? Sure. His genes didn't care.



"We're offering you the promotion, on the condition that you won't take a trip back to your home town, fall in love with the local baker, and learn that the true meaning of Christmas is family." Cartoon by Jeremy Nguyen

But Loewenstein thinks that negative emotions aren't simply a design flaw or a regrettable by-product of natural selection. On the contrary, he thinks that we have good evolutionary reasons for being able to feel bad. Our

ancestors would have been less “fit” to pass their genes along if they hadn’t been equipped with negative emotions. Fear could save us from predators; guilt could help us maintain the social bonds on which survival depended.

Knowing this, Loewenstein warns, won’t make us feel any less unhappy. “I offer in these pages no tips and precious little advice,” he writes. “This is *not* a self-help book.” (I wonder whether his publishers tried to talk him out of that.) Loewenstein describes the book as, instead, “one scientist’s bird’s-eye view of the subject, shaped by broad reading, personal experience, and, in many cases, my own research.”

“The Opposite of Happiness” is fairly nontechnical. There is no talk of neurotransmitters, and Loewenstein, who has himself conducted brain-imaging research, thinks that the interpretation of functional-MRI scans is often “not much more reliable than reading tea leaves.” The book is also quite personal, although selectively so. Loewenstein lets us know, for example, that he suffers from paruresis (shy-bladder syndrome) but neglects to mention that he is a great-grandson of Sigmund Freud, whose theories of unconscious drives bear some family resemblance to Loewenstein’s account of our emotional programming.

The problem with a lot of evolutionary psychology is that its explanations are hard to verify. It undertakes to explain an observable fact (we fret about bald tires) with an unobservable one (cavemen worried that a mastodon might trample them). Loewenstein is alert to the danger of producing “just-so” stories, accounts of human attributes based on unconfirmable hunches about what life was like in the Paleolithic era. But they’re hard to avoid.

Even if we accept these evolutionary explanations, they leave a further puzzle. Why do negative emotions so often persist long after they’ve served their purpose? Like the earworms of cheesy pop songs, they can get stuck in our heads. Our brains continue pumping them out even when the occasions for them have passed.

We also have the unfortunate ability to reëxperience some negative feelings just by remembering the occasions for them. We may find it hard to recall what physical pain felt like once it has stopped, but, when we remember

something shameful we did, we can feel the shame all over again. Most of us could use an empathy gap there.

“At the heart of so many of our miseries,” Loewenstein says, “is not the fact that we feel bad, but the belief that we should feel otherwise.” Our brains fight with themselves. We feel ashamed of our shame, angry about our anger. The wish to escape an unpleasant emotion becomes another source of misery. Who’s running the show in there?

Not “us.” We may resolve, after firing off an intemperate e-mail, to respond more calmly the next time. But, when the next provocation arrives, our anger can make the resolution seem lame. As Loewenstein explains, we are adept at psychological self-sabotage. Sometimes our very efforts to gain control make things worse, as when athletes concentrate too intently on not trying so hard.

In the second half of “The Opposite of Happiness,” Loewenstein lets unhappiness sufferers speak for themselves. He has gathered their stories through what he calls the Misery Survey, in which more than five hundred respondents were asked about their experiences of negative emotions. Each was assigned an emotion at random and asked whether it had caused them misery. If it had, they were invited to describe the experience; if not, they were assigned another emotion. The stories make for fun reading (more or less), not so much because they hold surprises but because we recognize ourselves in so many of them. Misery, it turns out, loves company.

Loewenstein devotes a chapter to each of twelve varieties of misery. It’s a bit like Dante’s Inferno if Dante had modelled his work on the *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual of Mental Disorders* rather than the “Summa Theologiae” of Thomas Aquinas. The first two circles in Loewenstein’s hell are Impatience and Boredom, followed by Anger, Envy, Jealousy, Rejection, Guilt, Shame, Anxiety, Regret, Loneliness, and, in the last circle, Depression, which he deems “a fitting finale to this Hieronymus Bosch underworld of psychic torments—not just because it is so supremely awful, but because nearly all the other miseries, when they persist and accumulate, can give rise to it.” (Hate, a resurgent political emotion across much of the planet, did not make the list. Neither did grief.)

Loewenstein suspects that depression, unlike some other negative emotions, has no adaptive function of its own. It arises, he thinks, as a by-product of other psychological systems in distress. That's close to what Peter D. Kramer concluded in his 2005 book, "Against Depression," where he defines depression as "a disease in which a host of injuries combine to cause a common downstream process that becomes self-sustaining." It is hard to see how suicidality conduces to reproductive success. And depression can create what Loewenstein terms "the ultimate empathy gap": people in its grip find it almost impossible to imagine what life without it would feel like.

At the other end of his inferno is boredom. We might not think of boredom as an emotion. It seems more like the absence of emotion. But, in a study tracking the daily feelings of some four thousand adults, Loewenstein and his colleagues found that boredom frequently accompanied strong negative feelings, including anger and anxiety. "We found that boredom was 4.2 times more likely to occur in the presence of another negative emotion than a positive one," he says.

Two places where people commonly report being bored are doctors' waiting rooms and airport terminals. We sit there fiddling with our smartphones, and with nothing else to do, running scary or angry scenarios through our heads—the medical news will not be good, the flight will be cancelled, they will close the gate while I'm in line at Starbucks—and composing powerfully cogent letters to the airline about the incompetence of the gate crew. We get mad when we are forced to wait for something for which there are no substitutes, and then we complain that we're bored. (In a section titled "Why Are Dreams So Boring?," Loewenstein says that one of the most "excruciatingly boring" things we can do is listen to someone describe a dream they had. This reads like a barely veiled put-down of his famous forebear.)

But how did we acquire the capacity for boredom? There don't seem to have been airports or doctors' offices back in Paleolithic times, when men just hunted and gathered (and, we hope, partied). Loewenstein suggests that the ability to become bored developed as a way of budgeting attention. "If early humans didn't feel the urge to redirect their attention when staring at

the same patch of woods," he says, "they might have missed important opportunities—a rustle in the bush that signaled prey, or an approaching threat. Our ancestors who were better at reallocating attention had an adaptive advantage: they probably avoided more predators, found more food, and pursued more socially or intellectually engaging activities." This might be a little just-so-y. It's hard to see how the humans or proto-humans who never got bored were the ones who got selected out. Maybe sabre-toothed tigers ate them all.

Other evolutionary explanations seem more persuasive. Loewenstein agrees with many people who have written about negative emotions that feelings like shame and guilt perform a regulatory social function. They help enforce the norms of the group. Shame, in particular, encourages submission rather than confrontation, a response "designed to protect us from one of the greatest threats to our survival—being cast out."

Explaining why negative emotions might have evolved, though, still leaves that problem of why they can become so consuming, so hard to toggle off. Why *do* we spiral? Is it because we inherited emotions like anxiety which evolved in response to genuine threats to survival and can now be triggered by the prospect of missing the bus? Or were our emotions always liable to become excessive? Did our Stone Age ancestors lie awake wondering whether they had remembered to put out the fire pit?

Loewenstein thinks that it's at least partly the latter. Our emotional system, he says, "is prone, almost by design, to malfunction." To protect us against threats, it has to be highly sensitive, prone to false alarms rather than risk missing a real danger. But this sensitivity also makes the system unstable. He believes our psyches are poised on a "razor's edge" between negative feedback, which allows an emotion to subside when the threat has passed, and positive feedback, in which an emotion amplifies itself. Anxiety, for example, makes us more alert to threats, which can make us perceive more threats, which heightens our anxiety. It's like driving on an icy road: the harder we brake, the more we lose control of the car.

Of course, an emotion that makes us miserable is not necessarily an irrational response to our circumstances. One question we can ask about psychological diagnoses is whether some states we classify as symptoms of

mental disorders are responses to a world that's genuinely frightening or depressing. What if life really is meaningless? What if other people really are out to get us? What if the barista really is hitting on our girlfriend? Then feelings like sadness, anger, and jealousy might be perfectly understandable, and the emotions that need to be explained are optimism, tolerance, and a sense of humor. Maybe it's the optimists who are the crazy ones.

In the list of books that helped replace a theological understanding of the universe with a secular one, "On the Origin of Species" is near the top. One theory about Darwin's poor health, in fact, was that he was horrified by the implications of his own discoveries—that our species was not a special creation and that no providence dictated its characteristics. Natural selection is a blind process. There is no being out there or up there that oversees its course.

Still, there is a way in which evolutionary psychology belongs to a religious tradition, the tradition of theodicy. This was the effort of theologians to explain why, given an omnipotent and beneficent God, there is evil in the world. Transposed to a Darwinian world view, this becomes the question: If natural selection has equipped us to survive and reproduce, why has it burdened us with so much misery? There is a temptation to assume that every form of suffering must have served some evolutionary purpose, just as God must have had a reason for earthquakes in Lisbon. The problem of why bad things happen kept intellectuals busy for centuries. The problem of unhappiness promises to do the same. It may be that both depend on a shared illusion: that it all makes sense. ♦

Louis Menand is a staff writer at The New Yorker. His books include "The Free World: Art and Thought in the Cold War," released in 2021, and "The Metaphysical Club," which was awarded a Pulitzer Prize for history.

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Pop Music

The Long-Awaited Rise of Tinashe

After more than a decade of niche popularity, the singer released “Popstar”—an album whose title was a self-fulfilling prophecy.

By Kelefa Sanneh

November 9, 2026



At a sold-out show at Brooklyn Paramount, the crowd hollered loudest for Tinashe’s sassiest lyrics.Illustration by Bijou Karman; Source photograph courtesy Hugo Comte

In 2014, a twenty-year-old singer named Tinashe released a steamy track called “2 On,” which proved to be extremely popular and a little bit misleading. The song didn’t top the pop chart, but new listeners kept finding it, and then coming back to it; on Spotify, it has been streamed more than eight hundred million times. Over a low-slung hip-hop beat, Tinashe sings, “I love to get 2 on,” and then she explains what that means: “Get

faded, turn up, bruh, pour it on up till I can't even think no more / Get ratchet, go dumb, then go more dumb, then we can keep it lit, let's roll." Her delivery is seductive enough to make the two lines rhyme, and to make the anatomically specific guest verse, from the rapper ScHoolboy Q, seem entirely appropriate. Tinashe was brought up in show business, having worked as a child actor and as a member of a girl group, the Stunners, whose addition to the canon of bubblegum pop was a playfully robotic song called, fittingly, "Bubblegum." The success of "2 On" seemed to herald her arrival as a grownup R. & B. hitmaker, ready to take her place among the genre's gyrating headliners, with songs about hookups, heartbreaks, and nights out that were either unforgettable or unrememberable.

In fact, the singer who made her name promising to "go dumb" turned out to be an uncommonly thoughtful and careful musician, turning out meticulously crafted songs that earned her a small army of fans convinced that it should be a big army. Tinashe struggled with her record company, RCA, which at one point released an earnest love song, "Flame," which she evidently did not consider her best work. ("I cried for two days when they told me I had to put that song out as a single," she later said.) For a while, she distributed her music independently, and then she joined Atlantic Records, which in September issued "Popstar"; the record could be considered Tinashe's thirteenth release, if we count mixtapes and mini-albums. "Popstar" is a collection of songs that is partly about the twelve collections that preceded it—about, that is, the gruelling process of trying to become a pop star. Tinashe has said that one song, "Empty Stadium," is based on a recurring nightmare about being trapped onstage with no audience and no exit. "I put the work in, and I waited / Don't wanna die underrated," she sings, and there's no telling whether this is part of the same dream, or her wide-awake reaction.

Happily, "Popstar" is a riotously good time, and also, it seems, a self-fulfilling prophecy. It débuted at No. 6 on the *Billboard* album chart, putting Tinashe in the Top Ten for the first time in her long career. On a recent Saturday night, she turned up at Brooklyn Paramount to celebrate, performing a sold-out show for about twenty-eight hundred fans, many of whom seemed as if they had been waiting for this moment even longer than she had. She appeared flanked by four dancers dressed, from the waist up,

as paparazzi: black jackets, flashing cameras, no pants. She was singing the album's titular song, asking, "Tell me, is it everything you thought it'd be?" On the record, the beat drops out, leaving Tinashe alone with stacked echoes of her own voice, which suggest that the answer is no. But for more than an hour in Brooklyn, the crowd left no room for misgivings, hollering loudest for the sassiest lyrics, and whooping every time Tinashe or one of her dancers lifted a leg or dropped a backside. A few days later, she got an endorsement from the Swedish singer Robyn, who incorporated part of "Popstar" into a live performance on BBC Radio 1. Robyn is probably the patron saint of cult-favorite pop stars, a designation that seems much less paradoxical than it once did, thanks to the rise of singers like Tinashe, who appear to thrive in their own cultural galaxies, whether or not they ever cross over into ours.

In 2014, at the dawn of her career, Tinashe told an interviewer that her music was "rooted in a place of R. & B.," and many of her early tracks have beats that are stately and restrained enough to let her carve out memorable vocal lines, enriched by well-chosen harmonies and ad-libs. The song "Nasty," from 2024, marked a commercial resurgence, inspiring millions of TikTok videos, some of which showed users lip-synching the question Tinashe poses: "Is somebody gonna match my freak?" Part of what made the line work was the trancelike way she delivered it, as if she weren't sure what had come over her; eerie keyboards and a ghostly beat echoed the unsettled mood. "No Broke Boys," her other recent hit, pulled off a similar trick, pairing feisty lyrics with incongruously pensive music. Last year, the producer known as Disco Lines remixed it, building a muscular house track around Tinashe's taunting refrain: "No broke boys, no new friends." It became one of the year's biggest dance tracks and has been streamed about a billion times on Spotify—drawing in, no doubt, plenty of listeners who knew nothing about Tinashe's trajectory, even as they were helping to change it.

One of the defining qualities of pop stardom is that it is bigger than music: hit songs help create vivid personas and vice versa, and today it is easier than ever to follow the semiprivate lives of public people. Tinashe, though, is more self-contained. She is poised and polite, offering fans no personal details to match the decadence and drama in her lyrics. During a recent

conversation with Ricky Reed, who served as an executive producer of "Popstar," Tinashe dissected "Nasty" with a music nerd's exactitude. "There was a really interesting moment where we found that juxtaposition between, like, the minor chords and the major chords," she recalled. (Once, when a radio host asked her to name celebrities beginning with the letter "T," she started with Tori Amos, the melodically expansive singer-songwriter.) These days, Tinashe seems to be deëmphasizing R. & B., perhaps in keeping with her ambitions; during a recent interview, she said, "I always saw myself as a pop artist." On the new album, her voice is smaller and the percussion is brawnier than before. She sounds enviably unhurried when she coos, "I know that I'm a superstar," even though the drums are hammering away at around a hundred and thirty-six beats per minute, which is nearly as fast as pop music can get without turning into something else.

Onstage in Brooklyn, Tinashe said almost nothing to the crowd besides "Thank you so much"—confident, perhaps, that the precision of her vocal lines and the prerecorded backing tracks would tell the audience everything it needed to know, and that people would arrive with plenty of their own unhinged energy. Pop stardom is a collaborative project, well suited to the social-media era, and this makes it easier for fans to participate, competing to express their enthusiasm in maximally hyperbolic terms. (When someone on X asked for an example of a historical event so glorious that it could be considered "the Opposite of 9/11," a fan proposed February 6, 1993: the day Tinashe was born.) The crowd at Brooklyn Paramount was full of Black women and gay men, who have long been among Tinashe's most voluble supporters, and when it came time to perform "Melatonin," the new album's raucous highlight, she brought fans onstage for a dance party, with men and women equally eager to twerk for their idol. When the show was over, she headed across the bridge for a d.j. set at a Manhattan night club, but some of the fans stayed put, continuing the dance party out on the sidewalk. For at least a moment, Tinashe's world and the real world seemed like the same place.

How long will stylized, self-conscious pop music remain in vogue? The wave crested in 2024, when Charli XCX—after years of niche fame—conquered the world with "Brat," a brilliant meta-pop opus. Earlier this year, Charli seemed to announce a cultural shift when she released a song

called “Rock Music,” declaring, “I think the dance floor is dead / So now we’re making ro-o-o-ock music,” dragging out the word as if she were stifling a yawn. And yet the pop era has endured. A playfully obnoxious pop auteur named Slayyyter has lately ascended to stardom; she is booked to play Madison Square Garden next summer. And JADE, a former member of the British girl group Little Mix, currently has a delayed-reaction hit with “Angel of My Dreams,” a 2024 song that perfectly evokes a bygone era of bombastic Euro-pop, morphing from a ballad into a dance track and back again. (It was the soundtrack to Kylie Jenner’s star turn at last month’s Victoria’s Secret fashion show.)

It also seems clear that “pop,” always a nebulous term, is evolving. In Mexico, an emerging singer named FLVCKKA (pronounced “flaca”) is using sparkling keyboards and up-tempo rhythms to create addictive hybrids that can sound simultaneously dreamy and streetwise. On her new album, “Hypercorridos Vol. 1,” FLVCKKA marries the giddy sensibility of hyper-pop with the tenacious spirit of Mexican *corridos*, ballads that tend toward the extremes of triumph and tragedy. The record includes “Si No Contestas,” a duet with Marcos Villalobos that is not as playful as it might seem: it turns out that the lovers trading promises also happen to be carrying guns. On the album cover, FLVCKKA is surrounded by scantily dressed friends and heavily armed police officers: a pop star in her own mind, and maybe—with a lot of work and a bit of luck—elsewhere, too. ♦

Kelefa Sanneh has been a staff writer at The New Yorker since 2008. He is the author of “Major Labels: A History of Popular Music in Seven Genres.”

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The Theatre

In “The Heart” and “I Became We,” the Rise of the Hive-Mind Musical

In this new kind of show, an ensemble tells an individual’s story in unison, sometimes down to the thoughts inside her head.

***By** Emily Nussbaum*

November 5, 2026



“The Heart” is a thrilling, thrumming twenty-four-hour countdown to an organ transplant, tracing the path from one person’s tragedy to another’s miracle.Illustration by Carolina Moscoso

The first image in the poignant, propulsive new E.D.M.-pop musical “The Heart,” at the Roundabout’s Laura Pels Theatre, is of a young surfer, Simon (Nick T. Daly), swaying in solitary bliss, like the only dancer left at a club. Behind him, a neon line pulses—it’s an ocean swell, an electrocardiogram, a musical beat. Just nineteen, Simon has slipped out early to catch a predawn wave, but on the drive home he’ll be critically injured in a crash.

And, in a flash, Simon is no longer the show’s protagonist—instead, his heart is. As bright grids fill up screens that frame the stage, the musical—smartly directed by the Roundabout’s new artistic director, Christopher Ashley, with lighting by Amanda Zieve, immersive video design by Lucy Mackinnon, and subtly gliding choreography by Mandy Moore (the auteur

behind Taylor Swift's Eras Tour)—becomes a thrilling, thrumming twenty-four-hour countdown to an organ transplant, tracing the path from one person's tragedy to another's miracle. We meet Simon's powerhouse mother, Marianne (a moving Joaquina Kalukango, belting in denial by her son's bedside); her prickly ex-husband, Sean (Jason Tam); Simon's girlfriend, a d.j. named Juliette (Max McKenna); and also the medical team, including a warm, no-filter nurse (a fab Bre Jackson) and a cocksure surgeon (Drew Gehling, who, after playing doctors in "Waitress" and "Little Shop of Horrors," may qualify for a medical degree). Later, we meet the recipient of Simon's heart, portrayed with rueful glamour by Heidi Blickenstaff. These characters are distinct individuals, but there's a fungibility to the whole enterprise: we meet each of them briefly but intensely, in passing, the way you do in a hospital. The cast juggles minor roles, so a patient might reappear as a doctor; Simon's surfboard becomes an operating table.

The central concept, adapted by Kait Kerrigan from a poetic French novel, could easily go gooey or gimmicky, like a musical episode of "Grey's Anatomy." At first, there's an almost bludgeoning pathos to what we witness, as Marianne resists the news that her son—brain-dead, but still with a beating heart—is gone. But, just as her grief becomes unbearable, a jarring image intervenes. At center stage, a fey stranger appears, warbling in a high operatic voice, with bright-blue gel patches under his eyes and a white towel wrapped around his head, diva style. Only after his phone rings do we learn who this person is: Thomas (Lincoln Klauss), the hospital professional assigned to persuade Marianne and Sean to donate Simon's organs. "They might be divorced?" a colleague tells Thomas, filling him in on the case. "The divorce'll be fun," he responds, tartly.

It's a tonic splash of detachment before Thomas's mask of professionalism slides back up. Some of the production's strongest moments feature this sort of tricky tonal pivot, as when a punkish gamer (a terrific Wren Rivera) is unveiled as the gleeful consultant who selects organ recipients using an algorithm. The show's lyrics are often literal-minded, with rare outliers, such as a wry joke about Juliette becoming "a side piece to his nine-foot slab of fibreglass." But did that blunt sincerity deliver emotionally? It sure did. Before long, my eyes stung; my chest got tight. If the critical part of

my brain sometimes resisted an obvious turn of phrase—“You are my heartbeat,” say—the rest of my body was all in.

There was certainly no resisting the score, an audacious suite of electronic anthems and ballads co-written, with some help from Kerrigan, by the married pop-music wizards Anne and Ian Eisendrath, the latter of whom was an executive music producer for the banger-heavy “KPop Demon Hunters.” Broadway musicals have mined everything from rock and pop to hip-hop and folk. But there’s something bracingly logical about injecting the synthetic jolt of electronic dance music into a hospital environment, where vulnerable bodies are sustained by machines. The score has an exhilarating artificiality, from the breakneck “Keep Up,” which is punctuated by the beeps of hospital monitors, to the kinetic “Strike the Match,” in which layers of slick digital uplift thicken like shellac as the consultant homes in on her match. Any rhythm that repeats becomes fodder—the whoosh of the ocean, the boop-boop of video games. It’s an aural vocabulary that evokes both the cold, invisible workings of neural networks and sticky bodies losing themselves at a rave, united by a heartbeat.

“Was he generous?” is the question that Simon’s parents are forced to answer as they struggle over whether to let the doctors remove their son’s organs. The show itself feels generous, open to feeling as a source of wisdom. As one of the show’s lovelier lines says of surfing—and, implicitly, of nearly everything else in life—“You only get one wave, then you pass it on.” As anyone who has ever been in an emergency room knows, in a crisis some clichés ring true.

There is a ravenousness in midtown right now, after a frustrating few years, for Broadway to get behind some great new musical. Will “Galileo” break through? Lin-Manuel Miranda’s “The Warriors”? “Wanted”? In late October, a hot contender débuted: the London transfer “The Curious Case of Benjamin Button,” which had a celebrated run there. In New York, some critics found it twee, but I adored this small, oddball fable about a man aging backward. The production actually shared a lot with “The Heart,” even though it was scored with Celtic sea chanteys. It, too, is a countdown show obsessed with mortality, a stylized tale in which actors swap roles. It,

too, had a lyrical directness that risked cliché in pursuit of elemental feelings.

But what felt most notable about “Button” was its structure, which, like “The Heart,” featured an ensemble telling an individual’s story in unison—in this case, down to the thoughts inside Benjamin’s head. Both plays are part of a cadre of hive-mind musicals, along with an earlier Ashley-directed project, “Come from Away” (which, like “Button,” has a Celtic-folk score). These shows are explicitly focussed on communities, not individuals—a hospital in “The Heart,” a fishing village in “Benjamin Button,” a rural Canadian town in “Come from Away.” They’re romances about systems, riffing off the choral storytelling of such classics as “A Chorus Line” and “Sweeney Todd” or the clever identity-flipping of “Operation Mincemeat.”

There’s another play in town that employs a similar technique, more austerely: the song cycle “I Became We,” written by Mona Pirnot, with soaringly lovely music by Jack D. Coen. At the Linda Gross Theatre, sixteen singers stand on risers, holding green choral folders. There’s a conductor and a piano. It felt like church until we heard the first line, which was sung as solemnly as Handel’s “Messiah”: “I saw a segment on ‘Jimmy Kimmel Live!’ called ‘What Do You Know About the Female Body?’ ”

What followed was the funny, philosophical narrative of a successful New York playwright in her mid-thirties. She’s got friends to dish with; she adores her mother, a math professor, and her “jumpy and nervous” husband; she is certain that she doesn’t want children. When she goes to a boring party in Brooklyn, a friend passes her a baby, who—as the chorus sings, in joyful, slightly frenzied counterpoint—starts “squirming, squirming!” and “screaming, screaming!” And then there’s a sudden, destabilizing shift in tone: a solo soprano begins singing mournfully, “She’s so small / She’s so small.”

It seems, at first, that this will be a story about fertility—or infertility. But the narrative never goes quite where we expect, its idiosyncratic turns intensified by the singers’ communal delivery, like a catechism or a shared consciousness. Nobody “plays” the narrator; nobody acts out her behavior. They just sing her thoughts, without comment.

Why did this pack such a punch? Maybe it was because of the tension between the elevated harmonies and the down-to-earth words. Maybe it was because the performance framed one person's inner monologue—*It is wonderful to see people love my talented mother! Why am I crying at this Adam Sandler movie?*—as a grand, even sacred project. When the payoff arrived, it reduced the audience to sobs as heavy as any I'd heard at "The Heart." I suspect that we were all thinking about our own lives. It was impossible not to. ♦

Emily Nussbaum, a staff writer at The New Yorker since 2011, is the magazine's theatre critic. Her books include "Cue The Sun!: The Invention of Reality TV."

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The Current Cinema

“Paper Tiger” Views Family as Deadweight

In James Gray’s new crime drama, starring Miles Teller, Scarlett Johansson, and Adam Driver, a Queens couple’s life is turned upside down by a scheme for easy money.

***By** Richard Brody*

November 6, 2026



Driver and Teller play brothers who unwisely sign on as consultants to a sketchy construction project.Illustration by Antoine Maillard

There are no ticking clocks or flipping calendar pages in James Gray’s new film, “Paper Tiger,” but it’s nonetheless a drama of time implacably passing. Call it a September song: the story opens on Labor Day in 1986, in Queens, at the home of the Pearl family. Early in the morning, the jovial, still youthful paterfamilias, Irwin (Miles Teller), has his power tools going in the narrow driveway beside the house, waking his sons—Scott (Gavin Goudey), who’s about to turn eighteen, and Ben (Roman Engel), maybe five years younger—on their last day of summer vacation. As Jerry Lewis’s annual telethon blares from a TV in the kitchen, Irwin and his wife, Hester (Scarlett Johansson), tell the boys that they’re all going to visit Hester’s mother, Iris (Cindy Katz), at a country club near her home, in the prosperous and largely Jewish Long Island suburb of Great Neck.

From this banal beginning, Gray launches a tale of fear and violence, criminal conspiracies and paranoia. That night, after the family gets back home, Irwin's older brother, Gary (Adam Driver), arrives with princely pomp, bringing a takeout feast from the venerable steak house Peter Luger. A former high-ranking cop now earning a grand living as a security consultant—and basking in the admiration of his former N.Y.P.D. colleagues—Gary, who drives a Mercedes and is seemingly sewn into sharply tailored suits, is as dashing as Irwin is staid. The fancy meal is the prelude to a proposition: he wants Irwin, an environmental engineer, to team up with him as a co-consultant to the owners of a grossly polluted site on the Gowanus Canal, in Brooklyn, which is about to undergo a federally funded cleanup. Gary is sure that the job will be lucrative and tells Irwin that the owners, recently arrived Russians whom he describes as scientists and engineers, are in need of Irwin's regulatory and technical expertise.

At a preliminary meeting in Gowanus, little about the prospective clients' rough manner and crude appearance bears out Gary's claims. And a few days later, when the overeager Irwin, following his usual procedure, visits the site to take stock—proudly bringing his sons along to see the world of his work—he finds that he's dealing with gangsters of rare ruthlessness and brutality. By this time, though, he and Gary are in too deep: the gangsters beat Irwin and menace Hester and the boys. To protect the family, Gary goes into heavy debt to the syndicate; the movie's title comes from the description he offers of his gangland creditors to allay Irwin's fears. "I'm N.Y.P.D.," Gary says, adding, "They're not gonna touch me." "But they can touch *me*," Irwin skeptically retorts. As the days until payment is due tick grimly by, Irwin and Hester grow increasingly fretful and angry, and their widening divisions wrench the family apart, to intimately catastrophic effect.

Such lovequakes are a through line of Gray's directorial career, which began in 1994, with "Little Odessa." Gray, one of cinema's great homebodies, grew up in Queens, and most of his movies are set there or in Brooklyn and deal bruisingly with the financial tensions, thwarted dreams, and frayed bonds of middle-class Jewish families like the one in which he was raised—stressed, streetwise, and crime-proximate. His previous film, "Armageddon Time," from 2022—to my mind, his hitherto most

accomplished one—is, like “Paper Tiger,” set in his home neighborhood, Fresh Meadows. That film takes place in 1980, with frequent allusions to Ronald Reagan’s ongoing Presidential campaign, and it focusses on a family very similar to the one in “Paper Tiger”: a father named Irving, who is a contractor; a mother named Esther; and two sons, the younger of whom transfers from public school to a nearby private day school dominated by a wealthy local family—the Trumps.

Gray conceived “Paper Tiger” as a sequel to “Armageddon Time” but altered his plans when the actors who played the parents in the earlier film, Anne Hathaway and Jeremy Strong, were unavailable. The two works remain cognate, but their differences are crucial. Strong’s Irving was tougher, more abrasive than Irwin is; conversely, Hathaway’s Esther, a teacher, was relatively refined and educated, whereas Johansson’s counterpart sleeps with rollers in her hair, like a vestige of the pre-Beatles sixties; speaks in a Queens accent that could cut metal; and holds the family together with her life-worn smarts and iron will. Yet she’s as unworldly as the nerdy Irwin, looking up to him with his fund of “facts and figures.”

But fires of rage burn below the surface of “Paper Tiger,” exemplified in the opening visit to Great Neck. Iris wants Hester and her family to move there; Hester demurs, explaining that college tuition for the boys must come first, but Irwin openly scoffs: “Everyone here was born with a silver spoon in their mouth, or stole one.” Iris, seeing suburban luxury as her daughter’s birthright, thinks that Hester’s marriage has been a comedown. The Pearls aren’t poor, but they’re burdened by expenses and tantalized by comforts just out of reach, especially now that their sons’ heads have been turned by Gary’s flashy success. (Comparing his uncle’s Mercedes with his parents’ cars, Scott whines, “Why do we always have to buy crappy stuff and live crappy?”)

Irwin’s run-in with the Mob dispels the fantasy of easy money; instead, he packs suitcases and makes plans to get the family out of town for their safety. Yet “Paper Tiger” is far more than a tale of criminal violence piercing the domestic bubble. It’s a story of silences, ones that form a conspicuous contrast with its precursor. “Armageddon Time,” with its expressly political context, is a film of rich discourse, filled with rhetorical

expositions of ideology and history, reminiscences and commentaries. In “Paper Tiger,” there’s plenty of talk throughout, but hardly any of it involves cultural context, broader observation, or deeper reflection; it’s not a film of ideas. Instead, the heated dialogue is an expression of the inner life of the family and its time.

Interviews with directors have become a familiar part of movie promotion, but Gray’s interviews are different, often less like conversations than like performances. He’s among the most publicly funny of filmmakers, a gifted impersonator; I’ve long hoped that he would direct a comedy (he hasn’t yet) and appear in it. But his talent for mimicry comes across thrillingly in the dialogue of “Paper Tiger”—Gray wrote the screenplay himself—which adds an extra dimension to the story’s autobiographical elements. Both in ordinary chitchat and in big confrontations, the dialogue plays like a musical score of language built from a trove of memories. The film’s wondrously street-lyrical patter, its emblematic phrases and inflections, amount to a vast act of world-building—a lost milieu brought back to life in bygone clichés.

Much of this evocative talk also proves evasive. Just as Gary’s forecast for the Gowanus venture turns out to have been misleading, the fallout from that calamitous misadventure quickly brings on further elisions and secrets, transforming a happy home and a stable marriage into a curtained stage of furtive designs, hidden agendas, and stealthy exploits. Gary’s Mephistophelian temptations break the façades of business, law, and marriage, revealing the profound and irreparable solitude that lurks beneath life’s fundamental bonds.

Gray has always displayed a probing visual style, boldly confrontational yet painfully tender. In “Paper Tiger,” he refines these tendencies into lapidary images—spare, taut, and precise—that evoke the fierce solidity of the family circle and the fearsome emptiness that’s left when it shatters. With a quietly dazzling repertory of shadows and reflections, fragmented glimpses, truncated vistas, and blocked perspectives, he conjures everything the film keeps hidden, the illusions and limitations that inhere in frank gazes and point-blank views. I’ve seen “Paper Tiger” on the big screen but am looking forward to its streaming release in order to rewatch it as a silent film. Amid

all its chatter, Gray has found the space to let images be eloquent, too. And their eloquence is greatest when expressing the silence and solitude of Hester.

In this regard, Gray's movie resembles a pair of recent classics by Martin Scorsese, "The Irishman" and "Killers of the Flower Moon," both of which feature women who respond to betrayal by men with silences deafening enough to rend the films' finely textured surfaces. In "Paper Tiger," the cycle of tragedy finds its definitive voice in Hester's reproachful silences, which turn out to be radical rejections of the tight little world she inhabits. Determined and relentless, Hester, as incarnated by Johansson, dominates the action and steals the film with a decisive form of passive aggression—one that Gray condenses into a breathtakingly rapid, boldly symbolic special effect. By the time September winds down, Hester is on a timetable all her own, out of synch with her family, detached from its cares, paradoxically and bitterly free. ♦

Richard Brody, a film critic, began writing for The New Yorker in 1999. He is the author of "Everything Is Cinema: The Working Life of Jean-Luc Godard."

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Poems

- **“Vers Libre”**
  By Jane Huffman | “I was being / let down.”
- **“After Rothko”**
  By David Biespiel | “Always there are afternoons, / The empty days, and scaly / Layers of intimate / Footprints, deep / Enough to step into.”

Poems

Vers Libre

***By** Jane Huffman*

November 8, 2026

I waited years to be let down
so hard that I spun,
though I knew those years

what I was being. I was being
let down. I didn’t see it
at the time, but I loosened,

I must have, so was able
to fall, after years of hanging.
I must have, though I can’t

find a metaphor that hangs
loose enough from its referent
in the world to convey it.

Red tick, skin tag, white pet-
al. Hangs loosely
from its referent, then falls.

This is drawn from “Dilemma.”

Jane Huffman is the author of the poetry collections “Public Abstract”(2023) and “Dilemma” (2027).

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Poems

After Rothko

***By** David Biespiel*

November 8, 2026

Always there are afternoons,
The empty days, and scaly
Layers of intimate
Footprints, deep
Enough to step into—
And the hidden meadow
High above the skyline
Under the spent trees
Like the opening of a
Spirit, half in, half
Out, of the clouds,
Smoke ring or
Kismet, or a first kiss.
The old trail of leaves—hundreds
Of miles—like scars, back
Down to the heavy door,
Cannot be seen in this
Dark, when, usually, or
Surely, a swelling
Rain falls over the house.
And, now, here is
One old couple—
They have removed
Their yellow
Layers of clothing—
Her scarf, then blouse—
So as to rest through

The night in the small
Bed, with sore feet,
Bare shoulders—and we
All can feel, I like to think, a
Tingle, a wisp,
Or fever, forever
Marked as love, mouthed
As birdsong. Now, hours
Of sleeping with mouths
Open, when, under the covers,
The acetate-thin skin of her
Forefinger grazes his,
The out-of-the-rain
Window open, a
Breeze, like a blessing,
To nothing. There are
Blue brushstrokes
In the oil painting above the
Pillows. What looks like
Trees have darkened
Into cathedrals. Is it the
Edge of stillness
Or the rivulets of twigs,
White as grace—or
Regarded as grace
Or unwashed as grace—
When something like
The departure of souls
Flutters out of you now,
Even in winter, so
That to yearn, should
We yearn, like children
Yearn, for open skies?
The thought of it is,
Like persuasion, or the
Passage of light,

A thin layer of white
Over white over white.

David Biespiel is the author of "Beautiful Is the World: New and Selected Poems, 1996-2026," among other books.

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Puzzles & Games

- **The Crossword: Wednesday, November 4, 2026**
  By Patrick Berry | A beginner-friendly puzzle.

Crossword

The Crossword: Wednesday, November 4, 2026

A beginner-friendly puzzle.

***By** Patrick Berry*

November 4, 2026

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Patrick Berry has been published puzzles since 1993 and lives in Athens, Georgia.

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